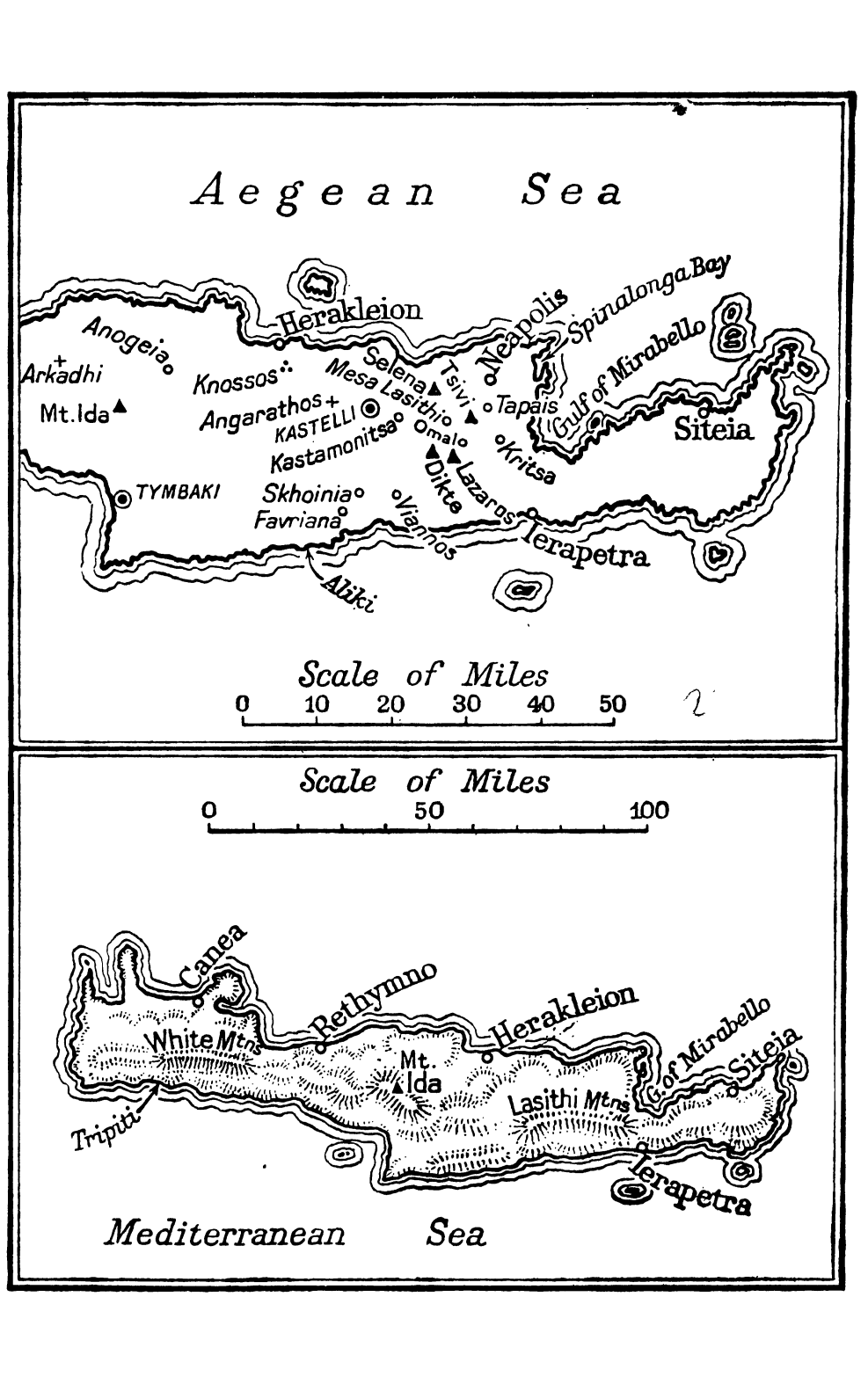

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Mesa Lasithi
Tsivi
Omalo
Dikte
Neapolis
Spinalonga Bay
Tapais
Gulf of Mirabello
Siteia
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Lazaros
TYMBAKI
Skhoinia
Favriana
Viannos
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Canea
Rethymno
Herakleion
White Mts
Mt. Ida
Lasithi Mts
Gulf of Mirabello
Siteia
Tripiti
Ierapetra
Mediterranean Sea

APPOINTMENT IN CRETE

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THE STORY OF A BRITISH AGENT

by

A. M. Rendel

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To
MY WIFE

Chapter One ♣

THE first thing I noticed about Tom Dunbabin, when I met him one evening in Cairo in the spring of 1943, was that he had grown a long and horrible black moustache. One end wound itself with sickly bravado almost into a complete ring, while the other straggled out across his right cheek and turned up into a more diffident but most untidy half circle; during lulls in the conversation he tended to manipulate it in a manner which was really absent-minded, though it looked at times positively girlish. My inclination was to exclaim "My dear Tom, what on earth have you done that for?" but I had not met him for a long time, and although appalled, said nothing.

Tom was an old friend of undergraduate days. We had known each other well before the war, although much of his time had been spent in Greece as an archaeologist. But since the outbreak of war I had seen him only rarely, not in fact since 1941, when he had been working at the War Office in some intelligence job connected with the Albanian campaign. That had seemed natural enough in view of his knowledge of modern Greek, but what was not so easy to understand was that he had apparently been ensconced since then in a staff job in Cairo and yet had a few months before been given a D.S.O. Once in the last year I had received a note from him written in pencil in a spidery hand, "while waiting for someone", as he had said. The letter contained nothing about his work—which did not surprise me—and in fact I had taken no special notice of it at the time. There were plenty of letters being

written just then on a man's knee in the back of a lorry, and I knew Tom's handwriting was atrocious anyway.

We dined at the Auberge du Turf because I had heard that it resembled a French restaurant in Soho—the Jardin des Gourmets—which I had known in peacetime. Tom agreed quietly and gravely that he thought the occasion demanded it, and it certainly was a delightful change from the Iraqi desert, from which I had just come.

I had asked him early on in the evening what his job was. He replied that at the moment he was doing nothing at all. He has always been the hardest of men to draw, and I knew that if I asked him about his D.S.O. I should be up against an almost prickly reticence, but he knew me well, and would not take such prodding in ill part.

"You don't mean to say they gave you a D.S.O. for that?" I asked.

"Oh! I don't know," he said with a suspicion of irritation, as he twiddled the more ragged end of the moustache.

"Well—all right—do you mean that you can't tell me about it or are just being damnably modest and won't?"

I don't remember what he answered, but I had the impression that as well as not wanting to, he wasn't really supposed to talk about it, and for some reason or other, I guessed that he had probably been crawling about behind the German lines at Alamein, as a liaison officer with the Greek brigade.

And there the matter would have ended, if I had not been determined at the time to change my own job. By the spring of 1943 the Paiforce command—which meant Persia and Iraq—had become a dead end. I had already been by then for three and a half years in various soft jobs, and thought it was time that I took any active job that I could get. Later that evening I told Tom that I was

thinking about volunteering for a parachute or commando unit. Tom listened and then said quite unexpectedly, "It's a pity you're in another command, because in some ways you'd be very suitable for the job we're doing."

"Oh!—but I expect I can get a transfer, though it's always horribly slow."

"I don't know that you can. Our administrative people won't make very much effort at this end to get you from another command."

"Anyway, I could try—but I don't know very much about the job yet."

"Well I'd better tell you something more about it. We go with parties of Greeks in and out of Greece dressed up as civilians."

"Oh!"

There was a pause. Doing a job in civilian clothes was a new idea and a shock. Somehow scrambling about at night with commandos seemed at that moment infinitely preferable to the chance of being caught as a spy. I felt very frightened indeed. Someone had once told me that when our agents were trying before the war to get information on the expansion of the Luftwaffe, the Germans had a habit of cutting off the right hand of anyone they caught, with a wooden axe.

But I should have been much too ashamed just then to tell Tom that I wouldn't do it. "I supposed you had been doing some sort of intelligence job," I said, "but I never thought that you were actually in Greece in civvies."

"It isn't Greece actually; it's Crete."

"But Tom, if you go in plain clothes, you're a spy."

"Spy is an ugly word. It's not the same thing as the secret service. Actually you keep your commission and do what they call a paramilitary course, and it isn't intelligence mainly, though we do that too."

"What are you doing mainly?"

"We organise the fifth column."

"Well, I don't want to quibble about a word; perhaps spy should only really be used for those who spy on their own country, but if you're in plain clothes, you're in fact spying."

"If you're caught, you're shot." I remember looking hard at Tom just then, and was disconcerted to find he was looking very hard at me. After that I don't remember how the conversation went, but I do remember asking how long he had been on the other side, and being aghast when he said "Nine months."

Later I asked him more about the work and felt somewhat reassured. They had had no casualties at all and it appeared that the Germans seldom came to look for them.

"But how do you get on for food, Tom?" I asked.

"You live on the country."

"But I thought they were all starving anyway."

"They give you anything they've got, and you get enough."

"Well what do you mean by that? Do you go hungry once a week, or once a day, or what?"

"I never went hungry at all, except when I wanted to get somewhere."

"You mean you made a long march and missed out meals on the way?"

"Yes, possibly for a day."

I was encouraged by that. "I suppose there's plenty of water?" I asked.

"Yes—most of the year. You have to be near a spring and in autumn a good many dry up, but water is no real difficulty."

"Well, I suppose you have to see people, and however well you speak Greek, the Greeks must know. How do you move about?"

"I never went anywhere without a guide."

"And I suppose he did all the talking on the way."

"Yes, but one of the difficulties is that they're very bad indeed at keeping a secret. You just can't trust anybody about that, and they're so proud to be going about with an officer, that lots of people get to know."

"Do you mean a dozen or fifty or hundreds?"

"Hundreds, but I never stopped more than one night in a village if I could help it. It doesn't matter so much if people get to know that you've passed by, but the thing that you must keep secret is your wireless set. The operator has to lie very low."

"And I suppose you move the headquarters when you think too many people have got to know about it."

"Yes, more or less."

"How often did you move? About once a month?"

"Yes, about that. It depends, some places are safer than others. We had one cave within a quarter of a mile from a village and the operator was there for three months but they never found it."

"Do you ever wash?" I asked him.

"No. There isn't much chance of washing normally, and you don't feel much inclined to in the cold weather. *They* never do."

"You mean you often wanted to ask for a bath but didn't like to appear upstage and county about it?"

"Well, yes, really."

"Didn't you get covered in lice?"

"Yes, sometimes."

There was a pause, and then Tom said with a scowl as if he had been contemplating lice objectively at some distance.

"I don't like lice."

I could see that he was getting annoyed and I felt too that he was bored by the whole thing. It was not that he was evasive, but his thoughts and mine seemed to be miles

and miles apart. We were sitting at the same table and yet it almost seemed as though I were talking to someone on the long-distance telephone—someone who at times wanted to get off the line. I can understand it now, having seen men step from the everyday habits of an officers' mess and within a week or two take without difficulty to what was virtually the life of a vagabond peasant.

But I think there was another reason that night to make Tom seem pretty short—something like the feeling of unreality a man gets when he comes out of prison. A British sergeant who had been eight months in a German prison in Crete and constantly under threat of execution, told me two days after he was released that he could scarcely believe he was really out of prison at all.

About Tom just then there was, I think, something of the same feeling. He had been for ten months in Crete and, though I did not know it then, he had only come out a few weeks before I met him. When I came out myself later after a much less dangerous spell, I felt something of the same strangeness. You got accustomed in the back of your mind to being an outlaw—a person at least, who although going about openly, was yet outside the ordinary processes of society, with a false name and a false appearance, and a real purpose that was different from the apparent one, and then suddenly you came out and found yourself in a world which was openly friendly and for that reason wholly strange. So it was not unnatural after coming out for you to slip away into your own thoughts. It was there that you had been accustomed to find what was genuine about your existence, and after that ordinary society seemed at times wrongheaded, and always flat. Sometimes you would drift entirely into your own recollections, and then rouse yourself from them as from some intense dream—not sure at first if the dream were reality and your present waking a dream. So I think that on that first evening when

we discussed the life, when at times Tom appeared suddenly lost in a reverie he was really suffering—though that is perhaps too strong a word—from the reaction of having led too long a solitary and risky existence.

He told me that the feeling of being cut off was about the worst part of the life. Mail depended on boats and boats depended on weather and on the enemy—but would be more frequent now that the Alamein battle was over. For nine months when the Germans were at Tobruk, it had been impossible to send or receive letters. Tom and the two other officers who had been in Crete then had held a meeting to decide what to do if Cairo fell. They believed it would fall and in that case they would have been out of wireless touch with headquarters. I asked what they would have done.

"Oh, we should have done something of course!"

(Another tug at the moustache).

In future however there might be a boat every two months or so. Tom told me too that much the worst moments were when he was actually deciding to go in and again when the boat turned round and left him on the shore.

I wanted to know how much contact Tom had actually had with the Germans. He was disturbingly vague about this, but I was encouraged when I asked how many times he had had to pass a German sentry, and he began counting on his fingers. He admitted, however, that when making a sketch of Tymbaki aerodrome from the top of a tree he had found his perch acutely uncomfortable.

I asked how it was that the Germans didn't surround an area and then work through it, and he said that long before they could get into position, some eager little guide from a neighbouring village would come running up to his headquarters with the news that the Germans were on

the way. There were apparently only two dangers—one, that someone might give the party away—the other, that Germans might bump into you by chance. He added that to his mind, it was not a particularly dangerous job and repeated that up to date we had had no casualties.

I think that all the time I was probing for some reason why I should not be able to do the job myself, and yet the more I thought of it, the more strange and also exhilarating it all seemed. In the general course of the war the work was only a sideline, and Tom had been at pains to emphasise that one could not expect G.H.Q. to be much interested in it. Yet he had told me that he had brought back with him an "enormous amount of information" including sketches and maps, and though the fifth column work might or might not be useful—that depended upon whether or not the allies invaded Crete—in any case, he let out, one was doing a "splendid job", because it cheered the resisting Greeks enormously to know that there were still British officers working among them. From what I had heard there could be no doubt that the job was well worth doing, but like many people who have questioned me since then, I imagined at the time a life of cold and want and nervous misery. When Tom told me that one of the officers who had been in for over a year did not come out for a holiday, because he was enjoying it, I believed him, but it only made me feel that this particular officer—it was Paddy Leigh-Fermor, of whom more later—must be a person entirely different in make-up from myself. What I should never have believed was that I should enjoy the life myself, and yet I think that without exception all the British who took part in it, found it the most exhilarating work they had ever done.

There was about the resistance movement everywhere, I suppose, the feeling that men were, if not at close grips with the occupying forces, then at least in the midst of

them, and in fact we saw daily evidence of the ruthlessness and beastliness of the war. The men too who worked with us—though they came from many motives—if they stayed, did so because by and large they were honest patriots. The work was done and could only have been done well by volunteers, and thinking of the best of my immediate helpers I have no hope or wish ever to work again with better men or women. All this perhaps was true of the work in many other countries, but there were factors peculiar to Greece. It is sentimental and unreal to labour the connexion between ancient Greece and the love of independence of modern Greeks. Most Greeks have, it is true, learnt of the great moments of their ancient past, as stories told to school-children, and men fighting in Albania were proud to be compared to the Spartans at Thermopylae, but the country is too poor for many of them to have had the chance to study the history or philosophy of ancient Athens. And yet there is much about the country today that is directly akin to ancient Greece. No people has ever been more individualistic. Good, even great, leaders there have been, yet no country remains more difficult to govern. A village cut off from its neighbour by a shoulder of mountain or an arm of the sea will choose its politics largely from the urgent desire to be unlike the village nearest to it. No people has ever been more litigious, more lively, or above all more devoted to pulling its own leg. These qualities all date from ancient days; moreover they are emphatically not German, and when they were suddenly subjected to the full functioning of a Nazi system, resistance became a personal and passionate emotion.

There was also the tradition of the struggle for independence against the Turks. This is more real to modern Greeks than ancient history and even in this war the creeks used by gun runners and the caves used by rebels

in Turkish days were pointed out time and again and used once more. And about modern Greek history there was also the wholly exceptional and for the British providential fact that no country had in the past 130 years felt more grateful to another than Greece has felt to Britain. The Greeks might think that we were with them because our own country was in danger, but at least as a people we had always understood their struggle for freedom.

I should, perhaps, have written this at the end of my book. What I am going to describe was not ultimately of any real importance in the winning of the war, but it seemed at the time and still seems real to the point of intensity and romantic to the point of melodrama.

I do not regret that a few days later I decided to get posted to Tom's unit by hook or by crook.

Chapter Two ♣

THE following weeks were spent in determined efforts to get transferred to a division of the Middle East Headquarters known as M.O.4. As a first step I composed a long and, as I thought, cogent letter to the artillery commander in Paiforce, pointing out my great suitability for sabotage in the Balkans. This was a fine example of making bricks without straw. The only facts to support my case were a one-time ability to read ancient Greek, a five weeks' acquaintance with parts of mainland Greece on a walking tour twelve years before, a number of other walking tours abroad, and a most rudimentary knowledge of Balkan history acquired over ten years previously. However, this, coupled with other even less relevant qualifications, was woven into a document proving forcefully—I like to think—that it would be nothing less than criminal disregard of the war effort in general, if the artillery command refused to relinquish a widely travelled and toughened, practically Greek-speaking, officer, schooled in current Balkan politics, for a special highly skilled assignment, in which just these qualities (so rarely combined) were desperately required. Whatever real impression this letter made on the artillery commander, it was at least successful, and I obtained with unflattering but agreeable readiness an assurance that my own artillery command would "raise no objection" to my being transferred. I was posted to M.O.4 in the middle of May.

We lived at a mess in Heliopolis. This was good training because there was no privacy whatsoever; my main

recollection is of an excited babble of Greek going on all round, which I could not at that time understand.

I learnt the routine of my section of M.O.4 which was housed in a large modern building called Rustum House. This was a lively change from other military staff posts, being full of self-confident looking officers wearing parachute wings, and even fuller of extremely decorative personal assistants, looking as if they had arrived direct from a morning in pre-war Bond Street. All the same the summer climate and the lotus-eating life of Cairo, made me feel disgustingly sybaritic, and, in the midst of total war, glad to leave for Palestine for a training course in "resistance warfare".

The training consisted mainly of demolitions, P.T., and enemy weapons. Tom had already told me that this would mostly be useful, so I took it all with enormous seriousness. "Demolitions" is, of course, a subject which anyone with an ounce of the schoolboy left in him is bound to enjoy. We strapped sticks of cordite on to steel girders with adhesive tape, and then lit a fuse and scampered away behind a hillock or into a sort of air raid shelter until the bang. However, this part of the training being largely aimed at railway sabotage, seemed particularly inappropriate. There are no railways in Crete.

We also did a number of field exercises. For these the practice was to work with a man going to your own area. I was lucky, for I soon spotted a New Zealand N.C.O., Corporal Perkins, who was taking the whole course, like myself, with great seriousness. On the march he looked like a fox-terrier quivering with eagerness. He had just the experience I wanted, for he had fought with the New Zealanders in Crete, and only escaped from it after five months of wandering from district to district with another New Zealander in search of a boat. He had been chased about by the Germans, and lived off the country, without more than a word or two of Greek. He was determined to

go back, and absolutely steady about any hazards there might be. Having plenty of doubts about it myself, I found it a help to be with someone whose conversation let slip little details about the life. How good the Cretans were to you. How one old man, whom he meant to see again, could always be relied on to give you a meal of potatoes even though he was desperately poor himself. How you could usually find potatoes to dig up. I looked pretty hard at Perkins at this point. He was such a virtuous young man, and it gave me a sudden odd glimpse of the makeshift life to think of him stealing potatoes from his allies in the dark.

After the camp at Haifa, I was sent to the Vale of Megiddo to another training establishment and then I returned to Cairo to prepare for an expedition to Crete, on which I was to go as "conducting officer". This meant that we took into Crete supplies for one of the officers who was already there, and also had to help fit out anyone else who was going in to stay. The supplies were usually clothes, arms, ammunition, and food. The men going in this time were Perkins and a Cretan boy called George Psychoundakis. Perkins, of course, knew the ropes and looked after himself, but George, whose spirits were irrepressible, not merely looked after himself but would gladly have played some enormous prank to get rid of the quartermaster, and pillage the stores. I soon got to like George. He was a good example of the intelligent independent tough type of Greek mountaineer. At that time he was about nineteen. He had nine or ten younger brothers and sisters, and himself had been, until recently, in charge of the family's sheep—a hard life which means a constant watch to defend your own flock from your neighbours. Sheep steeling is endemic in the Greek mountains—as popular a pastime as it was no doubt two or three centuries ago in the Highlands.

George had only been to a village school, but was quick and eager to learn anything, whether it was the mechanism of a pistol, a foreign language, or conditions of life in the fleshpots of Cairo. Before the war he had never been further from his native village of Asygonia than to the county town of Rethymno, but during the battle of Crete he had come down to fight the German parachutists at Rethymno, and his flocks were stolen by locals or removed by the Germans about this time. The following months must have been hard, but by the spring of 1942 he had come in touch with the first British missions to return to Crete, and was acting as a runner between wireless sets in the Canea and Rethymno districts. He was always determined to complete his journeys in the shortest possible time. Twice he was known to have fainted on the way, but his spirits had been an enormous asset to the morale of any party with which he worked. Certainly there was no regret on George's part about returning. He liked the life of "resistance", although his time in Cairo and Palestine must have opened up to him new and undreamt-of vistas.

We had a hot and nasty few days in Cairo. I did my best to buy or cadge a really good consignment of stores, and the office were amused when I produced a much greater variety of tinned food than usual, including asparagus. They wired this news to Xan Fielding, the officer who was to receive it, and got an answering telegram, "What about the salad dressing?"

Looking back on this time, I see now how ludicrous it was to bother about the details when provisioning anyone. In the first place a fair proportion of the stores never got there; for instance later, when I had supplies dropped by parachute, we actually collected only half the canisters, the rest going to alert local shepherds or to the Germans. In the second place we got so entirely accustomed to

local diet that anything in the nature of a "treat" just seemed out of place, when consumed from a mess tin or on the end of a Cretan knife.

When we reached Derna, we had to wait about three weeks, living in the harbour on the motor launch which was to take us to Crete. Three times we set off and turned back because of heavy weather, and once we were half way across when we sighted a lone German bomber. It was my first view of an enemy in daylight. It took a wide circle round us and we waited for the attack. The Motor Launches (M.L.s) were small boats with a complement of about fifteen men. As the bomber came astern of us I remember looking down the line of the ship. We were crouching mostly near the wheelhouse, each with a machine gun of sorts. There was an Oerlikon and an antiquated anti-submarine two-pounder, all pointing at the plane, but what struck me was the line of weapons and more than that the faces (and several beards among them). It was like the picture of some sea battle, with seamen crouching ready to board. As the plane went on circling, I remember feeling excitement and uncertainty, rather than fear, and half hoping that it would come nearer, and we would blaze away.

But this time there was to be no sequel. Evidently the plane thought we were an unimportant and thorny target, for it sheered off, and we, having turned tail, as soon as we sighted it, beat a retreat to Derna with undignified haste.

It was necessary to make these crossings to Crete without a moon, and as we had now missed the moonless part of the month we had to wait again, and were transferred to a new M.L., which had done the run many times. The commander was a Canadian, Lt. Bob Young.

We were soon away again. I was given a type of machine gun which I had not handled before. As we left harbour, the crew had a practice shoot, and were too busy to be able

to instruct me, and afterwards I did not bother anyone about it. I had set out so often by then without anything happening that it really seemed fussy to bother, though this state of mind was one which I had often had to combat with men in training and I was soon to regret it sadly myself.

The voyage to Crete was uneventful—a day far too lovely to think of war. The M.L. drove along stoutly over the calm of the Mediterranean, as blue and glorious as you could dream of.

All day the sunlight sparkled on the water and then gradually the evening burnt itself out in a coppery glow along the horizon, and before the light failed, Bob Young called me to the bridge, and pointed to a dim shadow well above the line of the sea. It was the crest of the White Mountains in West Crete, just visible in the sunset. It looked cold and distant, and I wondered silently and lugubriously to myself, if before the war ended, my bones would be lying up there for good.

The twilight faded, and on our right we passed the black shadow of Gavdos Island. It had a small German garrison, but there was no chance of their spotting the ship at that hour, although a seaplane might pick out the flash of foam in our wake.

There was nothing now to do for an hour or so. Part of the time I wrote a letter home. Even though I wasn't going to stay ashore, I thought that we might run into trouble. I always wrote plenty of letters, and that ultimately had one admirable effect on the work, as it convinced the Greek guides that I was eager—as we all were—for news from home. This appealed to them much more than any insistance that messages from a boat should be brought to one immediately. It was normally too much to expect that any ordinary Greek runner would make the journey without stopping at villages on the way, to explain the

importance of his mission—but when guides had letters for me they would sometimes hurry, so that incidentally I got messages from the headquarters quickly too. One young Greek, an eager, generous, and patriotic soul, called—quite unsuitably, I thought—after that staid old Greek statesman, Kimon, came once from a boat to my headquarters with great despatch—and proud of it—and presented a nice fat bundle of personal letters, well before he remembered to hand over two hundred sovereigns and instructions from Cairo.

As we neared the coast of Crete that first night the darkness became almost complete; the outlines of the mountains could no longer be seen, but you felt they were there. The night was all the darker because of them. At the part of the coast where I first landed, they rise steeply six to eight thousand feet straight from the sea's edge. I knew that there were German posts on either side of our landfall. The evening breeze died. For the last mile or so the engine was throttled down. The low chugging of it, and the whispering of the wash on the calm water was all that you could hear. Occasionally Bob Young's voice gave a short order to the engine room. By now we were within a few hundred yards of shore, and anyone who could be, was on deck watching for the signalling light. The land party were to signal two morse letters with a torch. Then suddenly two or three of us saw it at once—a white gleam that seemed well above us, and began to wink and blink, while we spelt out the letters in quick stage whispers. There followed an hour or so that might have been taken straight from Conrad. Even at the time I was conscious of the contrast between my own conventional past—tea on a lawn in pre-war summers at Hindhead, bowls in the college garden after hall at Oxford, the books and arm-chairs and household gods of a flat in London—and the knowledge that I was about to put off in a dinghy with

a tommy gun in one hand, orders in a sealskin cover (in case they fell in the water), some nasty sulphur-coloured pills (to put people to sleep), some even nastier grey rubber-covered pills to finish off oneself in case of need and eighteen sacks of food, clothes, boots, ammunition and explosives for a party of outlaws, who would depend in large part on that solid heavy lump that was pressing against me in my haversack, reminding me weightily but comfortingly that I had got in my charge a bag full of gold.

The M.L. glided in to within some thirty yards. It was just 1 a.m. Bob Young had made his landfall dead right. The light had gone out and reappeared nearer the water and finally at the water's edge. The lieutenant lowered the dinghy, and we pulled in. I thought we were going to a rocky ledge at the end of the creek, but when we got there we found ourselves in a cave.

Even from the boat we could hear the Greek party. On such occasions there was always the happiest excitement. They had been waiting probably for hours, and when the boat arrived—after three previous attempts—their pent-up spirits broke into sheer delight. The cave was a complete parody of the setting for a smugglers' chorus. It was lit at one end with a fire of dried furze which rose and fell, casting vast ogrelike shadows or suddenly illuminating a pirate profile, and on the ledge beside the water stood some dozen Cretans. To say that they stood is, however, an understatement. More properly they quivered, jumped, waved and welcomed with a variety of instructions to themselves, each other, and the boat. They were clad in many and diverse theatrical garments, having mostly black sarikis (a small square handkerchief with little tassels) wound round their heads, black shirts, shepherds' breeches with pouched baggy knees (a cross between riding breeches and plus fours), and leather

gaiters or jack boots with strips of motor tyres on the sole (excellent for climbing mountains but maddeningly slippery on wet rocks). They usually carried woollen braided knapsacks, known as sakkoulis, with designs in bright yellows and scarlets, which often showed the village from which they came. Most of them had a holster attached to a leather belt, or a bandolier, with tommy gun ammunition, or a purple sash, wound round their middles like a cummerbund, with the hilt of a long Cretan knife sticking out of it. They looked, I suppose, much as their fathers and grandfathers had looked in the guerilla bands, which had struggled for independance against the Turks. Indeed an old shepherd at a little bay which I later reconnoitred, recommended it to me as a place which had regularly been used for gun running in Turkish days.

Their ejaculations in demotic Greek meant nothing to us except that we were highly welcome, but as the dinghy neared the ledge of the cave, a voice from one of the rebel chorus broke through the din to tell us in perfect English accents, how to bring in the boat. Hearing an educated English voice just then, was as if one had gone up to a shaggy pony and been greeted with human speech, or bumped into a gipsy on Derby day, and discovered that he was a member of the royal family incognito. In any case at the moment only the ludicrousness of the sound tempered for me my own excited relief, for somewhere among that tatterdemalian reception party was clearly Xan Fielding, the liaison officer whom I had to see. Xan had been leading a Cretan party since the end of 1941. I knew him only from his reports, which were fruity, flippant, and bloodthirsty. Already he was violently at loggerheads with the local leftwing Greek resisters in his neighbourhood, who were hoping, with arms from him, to install a communist régime.

I got out of the dinghy clumsily, as I was gripping the haversack with the sovereigns under one elbow as I stood up, and it made balancing difficult. I thought then that I must be particularly secretive about the gold, and that only Xan should know it had come, but later with the men one could trust I was always open about it, though I naturally did not leave it about. Normally I carried about twenty sovereigns in a pocket stitched inside a thick belt, but sometimes I had to carry larger quantities from one hideout to another. By the time I had shaken hands with Xan, Perkins was being excitedly welcomed, and the party began towing the ship's boat backwards and forwards along a rope brought in the dinghy.

Xan was in excellent spirits, and wanted to know whom I had brought, the stores, and as much as anything else, news of Cairo. I gave him the gold first. I think he was amused at the hush-hush manner in which I handled it. I had also messages and congratulations from headquarters. He gave me a packet of reports and letters. When I asked where the Germans were, he replied airily that the post west of us would certainly have heard us arrive, but were too scared to move. He added that they would come along the coast in the morning, but by then his party would have hidden the stores. They were going to drag them through a hole in the roof of the cave, and bury them among the rocks on the mountain. Xan also told me that on the last occasion when we had tried to come a seaplane had patrolled the coast in the evening and two caiques manned by Germans had passed up it after dark, and again about 10 p.m. before our arrival that night two caiques had passed up the coast some way out. This certainly meant that we had been reported on the previous occasion and possibly again now, but the general atmosphere of confidence and gaiety made it impossible to regard this particular operation as part of any dark

tense struggle. It seemed much more—and to me, then, rather shockingly—like a practical joke played on the Germans in fancy dress. But that was in fact the best way to look at it. Xan I think enjoyed, too, flashes of grimness. He had had, I knew, to shoot a traitor himself. He told me that the Germans were buying over "large numbers" of traitors. Actually elsewhere in the island German sympathisers were all well known and shunned accordingly, but Xan had far more anxiety than anyone else from German counter-espionage, which was better organised and concealed in his district. Not that it seriously perturbed him. I suspect that that evening he was wondering what sort of an ass it was who had come from headquarters bringing him tins of asparagus.

When the stores were all ashore, Xan suddenly remembered to ask for water. They had had a long climb down to the cave and there were no springs near by, so he hoped to replenish flasks from the boat. This was the sort of detail that often went wrong. I went back to the boat, but found Bob Young rightly determined to wait no longer, now that the stores were ashore.

Soon we were gliding out to sea, and the outline of the mountains was discernible again. Much to my surprise I was sorry not to be staying with the land party. It would, in fact, just then have been much safer to do so, but I could not know it at the time and went restlessly below. Besides Bob Young there were two naval officers on board. Two of the three were bedding down to get what sleep they could. They knew that next morning was for the boat the real zero hour. I thought of writing a diary of the meeting with Xan, but felt lazy about it and turned in too. Perhaps it was just as well to lie down. The next day was to be a long one. I remember being too excited to sleep, for I was still delightedly recollecting the light in the cave and on the water, and

the weapons being handed ashore. Also I kept thinking again of George and Perkins—George chuckling as he scrambled out of the dinghy to be kissed by the pirate crew on his very youthful curly black moustache, which vied for him as a source of cheerful vanity with the heavy German Mauser at his side—Perkins, reliable and imperturbable amid the excitement, still reminding one, in his breeches and old jacket, of the open air life of camping days near his native Christchurch—and lying in the darkness of the cabin I yet kept seeing clearly again the dark keen features of Xan, talking in one breath in accents of Charterhouse about fellow-officers and girl friends in Cairo and traitors in Canea, and turning to curse in voluble demotic Greek an over-eager bandit as the stores were lugged in, while the little black tassels on his bandero danced with momentary anger. With such curious contrasted images of life in the resistance crowding in my mind, I fell fast asleep.

Chapter Three ♣

THREE or four hours later, with a feeling like lifting a punt out of mud, I dragged myself from a deep sleep, with a feeling that something was wrong. Somewhere an ugly, noisy, and above all dismally sustained sound seemed purposely to be making slumber impossible. With disgust and growing fear I recognised it as the ship's alarm. One of the naval officers was already pulling on his boots. We had been sleeping with most of our clothes on, and in a few seconds we were gazing into the horizon.

The sun was not yet up. It was the hour of first light, when the sea haze was rising. The horizon had already lost the rosiness of dawn and was now a misty white; to put it more prosaically, visibility was poor. Up above the sky was clear and pale blue with the promise of warm sun and deeper blues to follow—a day in fact when simply to be there and to be alive should have been fun. But there was no time to maunder about that. The lookout had sighted a plane. I heard someone say "to port", and began trying in landlubber fashion to decide which side port was, though in fact everyone was looking in one direction. After a few seconds which seemed, of course, far longer, I saw a solitary two-engined plane coming up fast, but likely to pass us wide on a flank. The lookout thought it must be a German raider, and we had no reason to think that any allied plane would be there. It flew straight on and did not seem to have observed us, and soon it was abreast of us. I could not judge distances at sea, but it must have been at least two or three miles off. At that range we could not be sure what it was, though several of us tried

with the ship's glasses. I had had aircraft recognition training and thought myself that it was more like a British Beaufighter than anything else, and the episode ended in gradually increasing bathos, as the plane drew away ahead of us and finally dropped over the horizon.

I went below again, but the knowledge that we were still well within range of German planes, and that this was the hour to expect them, made it seem ridiculous to lie down to sleep. The momentary fear of attack had, in fact, made me very wide awake.

Suddenly the alarm began screeching again. There was really no need for more than a single blast this time. The gunners were already at their stations. As I jumped up the companion-ladder I heard someone call out, "That's them all right", and there astern I quickly made out three float planes. They were German Arado 196 Seaplanes, no doubt from the seaplane base at Canea. The floats made them look like rather stubby ducks with long webbed feet about to alight. In the recognition silhouettes I had always thought them the ugliest of planes. Now they seemed to hover, in V-formation, and then one after another they drew out in a wide arc about the boat. They were having a preliminary scout around us, and perhaps hoping to come in down the sun, which had now risen, but was not yet high above the water. It is of course difficult to aim with the sun in your eyes, so Bob Young had turned the boat eastwards into the sun, as the attack was likely to come along the line of the boat from astern.

The planes circled, and when astern the leader turned sharply. Someone called out, "Here he comes", and with a sort of mental gulp I realised that the attack was really starting. I had never been under fire before, but to describe one's emotions for the benefit of those who may still have that experience before them and dread it, is difficult, because the next ten or fifteen minutes passed

with such violent swiftness, that I had no time consciously to be aware of my emotions. Looking back on it, I felt, I believe, a mixture of dread and anger, with the dread predominating. People are often afraid of fear, as I was, thinking that it will make them lose their heads. Actually, unless you are driven crazy with shelling, I should say that fear, which certainly quickens your reactions, probably helps people in an emergency to keep their heads, whereas anger may not.

On this occasion at any rate the instinct of self-preservation could lead to one course only—to hit back. Together with the aircraft recognition training I had also had training in firing at a trailer drawn by an aircraft, and knew that one had to fire 12 degrees in front of the target. It was of course absurd to think that in action anyone would measure off degrees by sticking out an arm and judging them across the back of the knuckles, but I knew roughly what the angle would look like and that I would have to judge from the flight of the tracer bullets; every third bullet in my gun was a tracer. The other guns were armed with some tracers too, and the enemy would have, we knew, no idea of our armament, for this particular motor launch was fitted for just this type of action, more heavily than the ordinary submarine searchers. It had two quick-firing, anti-aircraft or anti-submarine guns, which fired a burst of four slim shells about 18 inches long. There were also two heavy anti-aircraft double-machine guns, and there must have been three or four Lewis or light machine guns on board in addition. The full complement was fourteen men, and the ship was carrying one naval officer above its normal establishment. Fortunately I was the only passenger—fortunately because often on other runs the boat had to bring back fifty or sixty Greek refugees or recruits for the Greek forces in the Middle East. It would have been impossible to keep or even house

them all below, and if the deck had been crowded with human beings, there would certainly have followed a terrible and bloody havoc.

The leading plane straightened out and came sweeping towards us down the line of the ship. At that moment we seemed to sway a little. The boat was being turned to throw the plane off the line, and to give the forward guns, which would otherwise have been masked by the bridge, a clear field of fire. I remember hoping that the gunners would hold their fire, as I knew that the chance of hitting an aeroplane at speed is much increased at short range. There is, too, a great temptation to fire too soon if much of your body is exposed. There was certainly much temptation to loose off a burst before the plane opened on the gunners, but in fact the first plane was well within range when everything seemed to start at once. I saw the first tracer from the stern gun go sailing off towards the plane. It was close, but I didn't think that that particular shell could have hit; the three other shells in the burst must have been close to the tracer, but if any of them hit, I realised with dismay that they had made no visible impression on the plane. Before I could think anything else, the machine guns were stuttering and sputtering, the plane swept down about 50 feet above the water and perhaps 50 yards to port, and the general din of the machine guns was drowned in the droning and then the sudden roar of the engine, as it tore past. I had been stationed above the wheelhouse, which masked my body as the plane came on, and from there I could see in relative security that I had a wonderful target, and aimed carefully and well in front. Then I pressed the trigger. Nothing happened. There was a nasty little click, as though the gun had not been loaded, but I knew from the weight of the magazine that it was. The first rule, if you had a misfire, was to cock the gun and fire again. I had missed my best chance, but the plane was

sheering off, and as it wheeled to give the rear gunner a shot at us I had another good target and fired again. Again nothing happened. The other two planes came sweeping over us and swung off in different directions with a spatter of bullets from their rear gunners. At one moment there seemed to be planes roaring round the boat, whichever way you looked, with the ship's tracer bullets flying all round them. The planes were firing cannon shells too, and might well have holed us badly or put the engine out of action, but I was not aware of that till later. Then there was a moment or two of pause, while they reformed astern. The gunner and loader on the forward gun next to me were unhit and the gun still in action. The gunners were busy reloading, and this was clearly no time to ask one of the officers on the bridge to look at my weapon. I thumped the magazine, cocked and fired trial shots, but although the gun seemed in perfect order, it was no good. I found later that for safety two blank clips had been left in the magazine instead of one, which in practice meant that the gun did not load and reload itself, when cocked and fired. Had I had a practice shoot the day before, this would have been discovered at once. Though I have never particularly wanted to have anyone's blood on my hands, I have never really ceased to regret that I did not take part in the firing and bring down a plane.

The planes were back again, though this time I don't think they came so close. I cowered in front of the wheelhouse as the din broke out, holding up the gun more as an enraged threat than because I felt it could do any good, and heard again only the miserable click of the trigger in reply as the planes passed beside us.

During the second run one of the planes turned across our bows with its rear guns firing at the forward gun near myself. It shot low and I saw the line of splashes scudding over the water towards us. That part of the burst, which

was going to hit the ship, seemed on a line that would pass between myself and the forward gun. It showed that there were plenty of enemy bullets flying about somewhere in the air around us, and the thought that someone on that ugly enemy plane was trying to kill us—and might—made me feel anger and a personal urge to strike down the gunner, fiercer than any emotion which I had ever felt before. It seems curious to be writing this now from the depths of an armchair with my wife sewing quietly at the other side of the fireplace.

I don't think that there was any pause after the second attack. The leader seemed to come straight back firing all the way, but I thought some of our own machine gun fire was probably hitting him. Then there was a cry from the forward gun. The loader was wounded. He couldn't stand and do his job, but could hobble. I tried to help him, and somehow he got himself into shelter, I think into the wheelhouse. Then I went to the gun, feeling a good deal more exposed there, but also relieved that I could do something useful at last. The gunner had a clip loaded and showed me how to hold the next one ready. He was a good gunner I knew, but I remember that like children with a toy I would have liked to do the actual firing myself. We had just time to look astern for the next plane, when someone called out, "They're breaking off!" It was true. There they were, all three scudding every moment further and further into the distance though one of them seemed to be lagging. I think most of us probably felt the overwhelming relief of it and yet a pang of regret too. If only they had given us one more chance, perhaps we could have smashed them into the sea.

It was only as they flew off that I began to realise what they had done to us. It might have been much worse, but of the sixteen men aboard eight were wounded. Bob Young himself, looking as quiet as before, but older and

grimmer, had been struck by a splinter above the left eye. It wasn't deep but had caused a trickle of blood down one side of his face. Though he was anything but histrionic, he looked like a wounded stage hero if ever there was one. One man was lying in the wheelhouse with what might be a serious wound in the stomach. Another had been hit in the chest, but fortunately not near the heart, and one more was sitting at his gun with a bullet buried in his thigh. He smilingly but immovably refused to leave his seat, until hours later, in case the enemy came back.

The loader of the rear gun—a tall, fair-haired boy of nineteen—who had joined the ship a few days before, had been badly wounded in the left foot and had somehow crawled out of the way to the bottom of the companion-ladder in the officers' cabin. Bob Young knew he was badly hit and asked me to go with another of the men to give him some morphia. We found him lying on the floor. Someone had thrown a blanket over most of him, and he could not see his leg, which was sticking out. A cannon-shell had smashed across the instep leaving the lower part of his foot half-severed from the heel. It was a ghastly, nauseating sight. I had no doubt that they would have to amputate the foot and I tried to keep it from the gunner's view, as we lifted him on to a bunk, but he cried out hysterically, "I've seen it. I've seen it."

He was suffering from shock more than anything else. When he had had a morphia tablet, I remember feeling that I just must lift the lower part of the foot into place in the hope that somehow it could be set together, and that anyway that would stop the bleeding. Fortunately any squeamishness about handling wounds—(and about the pain it was clearly going to cause)—is completely overborne on such occasions by the obvious need to act. At any rate, with one of the crew, I managed to hold the foot in place and get emergency dressings round it, and

then he seemed—either because exhausted with the pain or because the morphia was taking effect—to be a little easier.

After a time the bleeding stopped, and I went back on deck to see if anyone else needed help and to find out if I could give more morphia. I also wanted to make sure that I could operate whichever gun I had to, in case we were attacked again, and I explained this to the wounded gunner, as I felt sure that he would not like to be left alone. At that he raised his head and an arm, which was an effort as any movement hurt him, and said with spirit something like, "That's the stuff!" It was an emotional gesture, but emotions were near the surface just then and it cheered me. Certainly our desire to keep the guns in action sprang wholly from the knowledge that that meant self-preservation; but I also wanted to take a fair share of the risk, if other planes followed, and the gunner's spirit and approval—though he was bordering on the delirious—gave me a momentary feeling of heroics, although, immediately afterwards, as I climbed up the companion-ladder, I remember praying earnestly and fearfully that the planes would not come back.

To get to the bridge I had to pass one of the machine guns, where someone had been wounded. I had never realised till then how much blood the human body contains. There was a patch some yards wide across the gangway and I remember skidding about on it and having to grasp the rail. The old cliché about the deck slippery with blood was suddenly, and even for a moment amusingly, and then grimly, true.

Fortunately the boat itself had only suffered superficial damage; there seemed to be bullet holes everwhere and cannon-shells sticking out of the woodwork every yard or two, but the engine was ploughing along gamely, and apparently untouched. It was only later that Bob Young,

seeing smoke as he went round the wounded, discovered that the transmission, damaged by a cannon-shell, was catching fire. He stopped it just in time. I was pleased, also, to find later that the triplex plateglass of the wheelhouse, by which I had been standing, was splintered from end to end. Fortunately the guns were all workable except one, although the sights had been shot away from two of them.

What more than anything still amazes and excites me, was to feel the abounding resilience of human spirits. Officially, it would be said that morale was excellent. But morale may be inflated by propaganda whereas there was nothing sham about the immediate reactions of the ship's company. To begin with they suddenly found themselves all, still, and as it seemed astonishingly, alive, and half of them exactly the same as they had been fifteen minutes before. Men gazed and then beamed at one another, as though they had just woken from some murderous nightmare. The smallness of the ship increased the sense of isolation, and heightened the unity on board. As it thrust home there was on the ship a feeling of human comradeship at its quintessential best. Emotions seemed a little larger than life. Men were no longer the parts of a naval unit, but felt a friendship and trust such as only those who have fought together, I think, can fully understand.

Indeed I have no doubt that on the journey back we all felt in our several ways that it was a happy ship. I remember Bob Young on the bridge grim but inwardly confident that it had been a fine action. By contrast the face of the sub-lieutenant, J. H. Weir, was radiantly happy. I think it was his first action. His estimate of the damage we had caused, ("One probable and two possibles") reminded me of a jubilant angler talking, as it were, of a salmon and a brace of sea-trout—wildly optimistic. By

contrast to him the spare officer who had been badly wounded in a previous air attack was reckoning with cheerful quiet relief that we were now past the range at which this particular attack might be followed up. I remember too the slow determined smile of the machine-gunner, whose thigh wound I sponged at the gun. As for the seriously wounded each of them when taken to hospital asked if they could rejoin the ship when they recovered.

Twenty minutes or so after the attack, the steward with a sunny smile came round with mugs of strong sweet tea and thick bully-beef sandwiches, announcing apologetically that much of the galley cooking apparatus was smashed. Most appetites, at any rate of those of us who were unwounded, seemed to wake up at once, and the sandwiches were put back with gusto, but it must have been about then that one of the machine-gunners fainted, and was carried down to the officers' cabin.

The journey to Derna passed without incident. Some way out from the harbour, another M.L. which had been looking for us, asked if we needed help—the number of casualties had been signalled and they thought that we might be short of officers to work the ship—but Bob Young signalled that we could manage and they left him to bring the ship in himself.

When we got to Derna, most of the crews of the other M.L.s in the squadron and several senior naval officers seemed to be on the quay. Two surgeons came on board and the wounded who needed it had soon been strapped into a breeches buoy and taken ashore. Then another ship's company came on board and began vigorously to swab the deck. The patent evidence of enemy bullets and cannon shell up and down the ship stimulated everybody, and by the time I had collected my kit there was only the holed and splintered plate-glass and the spattered

appearance of the hull to remind me of blood and wounds.

As I walked away, I felt how calm and silent Derna seemed. It was a hot-cloudless afternoon. The small Mediterranean town was taking its siesta, but for myself I was still thinking excitedly of the violence of a few hours before. Once at a crossing I happened to glance sideways, and found myself looking at an empty patch of sky, gazing at it giddily, and for a moment half imagining that suddenly some new swift-rushing fury would streak down with a blind scream. Somehow the daily prospect of survival had become all at once much less secure. It was difficult in fact to believe that life was continuing once more at its normal size and tempo.

Chapter Four ♣

FOR the next few weeks there was nothing for it but further delay. Tom, who had tried to go into Crete on the same moon as Perkins—or rather on the same moonless night—had been delayed at Bardia, and could not go in till the August boat, and as there was to be only one boat that month I had to wait till September. By this time Mussolini had been overthrown, and I was beginning to feel that the war would be over at any moment.

All this made me want to avoid further delay, and if the boat failed, there was a possibility that one might go in by air. A few months before I had been worried badly at the idea of parachuting. I suspected that everyone loathed it and did it merely out of bravado, and I only contemplated it originally as a desperate means of getting out of Paiforce. At that time the main British and American airborne operations had only just begun, and we still thought of parachute troops as a small picked commando unit. But I had seen a parachute demonstration early in the war in Northern Ireland. One of the men had dropped a few yards away from me, doubled up in a ball as he hit the ground, then flicked open the release on his tackle, rolled it up and raced off to form up with the rest, all as though going through any normal routine drill. That part of it had seemed easy, and I remembered the cheerful smiles of those particular parachutists, as the trucks took them away past my unit after the demonstration. I saw too that there was a certain camaraderie about parachutists which, when I remembered it two years later in Cairo, recalled the feeling on board the

M.L. on our return journey. Also I was beginning to get accustomed to meeting people, who in a restaurant in Cairo appeared no different in habits and manners from the officers of a civilised army anywhere, and yet who, one knew, had a few weeks before been conducting some fantastic adventure under the curious but uncomprehending eyes of their German or Italian enemies. What formerly had seemed remarkable and adventurous was beginning to seem part of a job, which all sorts of ordinary people did. So in the end it cost me curiously little effort to decide to take a parachute course, and though I daresay bravado played a part in it, I knew that it would be an advantage to have done it, whether I went in by air or not. Many of our Greek helpers had done it already.

When I got to Ramat David—the parachute training centre not far from Haifa—my own destination was soon given away by a hilarious greeting from two Cretans who were on the next course, but the security was good and though I was intrigued by the companions on my own course—who were all British officers—I did not know where any of them were going. At first the training was merely P.T. and the drill of jumping off a platform on to a mattress, with one's feet together. One of my daughters, now aged four, who likes showing how to jump off the nursery-table, reminds me constantly of the glee with which we practised. But all this was much like any other form of physical training, and did not give one much idea of what the actual jumping would be like. As the time came nearer, I certainly began to wish heartily that I had not got to do it. It was clear too from the talk of the others, that we were all thinking hard about it, and the instructor kept emphasising that, no matter how often you jumped, you always felt frightened. So I watched the face of the instructor when about to do a demonstration jump before us. Although he seemed as tough and matter-of-fact

a Yorkshire sergeant as one could meet, I felt sure from his look as the warning bulb lit up that he too felt the strain.

I knew I was going to be very frightened indeed, but believed that somehow we should all get through with it. That feeling increased in the plane itself. There were nine of us, and the first eight were to jump in pairs. This meant that only two left the plane each time it passed over the landing area, and that even if they were slow they would still drop within the area. As I was in the fourth pair, I would have to watch most of the others go first, but although the waiting increased the length of strain, it also increased one's confidence. It is no criticism of the others to say that they were all obviously frightened too. I remember watching them as we all chewed away at the chewing-gum, which our sergeant with efficient and not over-solicitous decency had produced as we entered. He explained that it was always best to take it before a jump, and that apart from helping one when feeling strained, it prevented you from getting thirsty.

The plane circled over the landing-ground. The door through which we were to jump was open and we could hear the air rushing past outside. The plane circled again, the warning light went up by the doorway, the first man took hold of either side of it, with his feet together almost out of the plane, ready to wrench himself through. He had to wrench hard to get out before the airstream knocked him against the side of the door. Then the green light went on; the despatcher gave him the order and he vanished through the door, followed a moment later by his companion. The despatcher looked out behind the plane and turned at once with a grin and his thumbs up. We could hear little because of the noise of the engine and the slipstream, but we knew that the first two parachutes had opened, and that that pair were now already drifting down, hundreds of yards away from us.

When my turn came I was thinking hard about how to jump out properly, and not asking myself whether to jump or not. Then the green light went up, the man in front of me shot out; I clutched the sides of the doorway, while the air outside the plane—and in fact the whole of space—seemed to be screeching past. One, two—the despatcher was beside me counting with his arm like a boxing referee—then the order to jump, and looking fixedly ahead so as not to look down, I wrenched with both arms.

The next half-second—for it could have been no longer—is something which no one who has experienced a first jump can ever forget, or indeed contemplate calmly—(I find for instance that I have been driving my pencil with several times its usual pressure on to the paper as I write about it)—nor, I fear, is anyone likely to be able to imagine it merely from a description. The parachutist jumps from a static atmosphere inside the plane into the slipstream flowing past outside at perhaps 150 to 200 miles an hour, and immediately it seems that a rushing mighty wind or raging torrent has struck one side of his body. I have never felt so helplessly in the power of blind physical forces, completely beyond the control of my own will. To be rolled about and knocked over by waves might feel something like it, if you could imagine the sea about you moving at twice the pace of a racing motorist.

Then suddenly there was a hard tug at my shoulders, and the sensation of being a snowflake in a maelstrom ceased as abruptly as it had begun. The parachute had opened. I looked up and felt inside me a great surging gratitude. I seemed to be suspended snug and safe, as I had lain years before rocking gently in a garden hammock, and the contrast and the relief were so sudden and overwhelming that I still wish they had never ended. Craning back I could see the parachute swaying above me. My

shoulder cords were twisted and I was spinning slowly round and round like someone with the ropes twisted on a swing.

The first thing to do was to get the ropes separated and straight over your shoulders. That you did by gripping them above your head and forcing them apart, and then after unspinning you held them as wide apart as possible to prevent overspinning in the other direction. The instructions worked nicely, and I had time to look down and found that the earth had suddenly got a great deal closer. This was most distressing. Drifting up there by oneself after the stresses and anguish of the jump was utterly delightful, and I certainly felt—as the instructor had told us that we should—that I wanted to go on and on floating through the sky. Everyone I suppose has something of the recluse in them, and floating there produced a satisfying airy feeling of isolation from the whole world, and all the time I was hugging myself at having got the jump over. Next time I should know much better what to expect. Also I was really reluctant to concentrate on the unwelcome fact that my immediate reactions and sensations were obviously soon about to be ended with—literally—a bump.

Meanwhile the earth itself appeared to be behaving in the most remarkable manner. First it tilted itself on one side, and then it spun round slowly like a plate juggled on the end of a stick, presenting an entirely different aspect, until I was not at all sure if I was going to swing on to it sideways or face forwards or flat on my back.

There was hardly time to feel more than surprised, and then the earth which had appeared at first miles and miles away suddenly seemed to rush up at me, much too fast to allow me to remember the landing drill. However it was an easy day, with little or no wind, and I dropped without sufficient force to knock me over, although I

somehow curled up and rolled, not being sure if it would be necessary, and wishing in any case to learn it as a habit.

Many people who pick themselves off the ground after a first jump must feel the bathos of balancing again on two dull legs, so ridiculously close to the earth's surface. For me that was happily avoided by the immediate and beaming glee of my two Cretan friends, who being in the next course, had been detailed to come and see how easy it all was. They happened to be standing at the side of the landing ground some few yards from where I fell and were the first people I saw on picking myself up. In a moment, we were all shaking hands and struggling to express ourselves in a mixture of Greek and English. I knew that they were saying, "Congratulations", but to say just that in modern Greek as if you meant it, requires a vivid reiteration of polysyllables for several minutes. Meanwhile I was trying to explain, with more sincerity than this account makes clear, that they would find it easy and largely delightful. I knew the Greek for "easy" but was at a loss to describe the particular form of bliss which was coming to them.

My British friends on that course were, I think, bored at times by the matey loquacity with which the Greeks tried to talk to me, but I always responded to it as fully as I could, partly because it was, I felt, my job to be as friendly as possible, partly because their mercurial spirits were admirably infectious and intoxicating, and partly because both of these particular Cretans had, I knew, already done good work helping our officers in Crete. One of them—though it little appeared from his clean-shaven but dark-jowled features—was really the priest of the large village of Anogeia. His name was John Skoulas, but he went among the British officers in Crete by the happy pseudonym of Friar Tuck. (This was later occasionally varied by other titles such as the Flying Parson

or the Parachute Priest). After months of assistance to Tom and other officers near his village, he had fallen under suspicion, but before the Germans could catch him had taken to the hills. He could do little there as a priest, and was evacuated to the Middle East, where indeed he might have remained, but he then obtained special dispensation from the Orthodox Church to shave off his beard and the bun of hair which Orthodox priests wear at the nape of the neck. Thus transfigured he was about to return to Crete to help Tom's party. He was also the father of an enormous family, and I felt that to become the first Orthodox priest ever to put up parachute wings argued considerable personality. Somehow we never felt that Friar Tuck would allow the fact that he was in orders and therefore strictly a non-combatant to get in the way of his other purposes in a military emergency. Besides this he had the most charming manners, and I think understood better than most of our helpers what was going on in the minds of the British officers, although apart from his trip to Cairo he can have had little or no idea of our real backgrounds.

My jollification with the Cretans after the first jump took only a minute or two, I suppose, but that was enought to make me the last to reach the truck, which was waiting to take us back to the plane. I suppose it was psychologically sound to make us do a second jump immediately. At any rate I remember nothing about it, except that they dropped us from a lower altitude, and I was even more regretful not to have some time for quiet detached contemplation while drifting to earth. For the rest of the day I felt as if I had done about 15 hours' hard physical work. One parachute jump, in the physical and mental exertion which it costs, is in fact worth about eight hours' work. The next night I spent largely unable to sleep, but when I did get some sleep it was

interrupted at frequent intervals by a series of half-waking recollections. All night long I clutched the bed-clothes or the pillow, in the belief that the earth was just about to rise and hit me flat on the nose, or that I was being swirled up on a round and towering wave, only to be drawn down again like a cork in a whirlpool.

Chapter Five ♣

WHEN I got back to Cairo, I found that I was to have a good and trusted interpreter who was already in the island, and the main contact with the local agents who would collect information in my area was, if possible, to be American George. His real name was George Doundoulakis, and he was known as American George to distinguish him from a host of other Georges. His father, who was living in his native village of Arkhanes, had spent some years in America, where George had been born, and George had therefore dual Greek and American nationality. He was then about 18, and had shortly before left the High school at Heraklion. Like many young Cretans of that age, having just missed the army at the time of the Albanian campaign, he had since then been eager to take part in the resistance. At any rate he had already proved himself an excellent intelligence agent. Having a secondary education he was soon able to judge from the unit signs on German vehicles or the badges on uniforms, what the units in his district were; that put him in a different class from many of our keen but more ignorant helpers; one of these once came to me and said eagerly that he had discovered the name of the officer in his village, as he had heard several men call him "Leutnant"! American George was far too intelligent to make any mistake like that. He knew too that accuracy rather than imagination was what mattered. Unlike some of the young agents from towns he was physically wiry, and keen. No walk over mountains was too far, I had been told, if he could fix a good contact at the end of it, and I liked his

confidence. Together we went over a large-scale map of East Crete, and he pointed to a village where he had already established a distant cousin as our agent. "That's where I'll take you for our first headquarters," he said, very much as if he was already himself in command. He added, as if this would make it above all desirable, that this particular village, Anatoli, was less than an hour's walk from the German headquarters at Ierapetra. I gathered it would be only too easy for George and his friends to walk in and out of the German units, and come scampering back to the wireless, so that Cairo should have a really up to the minute service about everything that the Germans were doing. George was so keen to explain these manifold advantages about his own scheme, that he totally failed to notice the startled horror with which I reacted to the thought of keeping my headquarters, and indeed myself, within an hour's walk of any German, let alone several German units. There was no gainsaying George. I could see that though he was polite enough, he knew best. That, I had been warned, was a failing of many Greeks, but the fact was that George really did.

He told me two things which impressed me, difficult as it was to visualise the life which I was about to begin. One was that you felt in the hills healthier and better than ever before. He said that after walking in the mountains you developed a wonderful appetite, and there was nothing nicer in the chill of the evening than to sit around a pot of good hot potatoes and oil. The other was that when the work was going well, with plenty of information coming in and everyone in the party knowing that he was being useful, there was a grand spirit about it, which made it the most enjoyable work in the world. George told me that with a keenness and enthusiasm which got well home. Clearly he had no doubts that it was the life of all others. Later I don't think we ever quite reached the high pitch of

exhilaration which George had reached in 1942. Then information from Crete had been of real importance, as the Germans used Crete as a base for the African campaign and intelligence about their movements was being used before the Battle of Alamein. Once, for instance, a whole contingent of transport planes were reported by Tom leaving Tymbaki, just in time for our fighters to catch them off the North African coast.

The last few days in Cairo were spent buying second-hand Greek clothes, getting photographs with suitably down-at-heel expressions for our identity cards, and selecting a few "toys". The toys were to be found in the workshop of a one-time architect, and were really camouflage devices for concealing or blowing things up. There was a length of rubber hose like a rubber truncheon, which could be laid inside the fuselage of a plane. It exploded when the plane reached a certain height. There were lumps of coal or logs full of explosive, suitcases containing wireless sets, and for my particular purpose a large and exquisite round demijohn covered with wickerwork, in the base of which was housed the charging engine for our wireless batteries. The top of it was detachable, and could be filled with wine up to the cork, which would look realistic and explain the weight, as we would have to carry it on a donkey or mule.

On the last morning I went to headquarters to take leave of the colonel and brigadier in charge of my section. The colonel seemed to think that Turkey would probably be coming into the war at any minute, and told me that they expected to keep me in Crete four or five months. This, although anything but accurate, was pleasantly encouraging at the time. He also told me *en passant*, as if to say that it might interest me but could not really have any direct bearing on my case, that if anyone was caught the headquarters would always assume that

the

enemy got to know anything known to him. I never understood why he said that then, perhaps as some sort of a comfort to show that they would not expect one to keep secrets, but I think more probably as a way of advising me to shoot it out, rather than be caught. The brigadier gave me some sleeping tablets for the benefit of sentries, night watchmen and such, and some other very special pills in little round rubber covers, to keep them waterproof, for the benefit of myself, if caught. We were given the option of having these with us, and I preferred to have them, though I doubt if I should have had the guts to take one deliberately. If you sucked one it killed you, we were told, in three or four minutes. If you swallowed it, it took much longer and would be very painful. Perkins had had one sewn into the point of the lapel of his coat, where he could have bitten it out in a hurry. I kept one loose in the breast pocket of my coat, and two in a belt round my middle, in which I also had the new consignment of sovereigns.

This part of our farewell though transacted in a quiet matter-of-fact style seemed all too like a third-rate thriller and therefore faintly bogus. I looked with disgust at a poster in one of the offices. It was intended for use in occupied country and showed the figure of a man in black and red, the head sunk forward, the body nailed to some sort of a cross but with hands and feet cut off, and blood dripping copiously from the stumps. It bore the legend "Traitors beware". Altogether, although I was given a friendly send off, I was glad to be out again in a few minutes and bundling in a truck along the road to Tobruk and Bardia.

Alas! the charging engine or rather its camouflage was our first casualty. The bumps on the journey soon lifted the false top from its moorings, and thereafter it wobbled at will out of line with its base, so that the whole contraption proclaimed itself to all and sundry as a drunken

sham. All the same I consoled myself by thinking that it might still pass for the real thing in the dark if we could gum the top straight although it looked as if any donkey would jolt it askew again before long. In that case we should have to cover the whole beautiful object with rugs, which, I was told, always made passers-by inquisitive.

There were four Greeks in the party, with George Dilley, my wireless operator, the conducting officer Holmes, and myself. American George, most unfortunately, had entered hospital a week or so before for a serious operation and only re-entered Greece some months later. Of the four Greeks with us Friar Tuck was the oldest. He was by now a captain in the Greek army chaplains' corps, (although dressed like the others as a peasant). He was to join Tom on arrival. A second man also was to join Tom. He was known as Scuttle George, his real name being Skoutelogeorgakis. He had managed in the dark to get on board one of our M.Ls. when refugees were being evacuated and so found his way to Cairo. This we regarded as merely an individualist method of seeing the Middle East and getting some training. There was in fact nothing Scuttle about George. He was a square-built very strong-looking man but like many Greeks from the mountain villages, extraordinarily agile. Shortly before the war he had been a national dancing champion—not that this meant that he in any way ressembled the product of a palais de danse. Dancing to Scuttle George meant the Cretan village dancing, where the leader with a handkerchief leads a circling row of men with their arms across each other's necks, and makes up a variety of twirls and whirls and leaps, slapping his heels with his free hand. George danced with less carefree swagger than some Cretans, but with a restrained concentrated confidence as if devoted to the art and consciously a champion.

The other two Greeks who came with us were Manoli

Vrelianakis, a plumber with a good resistance record already, and Siphi Megades, a youth from Herakleion, who had helped intelligence agents there. Siphi was to return to Herakleion and work there, if possible, so Manoli was the only member of the party who would come on with us from the landing beach to our new headquarters. The route lay partly through country which he knew, and like most Cretan villagers he had had plenty of experience of driving donkeys and mules. This turned out most useful, as neither George Dilley nor I had any inkling of the particular and varied grunts, whistles, and sucking noises with which the locals overcome the natural inertia of the Cretan donkey.

The passage out was rougher than the first crossing, and we were afraid that we might not reach the landfall in time, particularly as there was a large party to take off. The Italians in Crete had shown every sign of wanting to surrender, and their commander, General Carta, had been in touch with one of our missions. We had no real hope that they would start fighting the Germans, but it seemed at one moment that they might hold and neutralise the east end of the island to which we were going. They had about one division there. However, the Germans quickly installed themselves at keypoints. About this time also, the Germans had carried out large-scale reprisals against the district of Viannos, where a Cretan bandit leader, called Bandouvas, had installed himself.

Members of his band, which had recently received an airdrop of arms from us, made an unplanned and premature attack on a few isolated Germans, and the Germans then destroyed six villages, and shot about four hundred of the villagers whom they caught. The remaining villages were unable and unwilling, in view of these reprisals, to continue supplying the men in the hills, and resistance in the area collapsed. Many of the men were

able to go back to their villages, but the leaders were in some danger, more from relatives of villagers who had been shot by the Germans, than from the Germans themselves. We were, therefore, uncertain of conditions in the east end of the island, but it seemed likely that a large party of Greek refugees would be wanting to come away, and that Paddy Leigh-Fermor, who had been holding clandestine meetings with Italian staff officers, might be bringing off a bunch of Italians also.

This time we were to land at an inlet called Aliki in the centre of the Island. We actually reached it almost on time, and there was the light again winking away up the hillside. But I was intent on what was to happen next; already familiarity had demolished much of the romance.

The water was choppy and we could not come really close inshore, but they lowered the boat. Into it went the charging engine, and, as I now see, a most unsuitable attaché case of mine containing identity cards, maps, a Greek-English dictionary, a grammar, propaganda leaflets, the sleeping tablets and several other items of personal and specialist kit, which I had decided were important enough to go as part of a small allowance of extra supplies, which, if animals failed, I could carry myself besides my haversack. The charging engine was heavy and fell rather than was lowered into the boat. The boat was rocking badly in the choppy water, the charging engine's weight descended on one side of it just as that side was going down, and the boat tipped naturally still further on its side. Gazing helplessly from the rail I saw the all-precious charging engine and attaché case roll irretrievably into the sea.

It was nearly an hour before the boat had edged right in again by the shore. The breeze was now very stiff, and they tried to pull the rubber dinghy against it, but each time it was blown back. Then the third officer swam the

thirty yards or so with a rope and the dinghy was towed along it. The mountains did not rise so high or steeply as at Xan's cave, but it was a pitch dark night, and I could only see the bare outline of surf on the rocks. Again there seemed to be much commotion on the shore. As we neared the rocks, we had once more the queer sensation of hearing an English voice out of the darkness. It was Paddy Leigh-Fermor directing the dinghy. Then as I rose to step out, an elderly figure passed into the dinghy. I could just see the unexpected outline of a felt hat, and guessed—rightly as I learnt later—that it was the Italian general whom Paddy was taking to Cairo. Then two or three dark figures leant towards me to help me scramble up. The dinghy was wobbling badly and the rocks were steep and broken. One of the men caught my arm, and in spite of the din and clamour of Greek all about us, a well-known voice in Tom's matter-of-fact, pleasantly welcoming tones said, "It's nice to see you, Sandy." Meanwhile someone was shouting, "Trava, Trava!" which I recognised as "Pull, Pull". They were dragging in the boat with the rest of the party; there were two or three of them on the lines like a tug of war; the shore seemed to be full of burly bandit figures. Tom told me to go up a little out of the way of the beach party and wait while the rest of my own party joined me.

Meanwhile the Greeks were greeting old friends with bursts of affectionate loquacity, and a Greek officer, a nephew of the then Prime Minister, Mr. Tsouderos, whom I had trained with at Megiddo, gave me a tremendous welcome. He was a useful man, but somewhat careless, and while devouring a tin of sardines of which the Greeks have evidently been inordinately fond since ancient days, he succeeded in leaving the tin glimmering as litter near the water's edge. Tom, on sight of the tin, let forth a beautiful fluent stream of Greek invective that won my admiration

and envy. The P.M.'s nephew was evidently overcome with remorse, but I could not understand what Tom was saying except that he called many times on "My all-Holy mother"—presumably urging her to arise and smite. The Greeks, when they mimicked him, could often be seen explaining to each other how enraged he had been over this or that incident, throwing out an arm wrathfully and exclaiming "Panayia!!"

While the beach-party were at work, I had learned that the real reason why there were so many comitadjis around me was that the bandit leader Bandouvas and his party, unable to maintain themselves in Viannos, had in fact made their way to Tom, and wanted evacuation to the Middle East. Tom was only too ready to help them. Unfortunately our delay in getting ashore and the choppy water made it impossible in the time to evacuate more than General Carta and Paddy and his immediate party, so when Bob Young decided that he could wait no longer—it was already well past the hour at which he should have returned—Tom was left with Bandouvas and a large party of enraged desperadoes—about 40—still on his hands.

We all began to trudge uphill from the shore, but I remember only two things about the rest of that night; firstly, the M.L. turning. It was the moment when, according to Tom, one would feel blackest, but it is impossible to feel abandoned and isolated when you are in a large talkative party trudging noisily up a mountain-side and apparently paying no attention whatsoever to the possible presence of Germans. So I could hardly feel then—as I imagine Tom must have felt on his first entry—like a solitary figure left in a black windy night on a hostile shore, with little chance of return. I remember watching the boat, or rather the dim whiteness of the wash behind it as it gathered way, recalling what Tom had said about his own feelings and thinking, but not with any great

feeling of depression, that I had crossed my own personal Rubicon.

The other thing which stays in my mind from that night, was the hot heady scent of the thyme. It was late September—a season when the days in Greece are still hotter than summer at home, and the heat in the steep dried-up watercourses that slice down the sides of the hills gathers and rises and carries with it the evening scent. It was like marching through a cloud of incense. I breathed great draughts of it and began to appreciate also the raw qualities of the dry mountainside where the air was always fresh and vigorous after the sultry heat of the Nile.

The walk was steep. Although there had been a few yards of shore before the real slope began, much of it was about as steep as the slopes of Edinburgh Castle, where I had clambered about as a child. At times we had to drag ourselves up and I was not yet skilled at keeping my pack balanced. George Dilley who was a much smaller man, and less well trained for marching, found it heavy going. We had to hump everything as the party's mule had been taken that morning by a German patrol. The mule had slipped its tether, and wandered near the shore, where the Germans found it grazing. The coast there was a forbidden zone, and the Germans apparently assumed merely that it had strayed and commandeered it. Later members of our party bought it back from them.

At the head of the watercourse the sides narrowed into a steep cleft, and shortly before the first misty light began to steal over the sea—now hundreds of feet below—we clambered into a cave, or rather into a series of narrow galleries split into the rock. They formed a sort of stony rabbit warren with tunnels about ten feet high, but often only broad enough for one man's body. Bandouvas and his lieutenants were in a bowl in the rock with a window towards the sea. I was on a ledge above them with an

inside window between myself and them. Tom was on another ledge parallel and connecting with mine but out of earshot of Bandouvas. The rest of the party were stretched in separate crannies or fitted closely beside each other according to the rock formation. If we could have taken a cross section, it would have looked like a model of the life of primeval man in a Science Museum.

We dumped our packs and luggage, and I would gladly have lain down and slept, but first we had a meal. We had with us two or three sacks of food, mostly corned beef, sardines, and biscuits, and I had fondly supposed that we could live off these for several weeks till we got a local food supply established. I was therefore, at the time, appalled at the apparently spendthrift style in which Tom doled this out. Before we left that particular cave two days later, the whole food supply had been consumed. This was no doubt the best thing to do, and Tom always believed in eating food when it was there rather than carrying it. For myself, particularly at first when I had not local friends nearby, I liked to have enough food on me to keep my strength up, in case I should get isolated for several days.

After that we lay down but the floor was rocky and I was still accustomed to sleep in one attitude, so in fact I only dozed uncomfortably.

Most of the next day we lay up, waiting for a wireless message from Tom's set which was hidden about two hours' walk away. Tom was hoping that a second M.L. would come to take off Bandouvas.

I stole down to the gully to a spring shrouded by some oleanders, and took off my socks, much to the surprise of a Cretan nearby, who was even more horrified when I took off my shirt. Being seen naked was bad form. If we ever took off clothes in the hills, the local shepherd, who was usually watching unseen to see if we were sheepstealing, knew at once that we were British.

We also had a meal with Bandouvas and his men; they had killed a sheep, and we sat round the spit. Friar Tuck, with a beaming generous smile, scooped the brain out of the skull and proferred me a great gobbet of it on the point of his long Cretan knife, as a special honour. Already we were hungry enough to eat anything; I never got to appreciate the eye of a sheep, which was a special delicacy, but a lump or two of knotted entrail filled with blood to make a rich sausage would slip down gaily enough. My stomach fortunately had always been tough rather than discriminating and was soon content with a staple diet of goat, sour milk, and a local stringy grass known as khorta, warmed and lubricated by oil in every grade of purity and impurity, and scoured at intervals by raw astringent wine.

Bandouvas had sent several lookouts up the hill, so there was little fear of being surprised, and although my body was sore from lying in the rocky surface of the cave, it was a pleasant enough first day. Down the gully you could see, far below, the deep blue of the Mediterranean, crinkled by a light wind. The gully and the cave hummed with bees from the thyme.

That evening the runner to Tom's set returned with the news that no boat was coming. It must have been a black moment for Tom. He came to me after telling Bandouvas and said Bandouvas and his men had decided to hold what they called a "council of war". He did not know what they would do. He had promised them that they should go on the next available boat, but it would mean a long march down the coast, and a wait till the next moon.

What made matters difficult, was that Bandouvas, who had won a position for himself as a patriot at the head of a band of irregulars near Herakleion during the battle of Crete, had no idea of the war outside Crete or of co-ordinating his own tactics with those of anyone else. The

eldest of five brothers, he was a thickset village chieftain with a bristly dark walrus moustache in proportion to his girth. He had always a touch of megalomania and he probably felt that as the best known local leader, he should be himself in control of the resistance, should have his own communications to Cairo, and in particular should take charge of any supplies. Already he had had a serious quarrel with Tom over supplies dropped to Tom's party, which he had demanded at the point of a gun, but failed to obtain. Relations had remained, to say the least, strained, and when Bandouvas realised that we had sent off an Italian in preference to himself, no doubt it seemed to him like black treachery.

I did not realise then how serious things might become, but I knew from Tom's tone that the position was tricky. If Bandouvas decided to stay till he could be got away, it would be difficult to supply the party now that it was cut off from its native villages, and it was impossible to keep the presence of so large a party from other Cretans, wherever it went. The Germans too would be eager to track down a well-known bandit like Bandouvas. On the other hand it was by no means certain that Bandouvas would put any more trust in Tom's promise to get him away, than he would have done in the promise of another bandit leader like himself. He might in fact give up all hope of getting away from Crete. In that case he would probably turn nasty and there was no knowing then what might happen. There were inevitably in a party of that size men who had taken to the hills for many reasons, not all creditable. If they left us they knew that there would be hungry hours and days ahead, now that they had lost their local support. So it was not altogether comfortable to feel that they all presumably guessed also, that we must have a considerable quantity of gold about us. Tom told me to keep my pistol handy.

I remember lying in my particular snuggery that night, one of the knobbliest and draughtiest of many such that I later sampled, and listening in the darkness to the discussion between Bandouvas and the rest. The talk rose and fell for hours, but, although it got excited at times, most of it appeared to be steady argument. I could not bring Tom to where I was as it would have raised too much clatter in the dark, but I peered from my ledge on to the men below, feeling that all was well as long as they went on discussing what to do, and even at the time savouring the romance of the scene. I knew the Greeks well enough already to think that there could only be trouble if they got angry, but I had been told too that these particular men, shortly before, had caught a traitor and after hanging him upside down had amused themselves by sticking knives into him, until a British wireless operator, hearing his screams, had somehow shamed them out of it, telling them that they were behaving no better than the Nazis and that that was not what we were fighting for.

In the end, much to our relief, Bandouvas decided with nearly all his men to go to the Middle East. Both Tom and I were surprised at this, and Tom, in private, was highly scornful about it.

It was obviously essential to keep Bandouvas in his present frame of mind, and Tom had already decided that my interpreter, Niko Souris, would be needed to go down the coast with them. Niko knew most of them and being himself a Greek and a person of great tact who had worked most of his life in Alexandria with the British, he was the best man available to convince them, if they began to doubt it, that Tom's promise about a boat would really be made good. It was a sad blow to me, but I hardly realised then how little I should be able at first to cope with the work in Greek, and Tom thought that he had found a good guide for me instead—a man who came

from the East of the island to which I was going. This was Christo Zambetakis, a member of Bandouvas' party, then aged about 55. He had decided that Cairo held little attraction for a man of his age. He liked too the instructions which he claimed to have from Bandouvas which named him somewhat grandiosely the representative of national resistance in eastern Crete. Christo was in fact an agreeable, though at times most aggravating, blend of mountaineering caution and Mediterranean braggadoccio. He was justifiably proud of a large, flowing, white moustache, and this and his description of battles in the Balkan wars or accounts of how he and Bandouvas had descended upon the terrorised Germans reminded me of Tartarin de Tarascon. I christened him with the most inappropriate pseudonym, Mentor. He had considerable respect for the British whom he had known in the first world war at Salonika, but he had a lovable local patriorism and peasant shrewdness, which made him at times totally unreliable when he felt—as he often did—that instructions from Cairo or myself conflicted with local or personal interests. Another curious contrast about him was his evident tenderness for his family—he had a wife and daughter near Herakleion, and he had not liked the idea of leaving them alone in Crete—and this contrasted with the sudden wild fierceness with which one would see him slaughter a sheep or goat.

There was one other new and somewhat bizarre addition to my party. This was Lt. Tavana, who until recently had been the Italian garrison's counter-espionage officer. To my concern he evidently knew all our agents. It was he who had been in touch with Paddy Leigh-Fermor during the negotiations with General Carta. He had volunteered to stay in Crete, and we thought that he might be useful in collecting information, and perhaps bringing over Italian officers. I was personally glad to

have an educated Italian with me although we could only converse in stumbling French, but his presence was at times awkward. I explained of course to my own helpers as well as I could that he was very much on our side, but the Cretans generally suspected him, and although I was surprised how decently my own party behaved, there was always the chance that one of the shepherds would think that the only good Italian was a dead one.

That evening we had an amusingly demonstrative farewell from Bandouvas and his party, and after various grizzly-bear embracings between our party and theirs I shook hands with Tom with hardly a word—in fact with a sort of stage-English restraint in front of the others, wondering at the same time if I should ever see him again. I had asked him shortly before what was the best thing to do, if we bumped into Germans, and he answered with what I thought then was unnecessary sharpness that we shouldn't meet any Germans. All the same that night I had my pistol ready, and when once we had crossed the ridge above our hideout and had become a small party again, out of touch with everyone else, I constantly peered ahead, staring at bushes and trees. Eventually, as no Germans loomed in front, one got accustomed to walking about almost as though there were no enemy in the island at all.

That night we soon reached Tom's wireless set in another rather easier gully where a sort of wortleberry covered the slopes. The set was hidden in a dried-up watercourse that ran through clumps of oleanders. There we found two men in black puttees and Cretan breeches. One had a rather ruddier moustache than I should have expected in a Cretan and again we had the ludicrous sensation of finding that they were in fact two very British sergeants, Everson and Lewis. Although we were still in the centre of the island, and there was not at that

time any British agent anywhere in the 70 miles or so to the east of us, the walk to them had been so easy, and Tom's scorn at the idea that any Germans might interrupt us so immediate, that I began to lose the feeling of being all the time in the midst of the enemy. One felt rather that there were two organisations working in the island at the same time—the Germans and some fanatical Italian blackshirts (who had by then decided to go on working for them), living by day in the main centres largely in the plains, and ourselves with the whole Cretan population to wish us godspeed, passing about at will, but largely by night, from one mountain to another. Obviously we should be able to tell headquarters in Cairo everything that the garrison did. I was already feeling eager to get my own headquarters established and the wireless working.

We lay up next day, and then in the cool of the evening at the lamentably slow pace of the donkey, moved off along bare stony mountain paths till we descended into the southern end of the plain of Herakleion. The route took us through the village of Demati, by then peacefully abed. The moon was rising late, but there was half moonlight glimmering on the roofs and stone walls, and I remember the stillness of the cypresses. There are few trees in the plains but there were few things more peaceful on a cool windless night than the trees which sheltered a village or some half-hidden monastery on the lower slopes of the hills, where we often had to wait for a message or guide, while the moon was rising.

Cypresses lifting their black candles in the moonlight have long been a hackneyed picture all round the Mediterranean, but there was nothing sentimental about our passage through the village that night. Long before we reached the outskirts, one of the many mongrels, who somehow live and breed in Greek villages on a diet of curses, stonings, and occasional and completely uneatable

leavings from a goat's carcase, had picked up our scent, and passed it on to his colleagues in a long-drawn wolfish howl. The peace of the night was then utterly shattered by cacophonous and continuous barkings from all angles of the cobbled street. This happened whenever one, two, or more of us passed through any village after curfew. It must have wakened the whole village, but although I daresay there were faces close behind the shutters, normally the villagers would stay put. Usually I expect they thought it was black marketeers, and sometimes when we wanted to prevent a village from knowing that we had passed, we used to call out to one another in German, though I don't suppose that deceived many.

I found that my guides never paid much attention to dogs, except that the warning which the dogs always gave, kept any large party of us from going through villages where Germans were billeted. Altogether the row was a good cure for nerves on the march. It was obviously futile to worry about kicking loose stones on a mountain path, when every two or three miles your presence was going to be proclaimed to the whole world.

There were, we knew, no Germans in Demati, and after the howling had subsided we trudged on as if nothing had happened.

Somewhere near Demati we acquired a small boy as a local guide. Like most small boys in Crete he appeared to be approximately the second cousin twice removed of someone who had stood as godparent to a child of a second cousin of the wife of someone in the party. He was therefore regarded as "one of us" and entirely reliable. He was extremely proud and delighted to be guiding us, which he did quicker than most guides, looking forward, no doubt, to the adventurous accounts he would give of the exploit next day, and to telling all the other little boys in the neighbourhood of our hiding place. At the time I

am ashamed to say that his attachment irritated me considerably, so stuffed was I with the need for security about our movements. Although I could understand the explanations, it was all the more annoying to be angry without being able to explain why. Within a week or two, however, this sort of episode seemed very much part of the day's play. I soon came to trust entirely anyone whom my own men trusted. When making plans I assumed, too, that any Greek near us, except the occasional pro-German, would be told who and where we were.

That night, just as we were crossing a stream by stepping stones, and the donkey, with most of the stores piled on it, was staggering about in the mud, the distant sky suddenly began flashing and bubbling with red glowing balls. It was an air raid over Herakleion, and the German anti-aircraft were sending back the sort of grapeshot called "flaming onions". It was twenty-five miles away, a weird devilish, beautiful and exciting sight, but the fact that I thought that very soon we might be passing back information to our bombers, made it much less remote. I don't know if the guides put it on for my benefit, but apparently they were delighted and chuckled loudly whenever a particularly big flash meant that another of the heavier bombs had gone down on their own main city. There was to be more bombing that week, for the German counter-attack was just gathering against our landings in the Dodecanese, and a convoy was assembling outside Herakleion to take drafts from Crete.

We gave the large village of Skhoinia a wide berth, as Germans were staying there on a foraging expedition, and then before dawn we crept into a broken-down shepherd's spitaki, or little house, on a hill overlooking it. The house was merely four stone walls like a drystone dyke patched with mud, with a wooden roof covered with sods and bracken, mostly removed by wind and weather. I looked

out at Skhoinia, which was a mile or so away and tried to spot the Germans. It was the first time I had been near Germans on land since the war began.

Up till then we had marched more or less to schedule, and I believed that we were now within one night's walk of our new headquarters. That morning, however, it became certain for the first time that we would not complete the journey according to plan. Christo went off to Skhoinia with a local guide to find a mule (the donkey, which was borrowed, could not be taken further). He returned with the news that no mule could be found. The Germans were still in Skhoinia, and had requisitioned animals and oil. In the end we waited two days and two nights in the spitaki overlooking Skhoinia. Looking back on it, it seemes stupid to have been as annoyed as I was; I began to suspect that Christo was not really wanting to get on in a hurry, but whatever the real truth about Germans or mules, I knew I was completely in his hands. Explanations too took a tedious time because of my Greek. It now became obvious that the new headquarters must in any case be more than one night's march away.

I was worried about the food supply. A villager from Skhoinia, called Mikhali Khaniolakis, brought us an excellent lunch, boiled potatoes with plenty of oil and tomatoes, and bits of goat which we ate off the bone in our fingers. He also brought some grapes and a bottle of wine, and bread and cheese. I wanted to pay for this, but was not able to and that also was disconcerting because I had plenty of gold. I wanted also to buy other supplies and it was tiresome to be told by my guides that I must not offer any money. I think they would have liked me to give something in return such as socks or a torch, but the stores were all needed.

During these first days in Crete I began to feel more and more that the guides were not really doing their best to

get the party to its destination. Lieutenant Tavana could understand Greek better than I could then, and he had had some experience of life in Crete, but I did not want to appear to rely on him in much in front of the Greeks and in any case I was not too sure at the time how far his views about individual Greeks were to be trusted. Altogether I began to get more and more angry at Christo's view that we should get there "tomorrow or the day after", as he said, which one soon realised meant some quite indefinite time in the future.

However, after 48 hours we moved at night, skirting another village, Embaro, and about midnight reaching a narrow stony path up into the Lasithi mountains. The moon was still not up and we stumbled about on the loose stones, walking with wearisome slowness. Eventually about 4 a.m. we had just come through to the edge of the upland plain of Lasithi, and it was clear in spite of promises that we could not reach the headquarters area at the other end of the plain, two or three hours' away, in darkness. The guides then said that it was impossible for us, with the mule, to pass across the plain by day. Looking back on it I am sure they were right. It would have been taking an unnecessary risk, as the Germans were liable to search a party of five or six men with a mule. But at the time I was annoyed by Christo, who hid us with great show of secrecy and cautionings in some rocks and holm-oaks, above one of the villages, and then brought several of his cronies to look at us. This had its advantages. They fed us admirably on bread and cheese and eggs and grapes, but by the end of the day at least a score or so of the villagers must have known exactly where we were, and that we were about to set up a wireless set in their district.

However, that night a new mule arrived on time and we set off along the edge of the plain, stealing past shuttered villages with fair futility amid the usual fantastic chorus of

mongrel dogs. Outside one village we stopped, while the mayor came to greet us with a great handkerchief tied round a pile of rusks and cheese. There we met a new guide, whom I christened Ukridge. He reminded me closely of that burly feckless character from P. G. Wodehouse. After roaring forth instructions on the route (which Christo said were enlightening—but by then I was already deeply suspicious of all Christo's utterances), Ukridge disappeared into the darkness waving his stick, and was not seen again by us for several months. After that I remember only that the journey said originally by Christo to take two hours, then four, then probably all night, ended shortly before dawn when Christo finally admitted that he had lost the way. We were at the moment in a vineyard, on the slopes above a village with a fairly large German garrison. A week before I should have been distinctly frightened to be lost just there, but there were plenty of trees and undergrowth where we could lie quietly by day; we had been on the way six nights along about eighty miles of mule track without having seen a single German, and the whole Cretan population, though distressingly inquisitive, appeared to be not merely friendly but for the most part closely related to one or other of our band. Provided that we went on being fed wherever we went, we could apparently continue on our way indefinitely and without anxiety. Also although I had—quite unnecessarily—changed my socks once or twice I was by now quite accustomed to wearing indefinitely the same clothes, in particular the same woollen army shirt (dyed black) which after the sweat of the march with a big pack was pretty well stuck to my skin.

After an extremely agitated *sotto voce* deliberation between the Greeks in the party we went on a few minutes up the slope, and there stopped to sleep for the last hour of

darkness. Christo said that he thought we were close to the two Greeks and the wireless set which had been left behind there by Paddy Leigh-Fermor. He tried to convince us of his confidence by giving a series of shepherd's cries into the night. Nothing happened, but as the light broke an hour later we found ourselves on the tip of a gully covered with shrubs and small holm-oaks, and from the bottom of it two ragged figures dragged themselves wearily up to us. One of them I had never seen before; the second was just recognisable as a smart Greek officer whom I had known in the Middle East. He was now covered in sores. It appeared that they had heard us the night before, but, not being from the locality themselves, had been frightened to disclose themselves. They had received little local help, and for the last ten days had had little or no fresh food. The sight of them was a horrid shock, for both seemed at first completely apathetic, and it was no pleasant thought to suppose that we should all get like that very quickly if the food supply was cut off. However, their wireless set, which was out of action for lack of petrol to run the charging engine, was otherwise workable. We had brought some petrol with us and it seemed at last that we could start sending information to Cairo.

Chapter Six ♣

ALTHOUGH there were moments in the next few weeks when I hugged my shepherd's cloak about me, and succeeded in half-desperate style in laughing at myself for being in the middle of a futile but ludicrous pantomime, the next two months or so were almost continuously miserable. Fortunately there was nothing that I could possibly do but stick it. If there had been any chance of getting out of it all, I might or might not have seized it, but the possibility would certainly have added greatly to the strain.

To begin with, on the morning after we reached the headquarters, the batteries failed. For about six hours George Dilley slaved till his hands were raw and blistered pulling on the starting cord of the charging engine. At last he got it going, and charged one battery with the petrol, which we had brought with us, but the battery had been very flat, and he could only get through one message before it failed again. The nearest town, Neapolis, was about five hours away on foot. After great difficulty in explaining what was required I sent a messenger into a garage to get petrol, being assured that he would be back with us next day. At that time I believed that he would be, and was much angered when he turned up a day or so after that, with a cheerful story that the petrol had been hard to buy. When he saw that I was angry at the delay, he pretended to be hurt, mentioned the dangers and difficulties of eluding Germans, and seemed to think that he had really behaved with commendable alacrity and patriotism in coming back so soon. All this seems to me

ridiculous now. In the first place within a couple of months I was completely resigned to runners who failed to return on the right day. They had at times to make detours to avoid Germans, or failed to find conditions as expected at the place to which they were sent, and they had also a happy lack of any sense of time. A Greek villager judges time by the sun. Runners usually thought that one day was as good as the next for a job, and if they had relations on the way, the journey was a chance to look them up, and sip a glass or two of raki, while recounting the arduousness of life in the resistance. It was really no good getting angry with this state of mind, at any rate before you could express yourself really well, and after a few weeks I found that far more could be done by taking a guide or runner aside, explaining that the headquarters in Cairo were waiting for just the information which he was to bring, that you had absolute and complete confidence in his patriotism, and that because he was the best man for this particularly important job, you particularly wanted him, rather than anyone else. If a Greek boy thought that a British officer liked him, he hated letting us down, and usually did his best. But at first even if I had known how to tackle my local helpers, it would have been impossible for me to tell them this gracefully, and my own impatience only made matters more difficult. In fact for the first two months or so I felt that we were anything but a happy party and that it was largely my own fault.

About now also we learnt that Perkins had been killed. His party was ambushed at night. Perkins, when challenged, tried to fire, but the path where he was stopped was covered from three directions. He was buried with members of his party near a hill village in the district which he knew best, but after the war he was reburied in the military cemetery at Canea.

The gloom of my own party at this time would not have been so miserable if the work had been effective. We were soon receiving a host of messages from friends in Herakleion and elsewhere giving the new locations of German units, which had been changing since the Italian collapse, and, more important than this, giving us the troop movements of units bound for the Dodecanese, but, for lack of petrol to keep batteries charged, and ultimately because the charging engine failed completely, we were only able to keep on the air to Cairo for one week in the first six. At the time this seemed a major calamity. It naturally increased the depression of George Dilley, who, after several years as a regular Sergeant, got little kick at first from the irregularities of the life. In other respects he was admirable. I often noticed that unlike one or two of the others, he would hold back himself when there was not enough food for everyone, although as he later admitted the mountain air made him ravenously hungry.

Another more serious anxiety, though it affected us less directly at first, was the break-up of the military fifth column organisation, which had existed in embryo before our arrival. After dispersing Bandouvas' group the Germans took a number of hostages, and one of these happened to be a Greek brigadier, who was in fact the intended military leader, if a fifth column should be built up and put into action. As always happened after such arrests, anyone who had been collaborating with the hostages was badly scared. There was no real confidence that men under arrest would not talk, and any hope of getting together a group of local professional men or officers and appointing a new under-cover leader was out of the question. So not only was the intelligence work ineffective as we could not send the information, but the fifth column work could not be carried on at all. Indeed not only the better known local leaders were scared. The ordinary

villagers in the plain of Lasithi were just then going through the worst time which they suffered throughout the occupation, as the Germans, fearing that resistance would grow in the upland plains, now that the Italians had collapsed and the war was evidently lost, recruited, largely from the Dodecanese, a Greek-speaking police battalion, which came in German uniforms to Lasithi. They took and shot a number of hostages, and rounded up the rest of the villagers, cross-examining them often with violence and with threats of worse. It effectively prevented any sort of organisation, and incidentally made our food supply intermittent.

My Greek helpers were inclined to squabble among themselves. I did not know their capabilities, and often gave the wrong job to the wrong man, and when they started arguing about it, they would speak more quickly in their excitement and I could not tell what their reasons were. Nor did I realise at first that they often saw through each other very much better than I could. For instance at the first place where we camped, there was no cover for the stores and the Greeks with me must have known that the local shepherds had some cave of their own nearby. I did not know this and did not appreciate their criticism of the shepherds, who seemed to be helping us well. Nor did it occur to me that a shepherd's generosity to a group of bandits who settled on his part of a mountain, came from mixed motives, one of which might be a patriotic desire to help resisters, while another was often self-interest, even self-protection. On arrival in a new place the local shepherd usually gave us a good share in anything which he had, normally cheese—and as soon as we arrived in Lasithi an old shepherd gave us a lamb. This was a princely gift, and at the time I was told and believed that it came from the purest patriotism, but looking back on it I imagine the shepherds expected my party to behave

like most outlaws in the hills. We certainly had in the party several men who knew the ways of a sheep or goat at night, and could easily have kept us in meat by sheep-stealing, and I remember later on one occasion Christo explaining to a shepherd, as though he would take some convincing, that I paid for absolutely everything we slaughtered. It was rather as though he was explaining a nine days' wonder, telling someone whose home we were requisitioning that in fact we were really the most admirable tenants, as, by local standards, we certainly were. Sheep-stealing was not the only thing which a shepherd might suffer from a band in the hills. A year later we were followed on one mountain slope by a small communist band who thought that the local shepherd had probably acquired some sovereigns and possibly arms from me. From the look of him when I saw him subsequently they must, as he said, have given him a ghastly beating. Another shepherd in their area was said to have disappeared completely with all his flock. I have little doubt that his skeleton is still up there in some hole in the rocks of his native mountain.

The first job was to find a good spot for the wireless set, as the hide-out used by the two men whom Paddy had left was unsuitable for a larger party. Next morning I set off with Christo up the mountain called Tsivi which rose steeply to the south. It rises to almost 6,000 feet. The last 1,000 feet or so is above the tree line—merely an expanse of large grey rocks. You could see a man miles away on that, but on the slopes below there were plenty of holm-oaks, and pines, and the ground was broken. We climbed up a loose stony shepherd's track. This was the first long march which I had done by day. Firstly I looked about to see if there were any Germans on patrol. But we seemed to have the whole mountain to ourselves and, even if there had been Germans in the offing, it would have been almost

impossible not to enjoy the weather. This was one of the things about the life which made it fundamentally so enjoyable. It was a still blue day, the mountainside was too dry and hard to recall an English valley, but there was a spacious silence about it, and the clearness of the Greek atmosphere, and the sun—not too hot in the hills at the end of September—made one feel keen and cheerful. Christo was proud to show me the tremendous views of one of his native ranges. On the far side of the valley we could see the road from Neapolis to the plain of Lasithi zigzagging along the mountain slope. The Germans had recently given it a macadam surface. Very occasionally a German truck could be seen winding its way in and out of sight between the villages, villages with names as picturesque as themselves. Great Pines, they might be called, or Honey Bees—or Holy Barbara—or Ancient Bishop's—and on that particular morning we had in view two very little villages which later I often stalked into at night—Upper and Lower Almond. Above them, bare, grey, and triangular, rose Mt. Selena, with a German wireless station on the top of it. I never knew exactly what apparatus they had up there, though my friends in Upper and Lower Almond knew most of the men in the post personally and often got them talkative and drunk. Technical information was difficult to get through villagers, who naturally could not ask the right questions or understand the explanation, even if I could have tutored them. So the fact that there was certainly a wireless receiver and large-scale transmitter and possibly direction-finding equipment on the mountain immediately opposite us remained, like the constant rumours about a German intention to search for us, vaguely disquieting.

That first morning Christo took me to a young shepherd, who as it turned out, served us well, but at first I was deeply suspicious. He looked cunning, thievish, and

distressingly nervy. Of course he knew every stone and bush on his particular beat, but it was obvious that we could not be shown any good cave or cleft to hide stores, or any suitable camp site or cave for ourselves until he had consulted his cousins, who were the senior partners, and were an hour or so away on another shoulder of the mountain. Eventually we met one of them, and they showed us two slits in the rocks, where the wireless set and charging engine could be hidden. A whole battalion might have scoured that particular slope for a month without finding the holes. Their mouths were covered with large rocks, and a crevice at one side of each rock was filled with an easily removable dead thyme-bush, which, however, appeared to be still planted where it had grown. The thyme bushes let in air and scented the holes pleasantly, and if he had had water and a few emergency rations, George could have remained down there more or less indefinitely.

A little way above these clefts we were shown a round basin or dingle in a sort of plateau on the slope. This was 4,000 feet up, and once you were over the tip of the basin, you were out of sight from all directions. As it was off any of the mountain paths, you could stay there indefinitely with little chance of being seen by anyone but the shepherds. It had enough cover to make it a good camp site, and there was a spring within a quarter of a mile. As long as the weather held, we could sleep in the open. After that we would have to find a cave, as the two slits which I had been shown, were much too small to house the party.

That morning I was happily surprised at the natural generosity of the shepherd. He was obviously miserably poor. His baggy black shepherd's breeches were worn and greasy, his thick woollen chemise was almost as dirty as his feet, which I was able, though reluctantly, to inspect,

because both big toes projected from gaps in his boots. Although it was a hot day when we met him he was still wearing a thick rough woollen homespun sweater with a long purple cummerbund round his middle, and an old blue laced bolero on top of it all. He carried too a heavy thick brown cloak, which with its large cowl acted as a protection against wind and weather all the year, and at night as an all embracing blanket. He had wound round his head his sariki, a black tasselled handkerchief, which he removed occasionally to wipe the sweat off his forehead and his sweeping black moustache. His face, the colour of a glazed brown brick, had at times a look of blank animal stupidity, but his blue eyes were bright enough, and I liked the smile under his rather sharp nose, when he unlaced the brightly striped woollen sakkouli or knapsack in which he kept his lunch. This knapsack held, mixed together, two or three rusks, an Italian army water-bottle, some crumbling lumps of goat's cheese, a couple of onions, almonds, an occasional walnut, several old nails for mending boots, an earthy clasp knife and an untidy bunch of twine or gut made apparently out of some animal's inside. He pressed us, as if he really meant it, to eat his lunch for him. This, as I subsequently learnt, came from a perfectly genuine desire to share what he had with a visitor to his hearth and home, and was merely common good manners in the mountains. I was reluctant all the same, not because the farrago which he produced was unappetising—on the contrary, the walk and the mountain air made water, rusks, cheese and onions, even when mixed with nails, gut, and the rest, seem a perfect lunch—but I had on me very little myself except an emergency ration, which I was determined not to share out. Christo, however, soon devoured a good part of the shepherd's provisions, and after we had shared a good deal less of our own, he assured me that it was bad form to offer any

payment, as this was the shepherd's mountain, and we were for this first meal his guests.

Late that afternoon Christo and I returned down the mountain and that evening as dusk fell, the stores were packed on to a convenient mule, produced by a friend of Christo's from the village of Mesa Lasithi.

We moved off for various minor reasons, however, a disgruntled and irritable party, and the next two hours or so continued miserable, as we stumbled up the loose stones of the track before the moon rose. In almost total darkness we reached a point where Christo suddenly proclaimed that he would go no further. One of the shepherds had met us and would take the party to the dingle which had been chosen for the encampment. The mule should stay with Christo, although they could not find the rocks which covered the caves or crannies in which the wireless set was to be hidden. There had already been one or two indications that Christo thought he could go his own sweet way, and I was at once incensed. I should have made allowance, of course, for his age, as he must have been weary. It had been, as I later found, a typical long marching day, and although the night was cooler, it was always heavy going and tiresome to walk at night on rocks and stone paths, unless the moon was well up. I forget what happened, except that I made it clear that the mule and I were not going to be separated until the stores were properly hidden, and after much altercation most of the party were sent on to the dingle, after which in a hoarse conspiratorial whisper Christo informed me that he had in fact found the hideout and was sitting on it.

Although much relieved, I was not amused. At the time I still believed that it would be possible to keep the set away from the headquarters in some cranny where only George, Christo, myself and the shepherds would know of it. But it was becoming clear that this would be impossible

in practice. In the end I hid the stores with Christo, but was feeling pretty dejected and weary by the time I finally pulled a blanket round me and went to sleep stiffly on the ground. It was then shortly before dawn, and the brightness of the stars was waning. Sometimes in the next few weeks, when we were out of wireless touch with Cairo and the mission was serving no purpose, after squabbles among the party and failures on my own part to make everyone work hard or cheerfully together, I used to gaze at the night and try to get back a sense of proportion from thinking how much brighter and closer and livelier the stars in the Greek heaven are than the dim distant northern stars that I had known at home—but far less often watched.

Chapter Seven ♣

OUR first weeks on Mt. Tsivi remained miraculously fine. October was drawing in, and each day I expected the weather to break, not knowing that in most years the Greek mountains are blessed with sunny Alpine skies even to Christmas and beyond. There were, it is true, times when the mist came wisping over the edges of our dingle, and covered everything with fine drops of dew, but I soon learnt that on such nights or even in quite steady rain anyone who gets accustomed to it can sleep warm and dry in the open, if they lie still, and don't work the moisture through their blanket. We slept in our shepherds' cloaks, and the cowl protected the side of our faces and yet gave an adequate air vent. (In summer they were useful too; sometimes when travelling in the plain I used to tuck mine round my head at night with just enough room for my nose to get air, and it made a stuffy but impenetrable mosquito net.)

But mostly the days continued fine and clear. On one such morning, while all seemed peaceful and the Aegean islands lifting their dim shapes along the horizon, appeared as they often did before sunrise, to be themselves drifting quietly out of the rosy haze, we heard a new sound at first faintly, that swelled more and more pervasively into a great angry drone, and then in the distance we saw what looked like a flock of ordered midges. They were not flying high. I counted twenty-seven at least, and knew that they were Stuka divebombers, passing along the northern coast to attack the Dodecanese. Then they ground on out of sight, though the sound was not

swallowed up until long after that. No doubt then the mountain would have been left to its own spacious silences and myself to reflecting that all was not as peaceful as it seemed, if our dingle had not before long re-echoed also with the chattered imprecations of the younger Greeks, and if Christo had not roused from deep in his broad chest and through the thick and bristly palisade of his moustachios a well-maintained sequence of patriarchal curses.

On misty days it was impossible even for the shepherds to walk on the mountains without getting lost, and on such days the sense of living in a separate world became complete. Normally the nearest Germans were about two hours on foot from us, and an early patrol might have come to our camp any day. But even from the first on misty days we knew that no German would venture into the hills, and I came to welcome the mist as it removed the feeling of vague insecurity.

Although we seemed to accomplish nothing, the days were busy. Christo and others who joined us had plenty of friends and relatives in the neighbourhood. Most of the time I was interviewing somebody. The Greeks, being highly intelligent, normally speak fast, and being one of the most loquacious peoples on earth, repeat everything they say half a dozen times. Every repetition had itself to be repeated slowly two or three times before I understood the words, and the words used, intentionally or unintentionally, often did not in any case signify what the villager to whom I was talking really meant. So at first it was tiresome when, having eventually understood the actual words, I realised that even so we were not getting anywhere. Christo and other members of the party greatly impeded the process by vainly offering themselves as interpreters, and often attended the conversations out of pure curiosity, understanding well enough what was in

mind, knowing that I did not, and then at critical moments taking the villager aside for a *sotto voce* conversation. About every three days we would receive, usually just after dawn, a donkey-load of food brought by a friend of Christo's called Leftheri, who had been crippled in the Asia Minor campaign in 1922. The conversation would go something like this.

Leftheri. "Good day, Captain. Fair is freedom." (This last being the local equivalent of making a "V" sign).

Self. "Fair is freedom, Leftheri." (Then more prosaically and stumblingly). "You seem to have a lot on the donkey. Have you brought the batteries?"

Leftheri. "Oh! please don't thank me, Captain. That was nothing, nothing, nothing at all, Captain. It was just an obligation."

(Then warming to the job) "In these times naturally we must all help our allies, and assuredly Greece owes a debt to Great Britain, who has always stood by her as we learn in our school books. Just before I left I said to my wife, 'We littles ones must do everything we can to help Great Britain, who has sent us her great men from Lord Byron onwards.' She gave me this, Captain, and asked me to give it direct to you with her regards and prayers, Captain."

At this point Leftheri, with a charming smile revealing a row of remarkably healthy teeth, would deftly take a couple of small slim eggs from the cummerbund round his middle, or remove from the donkey's wooden saddle a most unhygienic handkerchief tied round a cup containing honey.

Self, (pleased—but haltingly—being unable to say "Thank you" adequately, and then get to business.) "Bravo, Leftheri. Your wife . . . very good Leftheri. Very fine indeed, Leftheri." (Then, realising that the word for "fine" also meant physically beautiful, and noticing some bewilderment on the part of Leftheri.) "I wish to say I

thank your wife very much Leftheri." (A momentary pause, while I groped for words in which to bring back the conversation to the matter of the batteries, and during which Leftheri, having drawn breath again, was easily able to seize the initiative).

Letheri. "Not at all, not at all, not at all, Captain. It was simply an obligation on us. In our village we all love the English, Captain. We love the English very much. Our people in Holy Water" (the name of a village nearby) "are all good people, Captain. People say that all the drops in Holy Water—meaning the people, Captain, that's so isn't it Christo? are pure drops, Captain, meaning in a manner of speaking that we're all good patriots, Captain." At this point Christo, slowly and with many repetitions, explained again the allusion to drops of water, adding that in Holy Water the villagers were indeed all as good patriots as Leftheri, although the actual water of the village was not all as fresh as it might be. In fact there were just as many mosquitoes there as anywhere else—another reason why I should not go there, Christo implied, except with an experienced guide like Christo himself.

Leftheri (having again drawn breath, but not being quite certain if I—or indeed Christo—were fully convinced of the utter dependability of Holy Water). "It's not the same thing at all, Captain, in Middle Mulberry," (the neighbouring village). "Not the same thing at all. We say that among the Middle Mulberriots, some of the pips have gone to seed." (Then, noticing my utter incomprehension). "That's just a manner of speaking, Captain. I'm afraid we are only simple people, Captain, but you can have complete confidence in the Holy Waterites." (A fairly prolonged interlude, during which Christo would make clear to me that the Greek word, Mournia, meant a mulberry tree, and that there was a

village called that nearby with some "Bad men" in it. This explanation underlined all too clearly the need to wireless to Cairo for a Greek dictionary to replace the one which I had lost at sea on arrival, and that reminded me about batteries, about which even I was beginning by this time to forget).

Leftheri (having again fully recovered breath). "You see, Captain, in Middle Mulberry they have a microbe, as we say—the microbe"—(this in a melodramatic stage-whisper)—"of Treason." (The Greek word for treason in the genitive (prodosias) containing as it does some convenient sibilants was invariably hissed with the most emphatic venom.) "Yes, Captain. There are traitors in Middle Mulberry, but we know who they are and of course we are keeping a watch on them. You need have no fear, Captain. One of them said last week that the Germans knew there were English in the hills above Middle Mulberry. But they won't find out where. You can have complete confidence, Captain. The whole village of Holy Water has sworn never to give you away. . . ." and so on and so on for minute after minute, even hour by hour until my initial amusement or concern gave way to exasperation.

Self. "But have you got the batteries, Leftheri?"

Leftheri. "Captain, I brought two large sacks of potatoes. They are the best potatoes in Crete, Captain. We always say in Lasithi. . . ."

Self. "Yes, Leftheri; thank you—but the batteries?"

Leftheri. "Just a little, little patience, Captain. We have hopes. Perhaps tomorrow or the day after."

Self. "But Holy Mother! Last week you said it would certainly be tomorrow or the day after."

Leftheri. "Well, Captain, it will be tomorrow or the day after."

Self. "But. . . ." (Wishing to explain that promises

were no good at all, but being unable to do anything but splutter irritably).

Christo, (reprovingly). "Leftheri is one of us, Captain."

Self, (with an effort managing to smile and speak as if I meant it); "I know. Of course Leftheri is a loyal friend. But the battery is important for all of us for all our work. Where is the battery now?"

At this point there would probably ensue a hasty whispered conversation between Christo and Leftheri. Greek peasants have no squeamishness about stopping a general conversation, and suddenly whispering together in the presence of other people, but at first I found this disconcerting. It looked as if they were blatantly concocting a story. However, at the end of it, as like as not Christo would say: "Captain, you must have a little more patience yet." "But Christo, where are the batteries now?" "For the moment Leftheri doesn't know exactly himself."

The batteries had in fact been taken by donkey across the upland plain of Lasithi, over the ridge beyond, and down into the plain of Herakleion. There they had been left with two Greek mechanics, who though attached to the aerodrome at Kastelli, and therefore in German employ, were in fact "our own men". They had promised to recharge the batteries, but after a week or so had said that it could not be done, and the batteries had been sent on to Herakleion.

There were other conversations during those first weeks. Some of them took even longer. One by one our contacts from the towns came to call on us. First there was Micky Akoumianakis. Micky's father had been the overseer for Sir Arthur Evans during the Minoan excavations at Gnossos and had been killed in the fighting at Herakleion. Micky himself had a round beaming face, and a thickset tough figure. Moreover he had been brought up in a

tradition of devotion to the British, had recently taken a law degree, and was training at a Greek Officer Cadets camp when the Albanian war ended. He was therefore an ideal agent and brought admirable information from Herakleion about the German units, and arms. There was really no need to ask any questions about his reports. I spent much time at first discussing with him the organisation of the work, the sub-agents, the jobs which my own party could or could not do, and food supplies from Herakleion. He arranged to buy flour for us, and have it baked in Lasithi, and we would then get regular donkey-loads of rusks, potatoes, oil, and raisins. Micky was as good as his word. He had sufficient knowledge of newcomers from England to know that they assumed that promises would be kept, if possible, and he was also tireless in collecting the information, egging on his own friends to help, arranging rendezvous, and meeting local dignitaries. Soon after this the room in Herakleion where he and his friends kept their propaganda and a small printing press, was raided. He escaped, but remained inside Herakleion for eight further months. As Herakleion is a town of about 60,000 people, to stay there so long when any one of hundreds of his fellow citizens might have taken fright and given him away, required not merely cheek, of which he had plenty, but remarkably sustained nerve. The cheek he was able to show on many occasions, but never better than when he made a close drinking friend of the German chauffeur of the General in command at Herakleion. On one occasion he offered him a cigarette, and then saw that it was a brand new Players imported from a recent boat from Cairo. He told me that it had given him a nasty turn, but before the German had grasped the point, he asked him if he minded smoking a British one, and explained that he had bought some black market ones captured at Canea, when the Battle of Crete

ended. The chauffeur had been delighted to smoke an English one with him, and thought it a capital joke.

It seemed odd at first to be asking questions about the Germans from someone, who only an hour or two before had been talking to them himself. The gulf between friendly chat in a Greek tavern between one of our Greek helpers and the German, soldier and what happened to the Greeks in a military prison, if they were caught, seemed so bizarre and disturbing that I tried to avoid thinking about it. The contrast was even greater between that and the gay flirtations between German officers and the Greek girls who worked for them as interpreters and supplied us with copies of their papers—a situation which was far too Hollywood to seem credible.

Often the interviews were not merely about the movement of German units, or one's own supplies. I was also trying to get into touch with the leading men in the district. But at first owing to reprisals it was impossible to arrange any meeting. One or two sent messages. They would like to see me. After about a fortnight, I went down to the nearest village one evening with Christo. There were a few Germans stationed in the village, but there was really no risk in this, as I soon came to realise, though at the time it seemed an adventure. We got to the outskirts about nightfall and Christo left me in a thicket, while he went to his friend's house to see that the coast was clear. Left to myself I had time to think again just how odd the situation was. I could hear the village animals returning for the night close by down a path beside the thicket. A Greek girl went past leading a goat, and I wondered if she had a dog with her—but I knew by now that there was no reason at all to be frightened about ordinary Greek villagers, and hugged myself in amusement and excitement. Then Christo returned bursting through the thicket like a sportive buffalo, although when

he saw me he indicated in hushed tones that we must proceed with extreme caution. I tried to walk down the cobbled village alleyway as normally as possible, but felt as if I was doing it on tiptoe, and was being watched by anyone who went by. All Greek villagers stare at a stranger, but it always seemed that they knew who the British were, and my own party told me encouragingly from time to time that they could tell an Englishman at any distance from his gait.

Evidently there were no Germans about. We slunk into a stable; at the side of it, walled off from the street, was a stone stair. Over the stable we entered two rooms, where our host greeted us with a beaming smile, while his wife gazed at us half frightened and half excited, I think, with the children holding her skirt. Inside there was a plain wooden table, one or two wooden chairs, a picture of the Virgin with an oil wick beneath it, and a chest in which was stored the marriage dowry, which seemed to be largely a pile of thick woollen homemade blankets. Halfway up the wall was an alcove with a mattress on the floor. Our host and hostess climbed up there to sleep. A curtain shut it off from the rest of the room. There was a second small room in which the children slept. The bareness of the main room was lessened by the strings of onions hanging on one wall, and a shelf with a few apples on it which sweetened the general mustiness. There appeared to be no window except on to the covered ledge at the top of the stair, and that at this hour—for it was nearly curfew—was blacked out with a sack. It was in such plain and humble surroundings that much of our work was done. I preferred the real peasant homes. A little higher in the social scale, families were dimly conscious that anything they could do was less than an officer from England would be accustomed to, but the peasant simply gave one the best he had—(often if there was not a flask of wine in the house or

a drop of raki you might see someone scurrying off next door to borrow it)—and he would apologise charmingly for having nothing else, and then accept your protestations of gratitude, and worry no more.

That evening we had what was certainly a feast for the house. Rabbit—the daughter kept one or two tame rabbits in the stable—eggs for us, though not for the family, bread baked twice into rusks (the Greeks think they are starving if they have no bread with a meal), and a little local wine, raw but warming, and some khorta soaked in oil. No doubt we had a glass or two of raki before we began. It was a cheerful friendly evening, and the first time that I heard Christo sing the charming old Turkish song, which we called "Philadem". Occasionally I found myself stopping to remember with a curious fear—which sooner or later turned into glee—that a German guard post was within a hundred yards of us.

We had got to meet local leaders next morning, but there was nothing to be done that night, but chat with our host. His wife, in the manner of most peasant women, kept quietly in the background, but by an occasional exclamation and by her intentness I knew that she wanted just as much as her husband to give us any support she could.

Next morning the local forest guard (agoraphylax) brought one of the local lawyers from a larger village nearby. He seemed frightened to be with us, and I did not blame him, for his immediate boss only a fortnight or so before had been taken hostage and shot. He told me that a member of the self-appointed political committee for the district, who had "undertaken" responsibility for organising subversive activities, would be able to see me "soon", and I made some enquiries about local leaders and was able too to check information about military units, but it was a disappointing meeting. Obviously the local leaders

were not in a position to start any useful work. I had hoped that they might begin organising groups of dependable men in each village, but though I was assured that they had the local population behind them to a man, recent reprisals had made them chary of working at any systematic organisation. I came away feeling that the fifth column side of my work would produce little of use from the civilian leaders. In the end we would probably have to build up groups in the hills, and it would take time before the right leaders could be found.

There were occasional scares. One morning shortly after dawn an aged figure in black rags half hurled itself over the edge of our dingle—(we had moved on by then to a more steepsided bowl in the rocks). Pointing a ragged finger like a parody of destiny herself she began screeching in the broadest of incomprehensible dialects. The scene, in fact, was too like the witches in Macbeth to be real. It was so theatrical that I could not take it seriously, though those of the men who could understand the dialect, were scrambling about hastily, and the faithful Manoli Vrelianakis explained that this was the shepherd's mother and that she was telling us that a German patrol had come up the mountain, and was making straight for us. However, for the time being they were out of sight, and we could not tell where they were. If we moved, we might get caught in the open and would have to leave most of the stores, which would then be taken by the Germans, or failing that by the shepherds. If we stayed where we were, the Germans, unless they really knew our hide-out, might well walk straight past it. Each of the men had a rifle or tommy-gun of some sort, and we should have been able to fight off an ordinary patrol, though this was said to be about a company (possibly a hundred men). Not knowing what was best, I decided to stay put, and we all crouched down in the

rocks and waited. We were necessarily hidden some little distance one from another, and I feared that one of the more excitable members of the party, if the Germans appeared, would loose off at them, long before it was necessary, and so finally give our position away. However, there was nothing to be done but wait. The shepherd's mother had disappeared, and we stayed there peering out for a trace of the Germans, and gradually getting more and more bored and ready to discount the whole story. Nothing happened, but we learnt later that a patrol had in fact passed on one of the mountain paths nearby, I don't suppose they were actually searching for us, though they probably had orders to look for signs of bandits. It meant that the Germans had begun to hear rumours about us.

One day I decided to go down to Lower Almond to meet a man, who, I hoped, would have news from Neapolis, and who would perhaps be able to arrange a meeting with our main source of information there. I took as guide a strong cheerful peasant from Lasithi, Aristeides Christouphakis. We left shortly before sunset, and had reached a main road by curfew time in the uncertain twilight that comes before a cloudy night. As we trudged up a path, I could hear a horse coming along the road, and Aristeides halted at the top of the bank that led down on to it. I halted a yard or two behind him and we peered down on to the road, which was in deep shadow. The horse had been close but I could see nothing. I suppose we had halted in a bad place. To the rider below we must have been visible on the skyline with such light as there was from the end of the sunset behind us. Suddenly, a few yards away, a gruff voice called out in German "Komm, komm." It gave me a thrill of fear, but I felt too a curious amusement at the thought that I could understand what the man on horseback was saying, and I wanted to tell

him that there was no need to speak to us in the mixture of pigeon-German with occasional Greek words which the German soldiers used when giving orders to the Greeks. Aristeides hesitated, and the German called out the order again, whereupon Aristeides went down to him. The German growled something to him which I didn't hear, and Aristeides began giving an explanation in Greek, which I couldn't understand, of why we were late out. Then the German pushed him aside, and called to me, with a threat to take us to "phylake" (prison). Looking back on it I don't think we were in any real danger, as between us we should have been able to tip him off the horse; we could in any case have made a dash for it and in the half darkness he would have been very lucky to hit either of us. All the same I knew that if I had to do any talking he would quickly see that I wasn't Greek, and we were unpleasantly close to a village where there were plenty of other Germans, so I felt deplorably hollow inside as I went up to him. I had a shepherd's cloak with the cowl over my head, and he bent down and peered at me. "Komm, komm." He repeated the words angrily and loudly, like a man trying to make himself understood. More or less automatically I went up to his stirrup. Aristeides was a few yards off, but I felt somehow that he was very much there, if anything went wrong.

The German leant over, seized the cowl of my cloak and threw it back roughly. I suppose that he himself was frightened by our two hooded figures in the darkness, and wasn't too happy at the thought of ordering us to come with him to the village guard house. In any case, after peering into my face from a few inches away, he seemed to be reassured that we were shepherds all right, and gave me a heavy push away from him. No doubt I seemed dumb enough in all senses of the word, so it was Aristeides

whom he told to get on. "Good night!" said Aristeides with a hearty cheerfulness, which might well have given us away, and in a moment we were both speeding down the path towards our village. All this time I had said nothing at all. The whole episode only lasted a couple of minutes, but it was quite a long time before I could think about it calmly, and tell myself that it had really happened. Instead I kept picturing the German's face thrust into mine, wondering if after all I was dreaming, and if I had really come down safe and sound from that hill road. Once such an episode had ended, it took some time to come back to earth, and I felt very flat—a sort of *post coitum triste* feeling as Paddy Leigh-Fermor once explained it. It was not till we reached the village and Aristeides was explaining it all in Lasithiot dialect to our host—the local carpenter—that we both began to enjoy ourselves. Aristeides had not understood much of the German, and I tried to help. It must have made a very piecemeal story, and the family who heard it, can hardly have appreciated the glee with which we repeated "Komm, komm" to each other. After that whenever we met after an interval, we would add to the normal greeting of friends, the little password which we kept up with a grin between us—"Komm, komm."

Chapter Eight ♣

At the beginning of November we received a message from Cairo that a new charging engine would be dropped to us in about three weeks. The message got fainter and fainter. It must have been an excruciating job for George Dilley who had been told that there were not merely one but two messages for us. He just managed to hear the morse tapping away until the first message was completed. If he had not been a really good wireless operator we should not have got even so much, but at that point the set went dead. Once again a local battery which we had managed to buy, had petered out after only a few days' use. We had no means of recharging it, and no spare.

I knew that we could not go on working on bought batteries, so I decided to go to the nearest British wireless, which was Tom's, somewhere on Mt. Ida, and complete arrangements for the charging engine from there. The journey lay across the plain of Herakleion, and would take several days, but fortunately there seemed no imminent prospect of any invasion of Crete, and I reckoned from the map and from what Christo told me that we could get to Mt. Ida and back in ample time, before the charging engine was dropped to us.

I took Christo with me because he knew the country best, and also two young guides, one of whom, Siphi Megades, was to stay with Tom and work near his home town of Herakleion. The other, Manoli Aggelakis, had joined us after the break-up of Bandouvas' gang. He came from a village south of Lasithi but he had been educated

by an uncle in Alexandria, and the partisan life was at times almost as strange to him as it was to me. Fortunately he had none of the townee's abhorrence of long marches, and had much more idea than the others of what was going on in my mind, and of why I was there. Gradually, as I began to speak more Greek and to see through the exaggerated claims of some of the runners, I could often raise a twinkle in Manoli. He looked more like an ancient Greek than most Cretans and soon acquired the code-name Apollo.

On the first day we had a long and wearisome march, but the route lay across the Lasithi mountains, north of the plain of Lasithi, to the plain of Herakleion, and unless by great bad luck we ran into a patrol, the day would be no different from a walking tour in mountains in peace-time. Indeed much of the travelling was like that, and I soon ceased to feel that there was anything dangerous about making a journey in so-called occupied territory, unless I had to go into a town or garrisoned village or knew that the Germans were rounding up villagers along the route. Such days were in fact delightful. The mountain walking was often extremely exhausting, but there was behind it the feeling that we had a real purpose in getting there quickly, and the slight chance of sighting a German patrol added a boyish spice of scouting. I soon found, however, that when I said that I must be with Tom in three days, (which I reckoned the quickest possible time), Christo and the others would readily agree, but regarding that as impossible and not feeling that speed was important, had no real intention of completing the journey in that time. Indeed it would have been impossible in any case. As night fell that evening, we had reached an empty stone shepherd's hut at the head of a steep ravine overlooking the plain of Herakleion. I had hoped to reach the plain before the light failed, but to go down in the dark,

when you had to feel your way in loose rocks, might, I knew, take us all night. In daylight it should take only an hour or so, so we slumped down to sleep on the floor. The atmosphere was rather like the inside of a henhouse, and the floor about as scratchy, but it was beginning to get cold at night in the mountains, and we were glad enough to be in shelter.

Next morning after a splash of ice cold water over the face from a trickle running through the shepherd's trough, a nip of raki, and a rusk which we had with us, we set off about 4 a.m., and before the sun was up had reached the plain. There we had to be careful. Parties of more than two would probably be stopped, so we split into pairs. Christo and I went in front, and the two others followed two or three hundred yards behind us. If stopped, Christo and I would have had to make a getaway, as it was no good pretending for more than a minute or two that I was Greek, so we kept our pistols. The other two reckoned that they were safer without theirs, and cached them.

We had not been going more than half an hour when we saw two men in what seemed to me nondescript clothes approaching us with a mule. Christo said he thought they were Germans. The mule track forked in front of us, so we waited at the fork, until we knew they were Germans, and then walked on down the other branch of the fork out of harm's way. Unfortunately the fork was then in full view of the Germans, and we had not been able to signal to the others, who were some way behind, and had not yet seen them, but when they did, would not be able to get off the track without arousing suspicion. There was, however, no reason to suppose that they would be held up, so we walked on, and once out of sight in a dip, waited, peering back to see what would happen. The Germans themselves were by then in a dip, and the two

parties were only twenty yards or so apart when they saw each other. There was still no reason to think that anything would go wrong, but for some reason, which we never knew, the Germans stopped them. Then I saw something white blowing away from the group and a moment later Siphi, who was a tall youth, was charging after it. There must have been a strong wind, as he raced about twenty yards and then fell full length. I saw him go back to the Germans, and the whole party moved off together. It was a nasty moment, but they had hidden, we thought, everything that might incriminate them. The Germans had tommy-guns and there was nothing we could usefully do to help, except quickly put as much distance between us as we could without being seen again. The track led along an old dried-up watercourse and we raced along the bed of it. Then quite close in front, we heard the sound of an engine. That almost certainly meant one or more Germans. There was a bridge just in front. I remember being again amused by the sight of Christo—by this time a distinctly breathless buccaneer—as he suddenly plunged into a tamarisk, but the next moment I shot into one myself, feeling, and no doubt looking, like a much-chased rabbit, just as a German motor-cyclist went trundling over the bridge. However, a few minutes later we picked ourselves out and went on more cautiously. Fortunately Christo knew the plain well. I suppose as a butcher he had bought livestock all over it. In any case he had soon guided me further down the watercourse to an old friend, who gave us a really excellent lunch of barley and snails, and some red wine, all of which I remember to my shame, as the recollection of what might be happening to Manoli and Siphi a mile or two away, was still an anxious and odious thought.

The rest of this incident I had much later from Manoli and Siphi themselves. When they were stopped, Siphi—

a somewhat careless youth—suddenly realised that he was wearing under his jerkin a khaki webbing belt, obtained in Cairo. As they were evidently about to be taken to a German H.Q. and searched, it was essential to slip this off. Siphi, like most Greek secondary school boys, was a quick thinker. While fishing out his papers, he let one of them blow away. He then managed to get rid of the belt in some heather, when he fell on top of the piece of paper twenty yards from the Germans.

So far so good! The rest of the story is more typical of what was happening to other resistance workers in Greece by this time. Manoli and Siphi were taken off to the German headquarters. No doubt the Germans thought that there could be no good reason for a couple of young able-bodied Cretans to be wandering about at that hour apparently far from their homes. At any rate they would have to explain at the local headquarters, where there would be an interpreter. There they were thoroughly searched and the Germans discovered in Siphi's sakkouli a suspiciously un-Cretan mackintosh cape, and rather more Greek money than two villagers would normally carry. The German in charge told them that because of the cape they would be detained, but Siphi managed to persuade him out of it, indicating that the money could be well spent for the good of his unit. Thereupon Siphi and Manoli were released, less about £5 worth of drachmas, amid smiles all round. According to many Cretans, German N.C.O's and junior officers, normally as honest in money matters as other Germans, had by that time become pathetically easy to bribe.

By dawn next day we reached the slopes that rise from the plain of Herakleion to Mt. Ida, the highest mountain in Crete. A new guide took me on that night to Anogeia, which at that time was one of the "richest" hill villages in Crete, with some 4,000 inhabitants. Although the

centre of all the surrounding mountain hamlets, it was off the main lines of communication along the north coast, and there was no German garrison. As the home of a sturdy mountain stock, it had therefore long since become a centre of the resistance movement, and Tom's wireless set had for long spells been established in the hills near it.

Part of that day I spent in Anogeia, itself and then a weather-beaten old gentleman led me further up-hill to Tom's camp. I had already learned that Tom was not there. This was a mischance which was only too likely to happen, but I received also the excellent news that a charging engine had arrived by sea and was already on its way to George. Another would be sent by air. Meanwhile I was glad that I had made good enough progress to have a few days in hand to get in touch with Tom before I had to return to Lasithi. I could also send messages now to Cairo and receive an answer when I met Tom, as there was another set near him. It was, however, distressing to be told that Tom was "only about eight hours away, over there"—this last with an airy wave of the arm towards the crest of Mt. Ida, still some four or five thousand feet above us. I explained expansively that, however short the way might seem, I had already been walking five days, and wished to goodness that they would keep Tom *in situ* when next I came to look for him.

On that particular day the camp was in a state of some anxiety. A Greek runner who had gone to fetch information had just been stopped on the way to Herakleion, and the Germans, finding a gold sovereign on him, had taken him to a military prison for further interrogation. This looked ugly. Apart from the general anxiety for the runner himself, who was evidently liked, the knowledge that he might be forced to talk was bad for everyone's nerves, and the officer-in-charge had to make the always difficult decision about whether or not to move the wireless set. In the

end they stayed put. The runner was eventually rescued through a bribe administered to the Germans by the local bishop, who was able to persuade them that the young man was merely a foolish youth, who had somehow got into bad company during the battle of Crete. As the runner was in fact highly intelligent, I doubt if the Germans believed much of this, but at any rate they were ready to let him off.

Before moving on I had the pleasure of meeting Mr. Skoulas (Friar Tuck) again. Having been the leading priest in Anogeia until he took to the hills, he knew the district and people better than anyone. Perhaps because, as a priest, he had taken confessional, he was also remarkably good at keeping a secret. Since the parachute course in the Middle East, he had become a jovial member of Tom's party, evidently pleased to be upholding the resistance tradition of the Greek church. He and his cronies were, however, much shocked, I was told later, when, before I set off for Tom, I undressed completely, and tried to freshen myself by a chilly scrub all over with a most inefficient local soap made of olives. I hoped too to eliminate some of the insects—fleas in summer and lice at all seasons—which had by this time got a firm breeding ground in most of my clothes, not to mention my own body. In the end I gave up trying to massacre them until we were sent some D.D.T. This worked miracles. Then we would shake a jersey and find the corpses sprinkling the rocks below—but at that time we just had to get accustomed to them, and found perverted amusement in seeing how large they grew.

Next morning three of Tom's young stalwarts led me up the slopes of Ida. Although we passed within a few hundred yards of the summit, it was still largely bare of snow. Standing on the dry grey rocks well above the tree-line, with a tremendous view across the plain of

Herakleion to the Lasithi mountains on the east, the White Mountains westwards and the sea to north and south, I felt very much monarch of all I surveyed, until I looked down and saw villages where I knew there were Germans and Italians in abundance. However, there was little time for philosophising on the relative freedom of the outlaw life, if we were to make the village, where Tom was said to be, before nightfall. The trees on the far side of the crest, if we reached them after dark would take hours and hours to pass. So we raced down the far slope, and this time did reach the village in the prescribed eight hours. There I found Tom dressed in a large shepherd cloak, longer and blacker than the usual. From behind he looked like a caricature of a Grand Inquisitor, and from the front the twirly black moustache which had made such an unfortunate addition to his uniform in Cairo, looked curiously at home under his shepherd's cowl. I learnt that he was making a tour of villages in the Amari. Being off the main routes it was a good centre for recruiting mountain bands. It had also harboured several hundreds of British, Australian and New Zealand troops after the battle and helped them to escape.

For the next day or so all that I could possibly do was wait for the reply to my messages to Cairo, and take part, as a further reinforcement of Tom's mission, in his peregrinations round the Amari. It was delightful to see the enthusiasm which greeted him everywhere; he was known as "Mr. Thomas" or alternatively, "Mr. Joanni", to hundreds, if not thousands of men and women throughout the valley.

On arrival I had my first experience of a village feast. That it should take place in a village in which a German guardpost was situated, seemed no longer in the least strange. It is true that we entered the village after dark, skirting first round the wire of the guardpost. Tom

explained that he did this to protect the villagers from themselves. We were actually seen only by the inner ring of his supporters (which meant about thirty people). If we had walked in by daylight the general chatter might ultimately have reached the Germans with possible ill effects for the village, but at night the guardpost of ten men were certain to keep well behind their own shutters. They made no move to look out, when all the dogs in the village as usual announced our arrival.

We were taken first to the house of one of the men who had brought me. He was a young peasant with three or four children. Although the one room was miserably bare, they at once sat us down on the only two wicker-work chairs and poured out glasses of raki. They were obviously delighted that we had come to them first. Although much of their life was pure primitive drudgery, it was in fact with the very poorest that we felt most at home. With them, it is true, conversation dried up completely at times, but then we would all sit, it might be in a stable or possibly at some wayside rendezvous beside a chapel or spring, with long silences but curiously without awkwardness.

The centre of the particular village, in which we were, was the village priest, and evidently he and Tom were firm friends. He was, indeed, an excellent nucleus of resistance in himself, being as a priest someone whom the Germans were reluctant to molest, and having some six or seven sons, who could be relied upon as messengers or guides, and who with their attendant first, second, and third cousins constituted in themselves an admirable framework for resistance or information groups throughout the surrounding villages.

Of that evening I remember only that some dozen or more of the leading men in the village sat down at a long table in too small a room, which became violently hot as we consumed first olives and cheese, then the eyes and

more intimate entrails of a sheep, then most of the sheep itself, and finally bulky gobbets of pig, roast with the skin. I suppose I was very tired physically. At any rate my stomach which by this time was usually only too eager to grind up anything, for once refused to function, and for the rest of that night I suffered excruciating indigestion. However we had to walk on down the valley some four hours after the party ended. It was a still starlit night and the walking and the fresh air helped to loosen up my intestines. After a sleep next day I felt mercifully vigorous and, as usual in the mountains, full of health and keen to be off. A runner had come to Tom with news that the charging engine would be dropped to us in Lasithi in four days. This gave me just enough time to make the journey back and prepare for the drop—if there were no delays on the way.

This time I said good-bye to Tom without any gloomy foreboding that we might not meet again. In fact it seemed that at any time we could walk over to each other in a day or two from our respective mountain ranges. Tom gave me as a guide a young Greek gendarme, Antonios Zoidakis, who, after coming (rightly) under suspicion from the Germans, had left the police station from which he had been helping us and joined Tom permanently in the hills. The first day we skirted the southern flanks of Ida, and passed the aerodrome of Tymbaki. We made excellent time that day, but by midday Zoidakis was far from well. I could see that this was no sham illness, put on because he wished to go slower, and looking back on it, I think his performance was a most remarkable one. By the second day he said that he had jaundice. By the third day he was as yellow as a canary. I knew little or nothing about jaundice except that you needed rest and a light diet, but I had to get on.

Zoidakis said that he would be all right, once he could

get to a village where there was an old crone who knew the cure for Jaundice. He fully believed that the right thing to do was to cut the tendon inside the patient's mouth beneath the upper lip. Where this hocus pocus originated I never discovered, but it is a firm belief among many Cretan villagers, who say that the job can only be done by certain old people, to whom the skill has been handed down apparently from the days of Aesculapius. I checked this later with a Greek doctor, who said there was no scientific basis for the belief whatever; but I suppose that by the time a Greek villager normally gets to the right medicine woman, the jaundice is already on the mend. At any rate I have met several Cretans who have had a tendon inside their mouths slit in this way, and Zoidakis had complete faith that it would make him well again. Meanwhile he would finish the job—and in fact he stuck it for a full day more, although visibly far too weak to do anything but lie flat on his back.

We had by this time collected Aristeides Christouphakis at his home in the plain of Herakleion. Next day about noon, after a long wearisome drag uphill, we reached the headquarters; but of George and the rest of the party there was no sign. I had half expected this, and we found one of the shepherds, who told us that George had moved to the other side of the upland plain to be near the site of the drop. It was only two hours away by day, but darkness was falling and Zoidakis looking ghastly, so I decided to wait and make the last lap at dawn. Next morning we found the party without mishap. It was good to see George again after some ten days.

George knew enough Greek, or at any rate had gathered enough of what went on around him, to understand that the date of a drop must be kept secret. If we had told even our trusted party a few days in advance, we should have had half their cousins from their respective

villages present to take a share, and even as it was the number of local shepherds around our cave doubled that evening.

As the twilight set in we went out to prepare firewood for the warning fires.

By nightfall we had stacked three piles of furze and wood in a triangle at the bottom of a flat open space which I had previously chosen as a good dropping area. The rocks rose all round it so that the fires could not be seen from the valley, but that was almost its only advantage. A space some hundred and fifty yards each way near the top of a mountain, where the wind was likely to be strong, was far too small. However, we settled down hopefully in our cave nearby. The aeroplane was not due for a couple of hours. Shortly afterwards something droned overhead and I thought it might be the plane arriving early, but it seemed to pass over the mountain once only and disappear. We took up positions by the fires and waited. It was a cloudy night. At times I could only see a few yards, and there was enough wind to deaden the sound of the other watchers stirring impatiently. Down in the valley it must have been still, but up there I feared that the wind was blowing too strongly, and that the parachutes might well drift far and wide. Then the clouds broke and I could see the dark figures beside the other heaps of firewood, calling occasionally to one another just for company. It was a lonely spot, away even from the few tracks that crossed Mount Tsivi. On such occasions men moved stealthily, although there could be no fear of an enemy nearby, and no wild animals who would attack us—and sometimes I wondered if this watchfulness when there was no logical cause for it, was not really a relic of the animal past, that came naturally in the wilder places. Such hours on the roof of the mountains with their dark motionless shapes, while clouds loomed darkly between

them, made me reflect again, that the war had brought us a long way from what we had known as civilised life.

At times a man would stamp on the rocks to keep warm, pulling down the sleeves of his cloak to cover his hands, and then hugging them about him or slapping his sides like a cabby. When there was light enough to see, he looked like a scarecrow dancing in the wind. But soon most of the party had lain down in some crevice near the piles of firewood, rising stiffly to listen when there was a pause in the sighing of the wind, but stirring less and less often.

Once zero hour was past, the excited expectations of the men turned into depressed doubt. It was a chilled and miserable party that crawled back some four hours later into a draughty and comfortless cave.

But it was just at such times that the capabilities of the men could best be judged. The hanger-on who had come for loot was shown up clearly enough, and I remember how warmly I felt on one such occasion towards one of the youngest in the party—Jason, known in despatches naturally enough as the Argonaut. He was an adventurous unselfish youth. One night when the work was at a standstill, and food and tempers short, and some wordy squabble had ended in sullen silence, he suddenly looked round the cave and said with a smile, "I think it's time we sang a song."

He had a pleasant voice himself and singing was one of the best things to do in a cave after dark, when the flickering oil wicks made reading, and most other pastimes, a difficult and even painful process.

The depression of a night spent merely waiting for an aeroplane or a boat which never appeared, did not usually last for long, and on this occasion we were cheered by a wireless message next morning, which told us that the plane had been held up by the weather, and was due

to try again that very evening. Although in the course of the day the party grew unaccountably, we were still only about a dozen by nightfall. Anyone who came to us, learnt somehow that a drop was imminent and found an excuse to stay; I was not really sorry. Unless the party got considerably larger, I felt that I could control the collection of the vital stores—of which the most essential was the charging engine. We were also expecting a good supply of dehydrated food, which I believed would greatly aid security through the winter. It would make it unnecessary to arrange for local food supplies to be brought to us along tracks which should by witner have been deserted.

We had removed the brushwood when we left the dropping area the night before, but it was back in place and well stacked as dusk fell. This time even a few minutes before zero hour we heard the sound of a plane approaching. Unfortunately there seemed more wind, but we could hear the sound of the engine growing louder and louder, and I remember straining and straining, though completely in vain, to see it. It appeared to come straight over the top of the mountains, and at first I hesitated to order the fires to be lit, expecting it to circle. Then there was an agonising moment or two, while we struggled in the wind to get our fires alight, but we had dropped a little of our precious petrol on the wood, and after a few seconds the fire by which I was standing and the other two corners of the triangle had shot into flame. For a second or two the dropping area seemed as bright as day. I had just time to realise that the plane was now right above us, and to remember as it passed on that the pilot would be looking well ahead, and probably had not seen us. In a few seconds he would be over the crest of Mt. Selena, north of us, and might well waste his time reconnoitering the gullies and hollows of that horny

mountain straight over the German wireless station on its summit. The Germans there had only anti-aircraft machine guns and in the dark could hardly do the plane much damage, but either they or any enterprising Greek shepherd might well have the sense to light a fire of their own. By that time the dropping technique was well known.

By this time our own fires had died down again almost as suddenly as they had flared up, but the wind, though it made the wood burn too rapidly, helped to keep them alight, and we all stoked away energetically. Meanwhile the first eager shouts of delight had given way to anxiety. The hollow was no longer bright, and the three fires seemed to be burning in a great empty black space. They seemed no more than a triangle of Guy Fawkes bonfires, but the dark figures that were outlined springing about them or brandishing a shepherd's staff were quite different from any English village figures in November. Against the surrounding emptiness and blackness and the mountain height and vastness, I should hardly have been surprised to see horns sprouting through the black head-bands and tails curling round their legs. The scene in fact looked like some horrific mediaeval illustration of little devils dancing round their braziers in a vast subterranean blackness, while awaiting in impatient jubilation the arrival of the damned.

The plane was now almost out of hearing, but just as I was beginning to face the appalling possibility that it had flown straight by and missed us, merely because I had been too late with the signal, it began to drone more loudly again. Evidently it was coming back, and I could tell from the shouts of the men that their always mercurial spirits were surging suitably skywards. Then my doubts vanished. The plane droned straight overhead. The fires were well ablaze. It must, I felt sure, have seen us. All

our straining to catch a glimpse of some darker shadow as it swept by was wasted in the blackness, but I felt that at any moment some drifting parachute shape would come swaying into view and welcome canisters would be thumping about our ears.

The plane flew on, its droning almost drowned in the wind. Someone called out in dramatic tones, "Perhaps it's an enemy." Men at times took a masochistic pleasure in such sudden scarifying changes of mood. However the party as a whole were now too confident to be perturbed by any such nonsense. The only trouble was that nothing had happened. I consoled myself with the thought that the pilot on this second run had probably been confirming our location, and that he would now come back to begin the drop; and, sure enough, in a few minutes the sound was back again, still high up, but straight on the line for us. It was like the exquisite moment when a long-unsuccessful fisherman suddenly feels a tremendous jerk on the float, without being able to see what is happening. But again there followed utter bathos when the plane flew by and nothing happened. This time there could be little doubt that something was wrong. There was not even a distant warning crash from the rocks round our hollow. Apparently for some reason best known to himself, the pilot had decided not to drop anything.

After that we had a tantalising three quarters of an hour while the plane still circled over our mountain high in the air. The fires died down, and there were frantic scurryings in the dark to find more brushwood. The only things suitable were little holm-oak bushes, which merely shrouded everything in smoke. However we evidently kept enough glow in the fires to direct the pilot, for he came over us six or seven times. Each time I thought he had gone for good, and then the men's spirits would rise again as we heard the sound of the engine growing, till finally it died

away altogether to the south. It was again an utterly dejected and weary party that clambered back into our cave. On nights like this when men were tired and clumsy, the entrance always seemed to be particularly low, narrow and jagged.

Next morning we were up early, to find the mountain shrouded in a white mist. As it turned out, providence was kind to us. It was much too dense for the mountain to be observed by field glasses from below or by reconnaissance planes from above, but thin enough to let us move about ourselves. So we scattered over the crest as quickly as we could in the knowledge that, if after all anything had fallen, the shepherds might bring us bits and pieces, but would certainly ransack everything which they could find before us.

But there were no high hopes; we had heard absolutely nothing the night before. So it was an exciting moment when I suddenly heard out of the mist a loudly echoing call, sounding like a Cretan version of "Tallyho!" As I scrambled towards it, I could hear several others clattering over the rocks, and in a few minutes most of our little band of dim misty-grey scarecrows had converged round the ruddy square figure of the senior guide, Gregory Khnarakis. One of the shepherds had shown him, half a mile away, a badly dented canister which they could not open. It disgorged tommy guns and ammunition, wrapped in some even more welcome and beautifully warm woollen blankets, bearing a trademark from Peebles.

Before the war I stayed in Peebles with a schoolfriend member of the Thorburn family, who ran the woolmills there, so to sit on top of a pile of blankets, almost on the top of the mountain, felt most pleasantly like receiving an almost personal gift from more peaceful days.

Soon we had discovered three more canisters, and about the same time George received a message from Cairo

saying that in all thirty-two canisters or crates had been dropped. I had an anxious day trying to ensure that the vital stores were not stolen, but everyone else had the most enjoyable and exciting of treasure hunts, until the evening, when the shepherds began to bring in rumours, that the Germans had learnt of the drop and were on the way to search for us. This seemed only too likely, for the sixteen canisters which we found had fallen over an area of about five square miles, and the rest had apparently plunged even further afield over the lower slopes. Their arrival was said to have been reported to the Germans at once, because one of them had landed through the roof of a half-constructed chapel in a small hamlet at the foot of the mountain, where all the inhabitants had naturally crowded round. As all the canisters bore in large white Greek letters, the legend: "If found, hand this over to the allied officers, to whom it belongs," the arrival of this particular canister in the centre of his domain was too much for the local mayor, who knew that the story would spread like wildfire, and that when the Germans heard it, he would be held responsible. After a heated village conclave, the mayor insisted—I think understandably enough—on reporting the canister to the Germans and in the end the Germans were said to have found eight—largely empty.

Meanwhile I could see from the energy with which the shepherds were working to hide traces of the drop, and even more from the look of anxiety on the face of the oldest and toughest of them, that the stories of Germans approaching were more than rumour. Fortunately there were plenty of good crevices where the stores could be hidden, and Mikhali, the shepherds' leader, disclosed one magnificent hide for empty canisters. It was a hole which no stranger could have discovered, for it was covered by projecting holm-oaks even if you looked down into it from a

cliff above. We could hear the canisters crashing downwards into the depths of the mountain, and I wonder how many centuries it will be before some cave explorer disinters their battered shells, and proves that the less fortunate outlaws and shepherds, whose skeletons will doubtless be found there too, knew at least the art of welding iron and of making alliances and writing about them in white paint.

By this time the light was fading. We had found sixteen canisters and a most welcome supply of food, blankets, warm clothing, and small arms, but no sign of a charging engine. This, however, was no longer vital. There seemed no chance that we could go on searching next day, so, as night fell, with the rumours of approaching Germans becoming more and more insistent, we took such arms and clothing as we could carry, and made off, leaving the holes and crannies on Mt. Tsivi preposterously stuffed with bundles of army pants, and the wizened stumps of a rich store of dehydrated carrots.

Most of this we were able to collect and cache more securely during the next week, and from then onwards I was glad to think that we had a very adequate food supply to last throughout the worst winter months, until the goats began to give milk in abundance in the early spring. My own particular helpers had now plenty of winter clothing, boots and small arms, for which they were deeply grateful, although the distribution of some of this led in the next week or two to some tiresome and ferocious squabbles and jealousies. I had also a reserve of spare garments to bestow on useful friends. I felt from then on that my own influence increased perceptibly.

There were also several curious after-effects. For instance, some weeks later a shepherd presented us with a brand new charging engine. I accepted this gratefully. By local standards it would, I knew, be shockingly bad form to ask questions. At Easter another shepherd, who

lived further off, and was unknown to us except by name, suddenly appeared at the headquarters with a donkey-load of potatoes and wine. He was wearing a new pair of British army boots. I was also pleased to learn later that the silk from the parachutes was being put to good use. One of the men told me confidentially that in the nearby villages the shepherdesses, who were normally clad in the drabbest and scruffiest of black rags or Italian waterproof cape material with a mottled yellow, brown, and green camouflage design, had suddenly been blessed with yellow silk underwear. I felt once again that the drop had struck a blow for British prestige.

Chapter Nine ♣

By this time George and I had been two months in Crete and I was beginning to see better how our work might develop. In the first place it was clear that we could go almost anywhere and with the full blessing of the Cretans. I was confident, therefore, that whatever happened we could reach one of the other British groups in a few days, so that even if our own wireless was captured or destroyed and ourselves on the run, we should sooner or later be able to get in touch again with Cairo.

Meanwhile the intelligence work, thanks to Kosta Loubounes, a civil engineer in Neapolis, and to George Khaniotakis, who ran a small transport business in Ierapetra, was proceeding excellently. Through them and their many sub-agents, several of whom were interpreters or typists in German offices, I had received a complete layout of the Germans in East Crete, together with exact positions for fixed batteries. From particulars or sketches of the guns and of the few tanks which there were, we knew too the types of weapon, and we had been told and been able to check within a day or two, the units or parts of units which had been moved from Lasithi, to take part in the Dodecanese fighting. With even a single keen and reasonably intelligent helper in each village where Germans were stationed, it was ludicrously easy to learn their battle order, and I don't think that any significant change occurred in it, without the news being brought to one or other of the wirelesses in a matter of hours rather than days.

The fifth column work had so far made no progress at all, but I thought that from then onwards I should be able to devote more time to it; Kosta Loubounes had informed me that several of the political leaders in Neapolis wanted

to meet a British officer. There were two ways in which we might have planned the resistance. Either we could have built up a large bandit force in the hills as Bandouvas had done—a plan which was likely to end in disaster, unless timed as part of an allied plan to invade—or we could prepare a secret organisation of men who would stay in their villages and be ready to join under local leaders, if and when an opportunity offered.

It was clear that there were any number of patriotic or merely hungry peasants who would gladly form bands in the hills, but I had no intention of encouraging men to come without the early prospect that they would be needed to fight. In fact my instructions were at this time to avoid building up any large band, and during the first two or three months I often turned away good men. I did, though, badly want by this time to interview the local political leaders, and also those officers from the gendarmerie or former Greek national army, who were likely to help. Through them I hoped to build up the nucleus of a fifth column, without arming it for the present. This would mean constant journeying round the district—in particular, I should have to visit the eastern-most part of Crete, Siteia, which would take ten days at least—but all this might be combined with plans for future sabotage, and also encouragement to caique skippers to leave for the Middle East. Such journeyings should also be useful politically. Although the Cretans were confident by the end of 1943 that we were winning, everyone always longed to hear that the war was going well, and the sight of a British officer among them in their own garb was a good way to keep them cheerful—and also anglophile. Already it was clear that the communists had increased their influence during the occupation, and that the communist leaders could not be relied upon to co-operate with us in any resistance work. So both from

the point of view of the war, and of the aftermath, there seemed good reason to make our presence known to as many Greeks as possible.

I had already a long list of journeys to make and men to interview, although these plans were to be frequently interrupted. Owing to the slowness of travel on foot, it took nearly a month before the new headquarters, which we had to set up after the drop, was established, with the food dumped near to it, and runners in touch with their contacts.

During the first fortnight of this time I was journeying about the Lasithi mountains with a series of wildly over-optimistic guides in search of a new cave.

I soon got to know the essential points. Most people probably think of caves as having a flat sandy bottom, on which you can stand easily, with a high open mouth, through which you can see a pleasant expanse of ocean. Such caves did exist along the coast of Crete, but the mountain caves were normally more like an awkward cleft in the hillside, with a rocky irregular floor, which had to be covered with such shrubs and blankets as we could collect, before we could sit down or lie on it with any ease. Most of the caves in which I lived, were chosen because they were near springs and not too far away from our centres of information. The entrance had to be reasonably concealed, and not too awkward to get through, which meant that one had a view of rocks or pines a few feet in front of it, (but far enough away to let in some light.) You needed a hole in the roof to let out the smoke, but that would also let in the rain or snow in the nastier months, when we lived largely "indoors". The best cave (which I lived in for over two months) had a vent for the smoke which we knocked in the roof at one side, so that the rain, when it came in, merely drained down one wall away from our bedding. Altogether I would not recommend cave life for the elderly or rheumatic, but I came

to enjoy its oddities and humours, and so, I think, did George Dilley, who in the manner of an old soldier, soon knew how to doss down comfortably enough. For several weeks he used a bag of curry powder, which had arrived by parachute, as a pillow.

It was curious how quickly you became fond of a cave. Almost always when it was time to leave, I felt positively sorry to be moving on. To crawl out of the aperture, and look back as you finally walked away, was like closing the door on a home, which you were sad to be leaving for good. In fact I felt more sentimentally nostalgic about caves than about former homes. Coming back to a cave and stopping for a night, was like living again in a room where you had lived a long time; for each had its own idiosyncrasies and each one had accumulated memories of sudden passions flaring up between the men, or sudden frights when an unknown voice called through the entrance, and the relief when the voice turned out to be somebody's cousin. There were high caves where you could sing round the supper, and low caves that were usually warm, but made your eyes smart with the smoke, if you had to light a fire. Some caves were as dry as the inside of a Pharaoh's tomb; in others the walls dripped perpetually. Each had its peculiar nooks and crannies. There was the ledge on which Jason and I used to play chess, with a piece of squared paper for decoding telegrams as the board, with other squares of paper for the pieces, until someone, curious to watch the game, would crane towards us and with well-meaning but heavy garlic-scented breath blow the pieces away. There was a crevice in another just beside the entrance, where we concealed a large wheelshaped cheese even from the shepherds, and there were smaller crevices, where gold could be left secure and dusted over with the accumulated earth and grime from the floor.

Several of the caves we were told had been used by other outlaws before us, men who had taken to the mountains after defying the Turks, or perhaps merely criminals running from their own law, who had lived for a time off sheepstealing, and formed a gang—for no one could live the outlaw cave life for long alone.

By mid-December I had made many weary journeys, but had only found one good cave. Unfortunately this was close to a path, which at that time of year was still frequented by peasants from the surrounding villages, and our local friends insisted that whereas the nearest village was loyal, the one beyond it contained several open collaborators. If our presence became village gossip there, the Germans would certainly hear of it and hunt us out. Part of this talk by our friends was no doubt due merely to local rivalry, but I was still impressed by the possibility of "traitors", and reluctantly decided that for the present we had best stay in the hut, to which we had originally made our way for a few days after the drop. It, too, was conspicuous, but the Germans, after sending planes circling over us on the first clear day after the drop, had shown no further interest in us, and I felt that we could stay there safely enough until the snowline came down. That would make the runners' tracks to and from the hut dangerously obvious, but by that time the good new cave which I had found should be safe enough.

I was about to set off on a round of visits when, as often happened, the political work was interrupted by more immediate and definite instructions. A cryptic message arrived from Tom telling me that Paddy Leigh-Fermor was about to return to Crete by parachute, in order to abduct one of the German generals. I was to find a good dropping area and receive him.

This was no easy task at that time of year. I knew by then that a considerably larger area was needed for

dropping than I had originally supposed, and men dropping would need an even greater area for safety than canisters. There were two excellent plateaus in the Lasithi mountains, and one of them was on our doorstep, but this one was still too populated and too accessible to the Germans at that time of year. The other was almost at the top of Mount Dikte, about six thousand feet up. Paddy had received supplies there in the summer, but it was no place to wait about, possibly for a week, at the end of December. Still, the winter came late that year. The weather had not yet finally broken, so I determined to try it, and after a first reconnaissance decided that if the deep snow held off, it would still be possible.

So I returned to Mount Dikte a few days later to wait for Paddy to drop. It was after the first fall of snow, and I had with me a young Greek officer, a depressing companion, as he was understandably convinced that the effort was wasted. I stayed till the last possible moment by the set, and then we made a long day's march up the mountain to catch up the rest of the party, who had gone ahead and were to wait for us in a shepherd's hut. I had never been to this particular hut, but nearing the summit in the growing twilight we saw it near the crest in front of us, and pressed on to reach it just before the light failed. Most of the day it had rained, sleet or melting snow, but now it became colder and the snow set steadily in for the night. Crunching up to the door we realised that what should have been a flat roof of branches, bracken, and peat sods, had been stove in, and that the hut was one of those which the Germans had demolished in the summer in the reprisals against Bandouvas. Of our party there was no sign.

It was already too dark to search for them, so in deepening dejection we gathered such damp sticks as could be found, and some relatively dry leaves, and then one by one watched our small store of matches fizzle out. After

that we just crawled under one end of the roof which still hung together. It covered most of us but continued throughout the night persistently and icily dripping. By this time relations between myself and my companion had become about as frigid as the hut itself, but it is impossible not to remain on speaking terms with someone, if you badly need the warmth of his body, and we found that by lying still, like a couple of lovers in each other's arms, we could keep most of our bodies from the damp. In spite of this extreme physical intimacy, I felt that we maintained throughout the night the stiff mental aloofness of a couple of chilly waxworks.

By next morning the snow was deep, and I knew that we would neither be able to wait for Paddy on the plateau nor keep in touch with the set. I managed to find the hut where the rest of the party had spent the night, but they were already on their way back to the set, thinking that we had failed to reach them—so that day we wearily made our way back by devious routes. It was a relief to find the message waiting for us, to say that Paddy's party would not be arriving until the following noon. By that time, I knew, the plateau near our set would be sufficiently deserted and we could take the drop there.

Meanwhile we had received a telegram in reply to the first written reports, which I had sent at the end of October, but which owing to delays and mischances in the meeting of boats, had only just reached Cairo. The telegram arrived on Christmas morning and was seasonably complimentary. It acted as an excellent Christmas present to the whole party.

* * * *

We were lying one evening on the floor of the hut—cushioned snugly on the sixty or so square yards of a couple of yellow silk parachutes, but keeping near the ground as the roof of the hut was full of smoke, and I had

been asking two of the younger members of the party what they had learnt at school about England. One of them said that in English lessons they were taught about Lord Byron, who had come to Greece to fight for Greek independence. Partly to assure me that this was really so, and partly to demonstrate that he knew the poem, he began haltingly to recite a few lines of "The Isles of Greece". I began to help him out; then, warming to it, together we declaimed:

"The Isles of Greece! The Isles of Greece
Where burning Sappho loved and sung,
Where grew the arts of war and peace,
Where Delos rose, and Phoebus sprung!
Eternal summer gilds them yet,
But all, except their sun, is set."

There was nothing very like eternal summer about the snowy night outside, but when we got to "The mountains look on Marathon" we were more in our own element, and after that amid the growing excitement and delight of the Greeks, who were quick to catch an emotion, we skipped half a dozen verses and with a feeling that after all we too, however bogus, were also a tiny party against enormous odds, we raced on to the "three hundred", and declaimed with gay earnest defiance, and in full flood and fervour:

"Of the three hundred grant but three,
To make a new Thermopylae!"

It was at this point that I noticed George, who, of course, could understand the words better than any of the others, staring wonderingly at us, a distinct smile in his eyes.

About now there were the first signs of what Tom shortly afterwards noticed to my astonishment as the beginnings of *esprit de corps*. He had seen the same thing in other parties, but it seemed absurd to apply so highflown a term to any group with such a complete absence of spit

and polish. Nevertheless from the way in which the men began to speak of others who were not regular members, or of the shepherds or villagers, it became obvious that the party itself was acquiring a rough-and-ready but self-respecting entity of its own.

Meanwhile, having received the message that there was to be a month's interval before Paddy's arrival, I decided to do a reconnaissance of bays along the south coast. Though this was a ponderous subterfuge, the journey should prevent any of the Greeks in the party, and therefore all our local friends, from guessing that Paddy was in fact coming by air to the particular plateau which I had in mind. I had been expecting a visit from Tom, but his last message, which had taken about a week to reach me, said that he had to postpone his journey, so I spent the next week walking in and out of little bays, several of which turned out to be possible landing places. After that my guide, Manoli Aggelakis, and I were both looking forward to a couple of days' rest on the way back at the home of his cousin George Metaxakis, who was also a member of the party. George was a well-educated young man and I had been told with pride that there was a library in his house. This turned out to be no less than true, for we eventually found in a secluded chalet at some distance from Parsas—one of the most beautiful but poorest villages on the island—a very middle-class-looking bookcase with a number of bound works, mostly encyclopaedias, but including a Shakespeare and some French classics.

But any prospect of a carefree book-wormy holiday was dashed, when we received news from the wireless (some eight hours away) that owing to further changes in Tom's plans Tom had already reached it, and would stay a day or so in the hope that I could return. There was much that I wanted to discuss—helpers who should be sent out to the Middle East; plans for local sabotage; how to tackle

hesitant caique skippers; Paddy's arrival and above all the political work.

So that day Manoli and I made good time back to the headquarters.

In the evening Tom and I arranged to go into Neapolis for a conference with political leaders, and next day Tom, Micky Akoumianakis, myself and two runners went into Neapolis at twilight. We had a long discussion with Mr. Roussos Koundouros, a former deputy, and five or six other prominent men in the town. I still could not understand most of it, but it was useful to be introduced to them as their link with the allied G.H.Q., and I knew that Tom wanted to find out their views, in particular on the chances which a Col. Plevres would have of holding the loyalty of resistance groups in the area, if he was "appointed" military leader and took to the hills. There were objections to Col. Plevres. He had a good record as commander of a brigade in Albania and he had previously been the under-cover military resistance leader for East Crete, but a few months previously he had been arrested and then released; the others arrested with him had been shot. He was clearly a man whom the Germans would watch, and the other Cretan leaders could hardly be expected to co-operate closely with him, at least for the present. This was naturally a ticklish subject, in which the Cretan leaders would speak by innuendo and seldom say exactly what they meant, but it became clear that night that the committee did not want Plevres as the military leader, and were against raising bands in the hills for the time being. For two or three hours Tom talked to them, as they craned round the table. For once they were reasonably well agreed among themselves, so there was no need to urge on them the need to drop local dissensions. As always, they were longing for news of the war. There we could encourage them, and finally it was agreed that they

should pass on the good news to as wide a circle of supporters as possible, but keep their friends in the villages for the present, and await instructions from us.

About 10 p.m. that evening—at the hour, that is, of curfew inside the town, we were spirited out of the meeting, so that the least possible number might know where we were that night. The members of the committee were not really frightened that one or other of themselves might be a German agent, but they did fear that they all, or severally, might be taken hostage and then induced in one way or another to talk, so it was as well that they should know as little of our movements as possible. Actually Roussos Koundouros was arrested some weeks later. He was kept in Herakleion for several weeks, and then executed with five or six other leading Cretans. It was said that in the final stages he confessed to having contact with ourselves, but what happened will probably never be known,

The morning after this meeting we slipped out at first light down a lamentably cobbled street, on which our five pairs of feet seemed to make an intolerable clatter. There were about four hundred Germans garrisoned in the town, but most of them had departed on local exercises. Our own party of five was, however, suspiciously large to be walking out of the town together at dawn, without any apparent purpose, and soon after we had left the houses behind it became apparent that the Germans' exercises were not far off. Shots began to ring out in the valley down which we were walking. Our path led through olive-groves, so it was impossible to see more than a few yards ahead, but it sounded more and more like the closing stages of a field day, when one side was advancing upon the other, using all the blanks it had. Our path would take us half a mile or so down the valley, and then we had to turn sideways out of it to a chapel, where a second guide would meet us. Meanwhile the

shots got closer and closer. The guide, a quiet grey-bearded old patriot, named Bandouvakis, hoped that we should turn out of the valley before they were level with us, and we still could not see any Germans, but an infantry company, or more, must be making a mock attack on Neapolis, through this particular olive-wood. I was myself beginning to feel distinctly squeamish about going any further; but we could not in any case have stopped to discuss what to do, and the guide trudged on quietly, with the four of us silent in line behind him. If we ran into the Germans they would certainly challenge us, and I knew—which the guide did not—that my own papers were not in order. I had at the time a faked identity card, but no photograph on it—the proper one had never been replaced after being lost in the sea on arrival.

A moment later there was a sudden shot immediately in front of the guide and someone called out "Halt" in German. The path was enclosed by a dry stone wall, and from behind it rose a young German private, his helmet festooned with sprays of olive for camouflage. Perhaps he had fired across our bows by coincidence, or perhaps he mistook us for the "enemy". Perhaps he merely wished to frighten us. In any event he certainly did frighten me, but we merely halted, and the guide wished him "Good morning". The German leapt over the wall with something which sounded like a mixture of laugh and curse, but then other shots rang out from behind the olives nearby. It was a thick olive-grove. No one else had seen us yet, and I had time to hope that there was no officer nearby. Anyhow the guide merely walked steadily ahead, and we all followed, without demur from the soldier. As we passed one or two of us wished him "Good day" again in German. My own "Guten Tag" suddenly sounded much too much like student days in Munich, when I had learnt to speak German well—far too well

to sound like a Greek peasant. A few minutes later we were all sitting gaily round a neat little white Chapel, while the exercise rattled and crackled on in the valley beneath us, every moment getting further and further away.

That evening we reached the hospitable and charming village of Kastamonitsa. Tom had told me that we should soon be coming up again with signs of civilisation, and explained that he meant by this a family where the girls entered into conversation instead of standing back, too shy to speak (as though the veil had still not been removed since Turkish days). We spent the night at the home of Tom's guide, Kimon Zographakis—a pleasant change from cave life. Kimon had two extremely pretty sisters, and they and their mother duly and cheerfully fussed over us in the upstairs room of their house, where they gave us a splendid supper. I dare say they enjoyed the romance of our slinking in, dishevelled, and footsore, and I think my own expressions of gratitude in broken Greek amused them; for the first time for some months I realised with dismay how physically filthy I had become. The general glad welcome, however, was all the merrier, because two or three Germans, from a rest house at the edge of the village, came to call on them also that evening. I think it was the younger daughter, Euthymia, then a schoolgirl of about 16, who came upstairs with a broad grin to warn us to keep quiet, while the Germans were pushed quickly and firmly on their way.

But behind the general merriment there was also an example that evening of the sudden transitions which often occurred from carefree exuberance to deep sorrow. On the wall behind us was a large photograph of a fine-looking young Greek Airforce Officer. I knew that this must be Kimon's elder brother, who a year before had been caught by the Germans, when carrying a message for one of our wireless sets. He had been taken to Herakleion

and then Canea. After that all trace of him was lost. At one point that evening during a lull in the conversation, the mother, a sweet old lady, suddenly but haltingly, asked us some question about the Germans which showed that she was still clinging to the hope that her son was alive. We could, of course, give her no information, and her husband, a handsome white-haired old gentleman, interrupted quickly to spare our embarrassment; the mother said no more, but I saw that she crossed herself, and that Maria, the eldest daughter, who was next in age to the eldest son, was deeply affected. Then we talked on more rapidly perhaps, as though deliberately running away from the pause in the conversation and the thought that the family was no longer all together.

For the rest of the time in Crete I saw much of the Zographakis family. Gregory, the third son, joined my party. Kimon had already successfully guided a commando raid into Kastelli aerodrome the year before, and the two of them continued to act as runners for us throughout the occupation. The father, Mr. George Zographakis arranged our supplies from Herakleion (this was at times a big job) and the womenfolk fed us whenever we came by, cooked, and washed our clothes. It was good after coming down from some hut or cave in the mountains, to find family life continuing affectionately and steadily, in spite of the anxieties of the occupation.

Early next day we went on to the monastery of Angarathos, where Tom was already well known. The Abbot gave us a dignified and most hospitable welcome, but we were soon off again to visit Col. Plevres, who had asked Tom whether he should go into hiding, in order to set himself up as the military leader for Lasithi. Even before our talks with the committee in Neapolis, Tom had decided that Plevres should be politely dissuaded from this, but we wanted at the same time to keep him as well disposed to

us as possible. If we found we could safely work with him, he would probably be far the best available military leader later on. During this interview we were very much on the watch, as there was always the possibility that the Germans were keeping closely in attendance upon Plevres; in any case, if he remained in his home he might again be taken hostage. We found him, however, living normally in his house not far from Herakleion, surrounded by his family, apparently unwatched, and continuing the life of a round red-faced retired regular officer. In Greece, however, senior officers hardly resemble the British model, most of them being immersed in politics and highly adept at that. Tom, who is himself a Fellow of All Souls, had described Plevres as "terrifyingly clever", so I was painfully aware that the interview would call for extreme quickness of wits. In the event, however, it all passed off with friendliness. Plevres wanted to take to the hills, but if so, argued that he must know in advance what arms we could give him. In the circumstances Tom naturally avoided giving him any indication of what arms we had or were expecting, although he gave an impression of immense confidence in the allies' position generally.

One disconcerting fact came to light during these peregrinations. It became clear that one of my men had been keeping Plevres posted about my movements. Indeed it was one of the minor difficulties of the job that our immediate helpers, although normally loyal and friendly to us, sometimes owed a primary allegiance to a local boss, who might or might not be dependable.

That evening Tom and I returned to the monastery and then left in opposite directions for our respective mountains. I was now eager for the next job—to welcome Paddy and his party, and on the way back realised suddenly that if I were now ordered to leave Crete, I should be curiously sorry.

Chapter Ten ♣

On my return I found the party settled in a new cave, and George and I, who alone knew of Paddy's plan, were naturally all eager for final news. I can see George still, squatting in front of his set with knees bent, back hunched, and earphones on his head like an eastern priest bowing forward to conduct some mysterious ritual.

We got the message confirming Paddy's arrival about 4 p.m. on the day he was due, and it was still a complete surprise to the Greeks when I explained, much to their delight, that we were to go up to the plateau, locally called the Omalo, between Kritsa and Lasithi that same night.

We set off before twilight and were collecting the firewood when the first contretemps occurred. One of the men had discovered two Greeks watching us from a deserted hut. They had come up ostensibly to catch hares, and I would have attached them at once to the party, if Christo had not assured me that they were both well-known in their village as collaborators. Two or three of the party would, in fact, gladly have shot them then and there, but even if I had contemplated that, it would ultimately, I knew, have led to a much more serious risk of betrayal through their families, since the tradition of vendetta is still a living one in Crete. In the end they were detained in their hut until we left, and then given as biting a warning to keep their mouths shut, as the most vehement member of the party could supply. If in fact they talked later, as seemed probable, it was too late to matter, since everybody in the neighbourhood knew by next day what we had been at.

The moon was now rising, but scattered clouds from time to time threw the silent expanse of the Omalo into

darkness. Exactly at zero hour we heard the plane approaching. We had made bigger fires this time and at once they blazed away. The plane began to circle and soon it got lower and much louder. Then against a moonlit bank of cloud we saw it clearly, as if benevolently hovering over us. At that moment, much to my disgust, it let loose a flare. We never discovered why, but as far as I could see, that can only have helped to show the Germans that the plane had some unusual illicit purpose over our particular mountain. I thought how filthily artificial the little pink star looked as it flickered out in the middle of that dark wild scene, like the last dismal dropping of a spent firework over some seaside pier at home. Then the plane circled again, with a white cloud behind it. I saw what looked like a little puff of smoke leave it. The plane flew on and was lost to view, and suddenly the puff of smoke had changed into a tiny marionette dancing beneath a billowing shred of fabric that blew out as we gazed at it, into the graceful circle of a parachute. It looked so frail and lonely against the night sky that I felt momentarily sorry for the human being dangling beneath, who was dropping swiftly into what must look to him like an infinite black emptiness. Not that there was any need, I knew, to expend any pity on Paddy Leigh-Fermor, who was not likely to be frightened by loneliness or the dark.

Although we had passed a few feet from one another on the night of my arrival, when he had taken out the Italian General Carta, we had never actually met, so I had determined beforehand that I should stride up to him in the true Livingstone tradition, stretch out a hand, and exclaim: "Mr. Leigh-Fermor, I presume." However, the men were already rushing gaily towards the descending body, and about fifteen yards above them a voice called out sharply in the darkness: "Is it all right down there?" "Yes!" I roared, but in the general commotion

I doubt if he heard. A second more and he had fallen on top of two or three Greeks, who were hauling him up and trying to grasp him by the hand. "It's Captain Livermore" one of them shouted in delight. "Are you all right?" I asked, but we were already shaking hands vigorously. He had made a perfect landing. I don't exactly remember his first words—some form of cheerful greeting—but almost at once he asked for water. It is a curious thing how thirsty parachuting makes people. Unfortunately knowing that we should have much to carry back, we had by then emptied our water-bottles, and Paddy had to wait another three hours or so before we reached the cave.

Meanwhile the plane was coming round again. There were still three men to drop—Stanley Moss, who had never been to Crete before, and two Cretans, Manoli Paterakis and George Tirakis, both tough young mountaineers, who had worked loyally with Paddy for months already. (Manoli's father in his youth had carried off his mother in the romantic local style. Their six sons all helped us.) The plane was also to drop a few canisters with some special stores including German uniforms for Paddy and Stanley. So Paddy by himself, though more than welcome, was far from complete. If we could not get them all that night, what with the uncertainty of weather, the tell-tale flare, and the complete certainty that after the first night the security of the operation would be blown sky high, I felt that the drop on any later night would be far less likely to succeed.

But up above, apparently, the wind was rising. Against the mountain crests around us, the clouds seemed to be driving deliberately this way and that, and then a mass of cloud gathered and in a moment or two had blown across the moon. Suddenly we could see nothing. What was worse, there were more and more clouds blowing up. We could hear the aeroplane still low above us, snoring away

like some lumbering blind monster. Sometimes the wind blew the sound down to us really loud, and then it seemed as though the plane must surely be seen, and another parachute come flickering out of it—but in fact the clouds only grew denser. The pilot must have done his utmost, for he seemed to stay over us for about forty minutes, but the clouds had now closed in over the whole Omalo and finally the sound of the engine died away.

On the way back I was so delighted to have Paddy with me, that I hardly regretted the rest of the party. Indeed the sudden arrival of someone who could talk on any subject under the sun made all the difference. Almost all the next six or seven weeks, although I did not know it then, we were to spend together in the same cave, waiting for the plane.

Throughout all this time I could hardly have had a more cheerful companion than Paddy, or a better guide to all things Cretan. For all his literary tastes and background, he was clearly wrapped up in his war job, and his touch with the locals seemed to me absolutely perfect. It was, for instance, delightful to hear him become immersed with one of the runners in an enthusiastic discussion about the different types of patch to put on the heel or toe or instep of a Cretan jackboot (a most technical and important subject), and a few minutes later to find oneself plunged with him in some swift, equally enthusiastic and cheerful wrangle about the relative merits of Stephen Spender or Louis Macniece. We had no books and must have been an odd sight playing such innocent games as Consequences on the cave floor beneath a couple of wick lights.

But best of all was the singing. Paddy could sing folksongs in half a dozen languages, but mostly he would sing with the rest of us the local songs, in particular "Philadem", the old Turkish tune which became a form of

code-name for him with the Cretans. In fact, throughout the length and breadth of the island they would refer to him as "the Philadem"—as a Highlander might speak of "the Mackintosh".

We often sang the lovely ballad about the girl from Samos—"Samiotissa"—which, when Paddy had taught me nine or ten verses—more than most Cretans knew—became a theme song, as it were, of my own. "And in your boat golden sails will I set, and silver oars, Girl of Samos, to bring you home"; and when we had sung this and many others there would be French songs, and more quietly Paddy would sing the Raggle Taggle Gipsies. Or, as the evening wore on, George would continue with the songs he had sung on Saturday nights in pubs at home—"The Farmer's Boy", or "The Lincolnshire Poacher", or "I'll go no more a-Roaming", for that we could all roar out in chorus and the Greeks soon learned the tune and loved it.

There was a curious, even macabre episode during that period of waiting. One evening an old shepherd came in to tell us that two ex-gendarmes had captured a traitor and wished to hand him over. They arrived with the man shortly afterwards, themselves dressed in German uniforms. They had caught him completely red-handed by just the type of cunning ruse which would, no doubt, have delighted their ancestor, Odysseus. Neither of them could speak or understand a word of real German, but by listening to Germans in odd cafés, they had learnt to imitate the words. They gave us an exhibition later, and although not a single sentence had meaning, they could "converse" in what would certainly sound like German to a Greek peasant—something like this:

"Jawohl, Heinz, Donner und Blitz, Mein Gott!

"Oberfeldwebel, Kartoffel Nicht?"

"Krieg Wein Lili Marlene—und so weiter!"

They had then donned German uniforms, of which

there were plenty hidden away in Crete at that time, approached their quarry talking "German" heartily, and "arrested" him on some trumped up charge like black marketeering. In order to ingratiate himself, he at once explained that he was an informer, and obligingly produced papers from the German authorities instructing their units to show him every consideration, and stating that he had the right to carry a pistol. It must have been a grisly moment, when he discovered a second later, that his captors were really Cretans.

We were given the papers, and there could be no doubt at all that the man was in fact a Greek agent of the Germans—indeed he made no attempt to deny it; he was a little man, and as he stood helplessly in the moonlight, with his forearms bound awkwardly together across his chest, he looked as if all hope and desire had gone out of him.

One of the gendarmes said expectantly that they had brought him for examination. He said it with something of a smirk, as though we would relish the prospect, and I had to conceal a momentary loathing at being expected to feel like a mediaeval Tartar chief being presented with a particularly succulent chance for torture. I suppose we should have interrogated him thoroughly, and then beaten him for more, but I don't think Paddy had the stomach for it, and I certainly had not. The man himself appeared to know nothing of German units, and merely said that he knew he must be executed, and asked only to be shot quickly. We told the gendarmes to take him away to a cave nearby, where the body would not be discovered except by the shepherds and then possibly not for months. As they were leaving I sent two of our own most reliable men with them, with instructions that he was not to be tortured but executed immediately. Later one of them told me that they had discovered at the last moment that he was only half Greek, having Turkish

blood in him. Being a Moslem he had asked to kneel down facing east. They had shot him through the head, over a hole at the end of a low cave, which we had used some weeks before, and the body fell into the hole. So far as I know it is there still.

Throughout this time we were going about twice a week by night to the Omalo, but either the plane did not arrive because of storms or anti-aircraft fire, or arrived to find the area covered in cloud. Once it arrived in the early hours long after it was expected, just as we had dispersed the firewood and were moving off. We raced back and Paddy managed to get one fire alight, but the pilot, not seeing the prearranged pattern of fires, flew round for a few minutes and then left us cursing violently in the chill of dawn.

Meanwhile the Germans' interest in us was patently and disturbingly increasing. There were about three hundred Germans in the plain of Lasithi on the far side of the mountain and about five hundred on our side.

On the morning after Paddy arrived, in the first week in February, the Germans, who had seen the plane firing its flare over the Omalo, surrounded and searched the village of Tapais; our cave was between the Omalo and Tapais and our runners were passing regularly through Tapais on their way to and from the main intelligence centres of Neapolis and Agios Nikolaos. The other runners who brought information to the set also called at Tapais for a drink and the latest news on their way up to the cave. Tapais was, therefore, the hub of our communications and the Germans were right in guessing that it was the home of many of our helpers. We were on excellent terms with the mayor and indeed with the whole village, and I feared that the Germans might take hostages, or burn the village; if they did so, apart from the misery which it would cause to our best friends, we should

have to leave what was otherwise a most suitable headquarters, and other villages might understandably be none too eager to give us similar support. However, the Germans did little more that day than give the villagers a bad fright.

After that however, somewhat ominously, the fifty odd Germans in Kritsa—the village next to Tapais—were increased by a hundred, at a time when the German garrison as a whole was dropping. As time went on our more rustic friends wildly inflated this figure till it grew in their accounts to three thousand.

Then after we had been twice to the Omalo in the second week of February, the Germans began to patrol it and occupied the shepherd's hut which we had been living in at Christmas. However the moon had waned, so just then we were staying regularly at home and after a couple of days on the plateau the Germans withdrew again, having learnt, however, as we were told, that "sixty parachutists" had dropped there.

After that all would probably have been well for a time if the plane had not let off another flare, apparently in ignorance of a previous urgent telegram telling it never to do such a thing again.

It seemed certain that the Germans would come again to the Omalo after that, so I wired to the plane not to come the following night. Something went wrong with the message, and the plane then sailed over for once in perfect weather—and for once with no one underneath to light a fire. We expected it again the night after but by that time it had apparently received our message not to come. We were glad not to have to make an unnecessary journey, and should have been even gladder, had we known what was about to happen. Instead we settled down cheerfully for an evening's singing in the warmth of the cave with the wine passing—raw stuff splashed into

a mug, but warming against the frostiness of the mountain in early March.

But that night the singing was interrupted. Somewhere not so very far away we heard a shot, and then as we listened at the cave mouth there were more shots, and in answer an excited burst of fire—and then another and another. The sounds came from possibly half a mile away at the head of the valley. No Germans should have been there then, but it was clearly more than the odd sheep thief firing surreptitiously with a captured pistol. We decided to take turns to do sentry duty near the cave, in case anyone was heard approaching, and then the party bedded down.

Soon after dawn one of the shepherds brought us the news. The night before the Germans had sent one patrol from Kritsa and another from Lasithi. The patrol from Kritsa got into position at the junction between the main muletrack from Kritsa to the Omalo and the footpath which led to it from our cave. Clearly they had accurate information about our movements, for it was the perfect place to set an ambush.

Meanwhile however, that same night the party from Lasithi had come down the muletrack from the Omalo, and when they reached the track junction were challenged by the first party in the dark, but failed to respond properly. They opened fire on each other, killing two and wounding several, and shortly afterwards we had the grim pleasure of watching them from our pinewood carrying the dead and wounded down to Kritsa. From our point of view it was a perfect little operation, for no one could blame the losses on Cretan aid to us.

All the same it was evident that the Germans were getting hot on the trail, and two normally stout-hearted members of the party came to me separately, to say that if the job was not finished at once, or called off, the Germans

in their opinion, would soon find the cave. We were contemplating a telegram that day to say that the party would have to come by sea after all, when we received one ourselves saying that the airdrop had been cancelled and that Moss and the others would be arriving on the next boat.

But peripatetics with our enemies round the Omalo did not end there and then. I decided to leave the area for a time and set off next day to reconnoitre a new headquarters south of the Omalo, which, as far as I knew, was now again deserted. There was much to be done before we were due at the coast to meet the boat, so I determined to return early in the morning, collect the rest of my party and go back again the same day. This was lucky, for it meant that we returned across the Omalo to the cave at early dawn, just as the light was growing, and as it turned out in a slight mist. We were beginning to climb off the plateau up the track which led to the cave, when we heard single shots and then a burst of fire behind us, and later we learnt from Paddy that the Germans had again come up to the Omalo the night before. Three local communist leaders who had called at our cave the previous evening, had set off that morning in the opposite direction to ourselves and had evidently walked into the Germans close to where we had crossed.

Almost immediately after this Mitsi Thrapsaniotis, one of the shepherds, came striding and sloping through the pines from rock to rock—silently as only the shepherds could—to say that in the middle of the night seventy Germans had occupied Tapais. Watching over his sheep from some nocturnal eyrie he had seen them move out at dawn up the path to Voina (a tiny cluster of shepherds' huts halfway between Tapais and the cave). We sent out scouts and almost at once they came running back—they had seen the Germans approaching up the lower mountain slope. There were only about twenty-five of them; one

detachment was coming up the path to the Omalo which branched near the cave, one fork passing straight below it.

Meanwhile we had stowed the stores—half a dozen sacks of dehydrated food, clothes, bandages, and such—under various convenient boulders with a special cranny for the wireless; and prepared for what Paddy described jauntily as "another Oakapple day", to be spent that is, hiding among the holm-oaks in the manner of Charles II. Paddy had already, I believe, spent a quiet day hidden in a cypress, but actually holm-oaks are smaller, stubbier trees than an English oak, and too prickly to sit still in, so on the present occasion, in practice, none of the party climbed into one, as the wood was thick and there were plenty of large rocks and boulders to hide behind. I was feeling excited myself, but several of the Greeks, who normally could work up the most extravert excitement at will, settled down cautiously, almost philosophically, among the rocks, as though they expected to play rather dull and sedentary hide-and-seek for the rest of the day.

The nearest detachment was now making its way up, in single file and in full view, and we could very easily have picked off the lot of them, but that would probably have meant the burning of Tapais and the shooting of any Tapiots they found. I was afraid that one of the younger men might loose off a round. Kimon Zographakis had begun to advise the party in a tremendous stage whisper, how best to ambush and massacre the foe—until he began clambering about to illustrate his strategy, and was told forcefully to shut up.

Meanwhile the Germans clearly knew that we were somewhere near, and were every bit as anxious to avoid us as we were to avoid them. When they had climbed level with the cave they stopped and made a tremendous noise crashing about in the trees, shouting to each other, and giving us in fact no excuse whatever to clash with them

unwittingly. After winding round another path above the cave they settled down for an hour on an adjacent spur, and lit three smoke bombs, as a signal to the second party, which was then on the way to the Omalo. Then we watched them drawing further away towards the Omalo, without ourselves having had to move more than about twenty yards from our own doorstep.

During this time we had been mildly anxious about one of the party, Antoni Papaleonidas, who was due to return across the mountain that morning with messages from Lasithi. It was always possible that they would see him approaching over open ground and then lie in wait on the track he was using, but in the afternoon we heard someone coming hurriedly through the trees. Whoever it was clearly knew the way to the cave, and one of the men called out the password "Nike!"—the Greek word for Victory—and was brusquely and vigorously answered with an "Eleftheria"—"Freedom!", whereupon Antoni hastened up red, weary, and looking somewhat relieved to find us at home. He had been chased on the way by various other patrols, which had come up from Lasithi.

Meanwhile the mist was getting thicker. The afternoon turned cold and wet, and I decided that, even if the Germans did not leave the Omalo, we could slip across it that evening and reach the new headquarters next day. Paddy was to stay the night with two guides, and leave next morning by another route for the coast, where we should meet again a week later. So that evening, with most of the headquarters on our backs, we set off once again up the path to Omalo, as it turned out for the last time.

Before the point where our path joined the main track, where the Germans had tried to ambush us, we halted in the rocky gully, and I sent ahead a cheerful Greek boy, Minos Loulakis, to spy out any sign of Germans.

Almost at once he came rushing back, to say that just

as he was about to break cover and enquire at a hut beside the track, three Germans had emerged on to it about fifty yards in front of him coming from the Omalo. This meant that a patrol was returning, and we raced down the gully, which was treeless, so as not to be caught in open country. We were all heavily laden, but I had in addition a case full of papers and a hidden lump of sovereigns pressing against a kidney, so willy nilly brought up the rear. The first four or five had hidden behind bushes in a hollow away from the path, with myself and one other man still making for it across open ground, when the rest began beckoning to us frantically from behind their several bushes. George in particular who normally looked like a bantamweight English yeoman, suddenly put on the most fiercesome eastern grimaces for our benefit. We stumbled on into the hollow and then found that twenty-five Germans had been passing immediately behind us in full view on the track to Kritsa. If any one of them had looked at right angles to the line of march, they must have seen us complete with tell-tale tommy guns at about seventy-five yards range—but once more as the luck had it, a wind had sprung up driving off the mist, but making enough noise by sighing in the pines to deaden the sound of our boots on the rocks.

This was all too narrow a squeak to be funny, and for the next half-hour or so we squatted shivering behind our respective bushes.

At twilight, being fairly certain that the Germans had gone for the day, we made our way warily on to the Omalo, crossed it safely by nightfall, passed a ravine—a likely place for another ambush—without mishap, and an hour later reached, now very tired, the hut of a friendly shepherd. He at once produced large bowls of hot milk—a hundred times better than nectar just then—and so, as they say, to bed!

Chapter Eleven ♣

THERE were times during the following weeks when the outlaw life for all its incidental roughness seemed positively idyllic. March, with its wind and snows, gave way to April—the loveliest of all months in the Greek year—with the certainty of warm clear days ahead when we should be able to live out all day and night on the mountain slopes. For the time we had found a new dry headquarters above the large village of Males. It was not a cave really, but rather a chance formation of rocks set together in the earth as though parts of Stonehenge had sunk conveniently side by side, with a flat rock twelve yards wide lying across the top. The whole lay in a hollow on the mountain slope and so could not be seen from any angle until one was almost upon it, and the hollow itself at that time of year was full of wild orchids and mountain lilies and the sound of goat-bells and the humming of the bees.

From the rocks above it we looked westwards to the great shoulder of Mount Dikte, that was still covered with a blanket of glistening snow—mile on mile of it against the soft blue of the sky. At times it looked so peacefully remote and so gloriously beautiful that I felt an almost physical longing to rise from my side of the valley and cast myself bodily upon it.

Below the snow came great forests of pine and below them again the clustered villages of Viannos. In six of them, we knew, the houses were roofless—charred and derelict shells—but we could see from the distance only the white sunlit walls surrounded by orchards of almond blossom. Below them again on the lower slopes were the

terraced vineyards and strips of corn now shooting green, and out to the south, down the valley, lay the deep azure of the Mediterranean—and beyond that again, out of the southern horizon, our own friendly planes came scudding more and more often, with the promise that before the next winter, as we thought, the war would be over.

The days at Males were so peaceful and beautiful, that I sometimes wished that time could stop. High up in the fresh mountain air, I felt at times the feeling which one of the mountaineers expresses in the "Ascent of F6", when nearing the summit he asks his companion if he will ever want to come down again into the real world of shouting and strife, false praise and false motives. For behind the peace of these days there was the knowledge that it would soon be our duty to go down into the unforeseeable turmoil of the end of the occupation.

I did much walking at this time, but even on the days when I was waiting at headquarters, the time passed busily, for there were always messengers coming and going, and for me much interviewing and questioning and friendly cajolery of supporters, and earnest discussion of the news. I used to enjoy particularly the last half-hour or so before I went to sleep, when I could count on being alone. The nights were warm and I began to sleep on an open shelf of rock covered with branches and bracken, with a shepherd's cloak round me and my jacket rolled up for a pillow.

One evening I was lying awake enjoying the warm breeze rising from the valley, wondering as always at the clearness of the stars, when I shifted slightly and felt an unaccustomed lump under my head. It reminded me that I had been to one of the nearby villages that day, and that the old lady of the house, crossing herself and muttering a blessing as we left, had run up to me with a kindly

gesture and thrust a handful of raisins into the breast pocket of my jacket. I started to munch them singly, and then slipped a hand into my pocket, took out the whole lot in a lump, and began to chew them slowly in the darkness. Every thing just then seemed agreeable, peaceful, perfect. I snuggled down comfortably on my back, gazing at the stars, feeling pleasantly tired and thinking that there were really many things about the vagabond existence which made it good to be alive. The raisins, too, were sweet and good, and I went on chewing them quietly, thinking sleepily of other things.

Then gradually I became aware of something odd. The raisins were not getting minced up as well-behaved raisins should: in fact two or three of them in a lump were positively resisting mastication. I was still too drowsy to give them a vigorous bite but began probing gently with the end of my tongue, and was much surprised to find that one of them felt like a piece of rubber. A split second later I became aware that I was really chewing the little round rubber-cased pill which I had placed in the bottom of my breast pocket months before, as a last resort to finish myself off with in case of need! And what was more, I recollected that it was well charged with cyanide and that, if you sucked off the rubber against the roof of your mouth, it killed you in a matter of minutes. If you swallowed it, it was certain to kill you too, but in that case you died "very painfully" three or four hours later.

Somehow, without so much as drawing breath, I managed to eject in one moment and movement raisins, pill, and a salutary jet of saliva, and then seizing a water-bottle began to rinse and spit. Several sleepy forms began to sit up and wonder why the effendi had suddenly taken to moonlit expectorations, which must have seemed sudden and violent even by local standards. Their concern had a calming effect, and I had soon reassured them

and myself that there was really nothing to make a fuss about. It was disconcerting to be asked what was the matter. I found it shameful to explain that I had been poisoning myself and impossible to say in Greek that this was really a depoisoning process.

* * * *

By the beginning of April Paddy and I and another British officer, John Stanley, each with a few helpers were waiting in a deep valley running down to the sea for the boat, on which Stanley Moss and the rest of the kidnapping party were to arrive. We knew that the boat could not come for several days, and Paddy suggested that we should visit the local monastery, which he had used on some earlier journey as a staging post. The Archimandrite was said to be "one of us"—a most hospitable man.

It was another beautiful walk, first an hour through a sapling wood just turning green, till we reached open ground at twilight and then skirted the cypresses on the outskirts of two villages, on the edge of the plain. The last hour led through vineyards and olives till we reached the monastery itself, which stood far away from any other building. Unlike most monasteries it was not built nestling in a gully, but had its own fields stretching away openly all round it. We had sent a guide ahead of us, and the Archimandrite was all smiles and welcome as we stumbled up the wooden steps into his living room. To my surprise we were helped in by a very timid nun, who, with some sort of theological student appeared to be the only inhabitants of the monastery apart from the Archimandrite himself. It was all highly conspiratorial. The entrance through the monastery wall was dark and they did not want to show a light.

Inside we were embraced by the Archimandrite, who sat us down, all smiles, while the nun and the theological student disappeared, the one to cook, the other to shut

up a gate into the monastery courtyard. As this was the only way in at night, we should have warning if a patrol suddenly arrived. Then the Archimandrite took us into his bedroom—I had begun to judge the status of my surroundings by the presence or absence of a bedstead—and then the bed was pulled delightedly aside and we were proudly shown a trap door in the floor leading down into the monastery cellar. The trap door was left open while we dined, and if anyone had come that night we could have slipped into the cellar in a few seconds, and from there into an orchard at the back of the monastery and away in the darkness. By day we could reasonably expect plenty of warning and should be able to walk away sedately without arousing suspicion, before any Germans reached the monastery.

All the same that evening we must have looked like a singularly odd junta. The living-room was only a few yards square, blacked out at one end with some sort of old-fashioned kerosene lamp throwing shadows over the table, occasionally lighting up one of the men's knives, or the shiny bun of jet black hair on the back of the Archimandrite's head. Vassili Konios, our local leader, was with us—a typical Cretan *kapetanios*. As he smiled, his profile danced on the wall, like an exultant eagle. The seven or eight of us craned over the table, eager to give the Archimandrite the latest news from Cairo. The war in Italy was going well. Everywhere the Germans were in retreat. By the autumn at the latest Crete would be free.

The good news we knew would soon be all round the local villages and meanwhile the monastery possessed its own vineyards, and we were soon well lit with raki. The Archimandrite seemed quite entranced by Paddy's singing, and it soon became the sort of carefree evening that everyone enjoyed. By the end of it the living-room, which was normally neat enough, looked anything but

monastic. We must have been drinking and smoking for several hours, and had forgotten everything but wine and song, when eventually we tumbled to sleep. I slept on a wooden settee beside the table, with a couple of men on the floor. Paddy was given the Archimandrite's bed.

It was a disturbed night. The blacked-out room was full of cigarette smoke and hot, snoring men, but next morning broke fresh and clear, and I enjoyed the customary splash of cold water over the face, while someone held a lump of olive soap for me and a towel. It always seemed a slightly biblical process, and all the more pleasant when the vapours of raki were still sweeping about in one's head. Vasili Konios had been up early and we both sat down on the verandah at the back of the house. It had a most attractive view of the plain across vineyards and open fields, with the immediate foreground broken by a patch of grass and an orchard. Unfortunately this patch and the verandah itself were that morning partly screened off by the monastery washing, which had been left out overnight.

I had just finished a delicious glass of fresh boiled goat's milk with sugar, and was wishing I could have another—it was a far better breakfast than the usual nip of raki—when the theological student, who had been out to climb the monastery wall on the other side of the building, suddenly rushed on to the verandah, just as two figures emerged twenty yards away round the side of the orchard. Fortunately the washing partially masked us. Before they had seen us, and even before we had had time to be sure that they were Germans and part of a patrol, we had stumbled into the living-room, hauled Paddy out of bed, hauled the bed away from the trap door, and bundled as speedily as we could without too much clatter down a flight of old wooden steps into the cellar. It was only when we got into the cellar that we had time to wonder how

much of our gear had been left about upstairs. However, the theological student—he was only a schoolboy of 16 or 17—appeared to be keeping his head admirably. He was soon handing us down a knapsack or two, and then we could hear the bed moved into place over the trap door, and the sounds of furniture being rearranged in the two rooms above. Once down in the cellar we exchanged grins cheerfully enough. It was so much like a priest hole, or the getaway down some secret passage in a mediaeval romance. Paddy, who had seemed to take a disgustingly long time to get his boots on, had by now regained his normal sang-froid, and took his stance with one hand on his holster at the bottom of the steps—listening intently to the voices of the Germans as they came in. He told me afterwards that he was worried in case someone might have given the party away, and that when the Germans looked round the living-room he heard one of them remark at once, that there had been a lot of people smoking there. However we were soon reassured by the urbane, even silky, tones in which the Archimandrite bade them welcome. I could almost see him rubbing his hands gently together with his priest's hat tilted a little to one side, inviting them with a sweet smile, to make themselves free of the monastery's hospitality. If they would have the great goodness just to sit down for a few minutes, he would be honoured to have a dish of the monastery's eggs prepared. It was a simple abode, and they must excuse it, but they were good fresh eggs and he had plenty of potatoes. Meanwhile they would naturally take a glass of raki, and his boy would just run out to the cellar to fetch a flask of the monastery's own wine. It was not, perhaps, as well known as the best wine of Arkhanes, but he hoped and believed they would like it. Someone in the patrol could understand Greek, so they were soon settled down contentedly enough.

Meanwhile the Archimandrite's boy had gone out into the orchard, and opened a door from outside into the cellar. With whispered expressions of esteem from us and assurances from him that all was well upstairs, we watched him draw the wine. Upstairs the meal was evidently progressing well. The cellar was only a few feet high, and my head was near the wooden floor of the room above. It was odd to find myself studying, through a fair sized chink between the planks, the boots of a German soldier about two feet from my nose.

After the first few minutes anxiety and amusement gave way to mild restlessness. We just had to sit still while the Germans—there were about a dozen of them—finished their meal, which smelt distressingly good. I remember thinking that sooner or later someone would probably sneeze, and that the Cretans were most unlikely to be able to restrain for long their childlike propensity to fidget. Meanwhile I crept round the cellar—it was really more like a windowless storeroom than a cellar—to see what was the best vantage point, in case they started a search. There was a shallow square well in the floor with a stone lid. I crept into it. Two or three of us could have been hidden in it, but it would have been a deathtrap if we had been found—so I hid such papers as I had on me in some chaff on the floor, dusted over my tracks, and beckoned to be hauled out again. After that we just waited. For their part the Germans merely continued to tuck in solidly. We could hear that they approved of their reception well enough, and they remarked among themselves in what might be called somewhat soldierly terms about the presence of the nun—but for the most part they just filled the two rooms above us and ate silently except when someone shifted his feet or equipment, which would rouse us to a momentary alertness. Then the leader thanked the Archimandrite in slow and solemn Greek and

they all got up with a tremendous clatter. It was with relief that I watched, through a chink in the cellar door, the patrol, or rather two members of it, make their way, somewhat wearily under the burden of a heavy machine gun, further and further into the distance.

Then we all came out smiling at one another a trifle questioningly. I felt distinctly claustrophobic for the rest of that day in the monastery, and no doubt the Archimandrite felt just then as though he was still walking about on a stage after the curtain had gone down. However, it was a cheerful business congratulating and thanking the Archimandrite, the theological student Joanni, and the nun, whose name was Anna. The Archimandrite had been given a note of thanks by the warrant officer in charge of the patrol, and he was eager that we should translate it. It said that he had received and entertained a party of German soldiers in a most friendly and hospitable manner, and implied that he was a good friend of theirs who deserved decent treatment in future. I forget if we endorsed this there and then. Probably not, because it was a useful document for the monastery to keep intact until after the occupation ended, but certainly, either then or later, we wrote on the back of it our own warm thanks for the even more hospitable and helpful manner in which the monastery had entertained (and secluded) ourselves. The resulting document, which spoke also of the extreme coolness of the Archimandrite, made for him, I like to think, one of the choicest of war souvenirs. After the war he received a British decoration at the Embassy in Athens.

A few days later we had final news that the boat was coming and the party assembled near the beach. It included a young lady from Ierapetra, named Antonia, who, in the best spy tradition, had been working in a German headquarters as a typist and supplying her brother with admirable lists of the German units in her district.

She seemed a pleasant girl but shy at meeting me, and I daresay was put off to find only a grimy and threadbare shepherd in place of the Californian Robin Hood, whom she may have been expecting. There were also four German deserters from a German air force unit. By this time we were beginning to get increasing news from the Cretans of odd Germans who were thinking of desertion, but were frightened of handing themselves over to the Greeks, and were therefore searching for a contact with us. These were the first Germans who actually reached me, and it was amusing to see their wonder and astonishment at the sight of us. Even before the war I had known that the Germans had an exaggerated idea of the efficiency of the British secret service, and I imagine that these four will have helped to perpetuate the legend. They had been brought first to a British wireless headquarters somewhere between Canea and Herakleion, and from there taken a night's march to Tom on the slopes of Ida, then another night across Ida to a third set, south of Anogeia and finally to the beach. By the time they reached us they had been some four nights on the way, and each day that dawned had produced a new British officer, or officers, and one N.C.O. or more with a wireless, all dressed in a variety of Cretan costumes. By the time they reached us they seemed to think that every second Cretan was a British officer in disguise, that the 50,000 odd occupation troops were practically surrounded by us, and that the whole island was moving around them under our direction. We did not enlighten them, but in fact in their few days' journey they had happened to meet practically all the British who were in Crete at that time.

Waiting with Antonia and the Germans were also a dozen Cretans—men who had helped us and were on the run, or who were to be trained in the Middle East so it was a mixed cavalcade that wound its way down to the

beach that night in the twilight. However the boat crept in in good time and in a few minutes out of a rubber dinghy stepped Stanley Moss and the Greek kidnappers and into it went Antonia, the German deserters, and a dozen eager bandits. Soon we were trudging back cheerfully through the scent of the thyme. The party had got in successfully at last, and for myself I had new instructions, another bag of gold from Cairo and, far more desirable, as it seemed, a nice fat bundle of letters from Hertfordshire.

Chapter Twelve ♣

NEXT day after a cheerful farewell to Paddy and his party, I set off eastwards through the district of Viannos to return to the wireless above Males. In Viannos the reprisals of the previous summer, in which hundreds of villagers had been shot and six villages set ablaze, had produced widespread destitution. So I was not altogether surprised, when we stopped the night in the village of Amira, to find that it was in the hands of two or three communist leaders.

They had not forgotten their local good manners, and we were politely given a simple meal of bread and cheese and olives, which was about all they could provide for anyone. But instead of the usual comradely welcome which I had come to expect from Cretan men of all ages, when they learnt that I was British, I could feel a suppressed tension. After the meal they became more and more hostile and a furious meeting ensued. The main spokesman, who had a disagreeable red-brown moustache and bloodshot bloodthirsty eyes, claimed to be a lieutenant trained at the Officer Cadet School in Athens. His name in rough translation meant Little Rosebud.

I will not go into the detailed arguments of that particular evening. But, as well as much else, we (the British) were accused of encouraging resistance and then endangering Cretan lives without making sacrifices ourselves. This was difficult to answer, for by then the Cretans had largely ceased to hope that we should liberate them quickly by invading, and I knew that the

capture of General Kreipe and other acts of resistance, whatever their value for morale generally, would shortly send down our stock in the areas of Crete which suffered afterwards. However, before I could begin to reply, they continued without pause to accuse myself and others of interfering in Greek affairs by supplying arms to their nationalist opponents. This last was untrue. My orders were clear and categorical—to support any group which was genuinely resisting the Germans—and I said so pointedly. After that the meeting suddenly and insincerely became all smiles again. It confirmed clearly, however, what from various reports I had realised already—that in future, I should have to spend much time in counteracting anti-British propaganda.

At the time the Russians were making sweeping advances on the eastern front, and the second front had not yet been opened. Also, although I did not know it then, the communist leaders on the mainland had managed to oust or murder most of their rivals and were claiming, with success, to be the real leaders of Greek resistance. These happenings were already influencing the political leaders in Crete, and a growing number of fellow-travellers and moderates and a large body of un-political peasants, who merely wished to "resist", were in fact joining the local leftist organisation, which the communists increasingly controlled. They had by now a number of political groups in the villages, and one small band in the hills, which would soon have become a rallying point for the more fanatical and for their simpler sup-porters, if they could have obtained arms.

After this I twice met the communist leaders in the hills. Once they had proposed some minor act of sabotage, but backed out of it when they found that we would not co-operate with them. The next time they asked me to see them urgently, and then merely wished to protest that the

kidnapping of General Kreipe, which had just taken place, had left the Cretans in the lurch, and their leader tried to get me to sign a statement that we could protect men on the run or, alternatively, that there was nothing that we could do for them.

The leader, even judged by the standards of totalitarian thuggery, was, it seemed to me, a singularly odious and vicious personality. His name was Johnny Bodias, but as he walked with a limp, we gave him the code-name Clubfoot. At the time of the battle of Crete he had been in Canea gaol serving a life-sentence for the murder, or manslaughter in self-defence, of the father of a boy whom he had assaulted. The German attack gave him the chance to escape and he took to the hills. He did not seem to me fully sane. Though his mind had been a good one, it had become fanatical. I guessed that his time in gaol had done him no good, and that more than anything else he was determined not to go back.

I never later had the chance to judge whether or not that was a fair view of him, but certainly Johnny Bodias never did go back to gaol. After the war he was still the acknowledged leader of the communist band. When the civil war spread they remained in the hills as a threat to an otherwise peaceful island, and pinned down a Greek battalion which might have been used against the rebels on the mainland. Then they descended upon Ierapetra, and murdered some dozen right wing Albanian refugees, who had been billeted there and were totally defenceless. After that a band of Cretan nationalists themselves took to the hills and, knowing the ways of bandits far better than the Germans, they ran Bodias to earth, or rather—as one of my former runners, who was in the party, told me later—they shot him while hiding up a pine tree, and then in accordance with an old Balkan custom, and with a fine regard for Cretan morale, if not for western

sensitivity, the decapitated head of Johnny Bodias was displayed in the centre of Herakleion.

This story should show that there was plenty of red-blooded primitive passion latent among the different nationalist or communist peasant groups who were springing up in the hills. Equally violent, if not quite such primitive passions, were becoming painfully evident between the political leaders in the towns. From the gossip that was reaching me, it appeared too that some of the main politicos in Neapolis were being increasingly swayed by the communists, and I gradually gave up any hope of helping them to form a united resistance front. It was true that all parties professed the most unconvincing and impractical readiness to unite and drive out their common enemy, but, in fact, it became increasingly difficult to keep the leaders' attention on the Germans rather than on each other. There was still a good prospect that some of the nationalist leaders would co-operate with us sincerely, so increasingly and inevitably we were forced into helping them with such arms as we were sent, and it became less and less easy to maintain that we were really neutral over internal politics.

I was pondering on this on the march back next evening, when the track bent and we came on what must in daylight have been a dry stony slope, but which now was mysteriously illuminated with quaint flickering little lights like a hundred will-o-the-wisps. They seemed for a moment stationary, but then to start up and down, as we gazed at them, this way and that, with the movement of an industrious anthill. Knowing that it was after curfew and wondering what it could be, I paused a moment but the guide, a pace in front of me, knew at once and merely grunted merrily that the local villagers with little wick oil lamps were out searching for snails after a shower. They were crowded with refugees from another nearby

village which had been destroyed, so every snail was needed, but as we passed, with a gesture of godspeed to the traveller, they pressed on us a handful or two of their best, fresh for the pot.

We reached the headquarters next day, and after this for the next two months I was largely engaged in visiting Neapolis and as much of my district as I could, urging on all and sundry a political truce and indicating the immense power of the allies, which was about to be unleashed on the second front. I also received orders to reconnoitre the north coast of Lasithi and the Gulf of Mirabello. This apparently meant that arms might be run in by submarine, and it appeared too that commandos might make a raid on the coastal batteries, which guarded Agios Nikolaos, so I made in all three reconnaissances of the coast, partly with Kosta Loubounes whom I picked up in Neapolis on the way.

Kosta was one of the most likeable of men. No one seeing the kindliest of many wrinkles at the corner of his eyes as he smiled, would ever have guessed that he was the highly intelligent centre of a spy network. With his cap and trim white moustache and swinging an old walking stick he reminded me, as we strolled along the cliffs, of a rather meditative country squire or perhaps an ex-officer ruminating quietly in retirement at Eastbourne.

One reconnaissance took me to the island of Spinalonga. This has a golden-brown exquisitely, even laughably, romantic Venetian fortress at the far end, guarding a little land-locked bay. In cloud and wind the waves could be choppy and then the water frilled into the authentic wine-dark colour of classic days, but normally in sunlight it was a single calm polished sheet of blue glass. When I first reached it on a warm sunny day, it was the hour of siesta; we had chosen it deliberately, so that we could slip unnoticed across a narrow causeway on to the island.

Everyone in the village, friend or foe, seemed to be sleeping in the shade. Even the curving, brightly coloured prows of a line of small caiques, that were drawn up along the shore before a fringe of whitewashed cottages, seemed like the sandhoppers about them, to be drowsing in the heat, and although my mind was concentrated on the immediate job ahead and my eyes alert for a possible sentry, I could not help thinking even at the time that no one could have found more beautiful surroundings in which to do a day's work, however odd.

At the other end of the island was a promontory rising steeply and then falling away in a cliff to the sea. This was a forbidden zone containing a coastal battery. I assumed that one of the main objects of the reconnaissance was to get information about it. So most of that afternoon I spent sitting quietly in the shade of a carob tree on a hillock overlooking the promontory, making a sketch and map-enlargement of the wire, and the minefield, and the sentries' beat, and the cottages in which the gun teams were billeted—while a local guide, an ex-warrant officer, was being rowed slowly round the island with a fishing line in one hand and a pencil in the other, marking down on another map-enlargement the position of the gun turrets facing seawards.

Then we strolled round the island, ostensibly to trap a hare, but really to note the shape of the inlets and the depth of water, and in two or three hours as much information had been gently collected as any commandos could have required. It was in fact an entrancing afternoon, although it seemed too like a training exercise to be true.

Towards the end of April I was on a visit to the plain of Lasithi and was beginning to wonder what had been happening to Paddy and his party; I knew that they had spent a cheerful Easter, but had heard no news of the

kidnapping of General Kreipe, which was due at any moment. Nor was it easy, of course, to make enquiries from my Greek friends without giving away something of Paddy's plans. By coincidence I went late one afternoon to the house of Manoli Markogiannakis who had been for many years a servant of Sir Arthur Evans, the archaeologist who had conducted the excavations at Gnossos. There he had built the Villa Ariadne which had long been an offshoot of the British School of Archaeology but which at that time was serving as General Kreipe's sleeping quarters. Manoli was a cheerful soul. He and his wife, Ourania, after many tribulations had settled, as it were, in temporary retirement in his native village, but clearly they were really living for the day when British students would once more come flocking back to the Villa.

Manoli beamed all over when I was led in by my guide. We had not met before. At the time I was dressed in a shirt buttoned at the neck, which had been both shirt and pyjamas for some ten days at least, a very old jacket patched in most places, and frayed at the edges, some muddy breeches, puttees dyed black, and boots that flapped about where the soles were loose. At once he hastened to relieve me of my sakkouli with the assurance of a pre-war British butler relieving a guest of his great-coat. "Excuse us, Mr. Alexis," he said, "I am afraid that everything"—pointing to his extremely tidy sitting room —"is in great disorder, and we have many shortages, but please be seated." Then after a momentary pause to lend some solemnity to words, which he knew would sound suddenly enchanting, he added: "If you will just wait a moment, Ourania will bring in the tea." It was all exactly as if he had been referring to a parlour-maid in pre-war Wimbledon. I must have smiled in astonished amusement, for I saw Manoli beam again. But I checked myself from exclaiming about "the tea", for I knew

by then that when Cretans speak of tea, they mean a form of camomile made from a local herb. In a few moments, however, Ourania swept in bearing, sure enough, a tray with a spotless teacloth, a china teapot complete with tea cosy, a milk jug, a sugar bowl, cups, saucers, and dessert plates to match, and a plate of astonishingly thin bread and butter with a pot of crabapple jelly. At the moment after a day's walk I could have done better, perhaps, with half a loaf, but the spirit behind the gift was delightful. Manoli and I had some fun explaining to the guide how to manipulate an English tea service, and I think Manoli and Ourania were as pleased to be providing an English tea once again, as I was to be given it.

Just about the hour when these nostalgic homely ceremonies were ending in Lasithi, with mutual assurances between Manoli and myself that shortly we would be celebrating the Germans' departure from the Villa Ariadne, Paddy and his party must have been lying by the side of the road near the Villa on the point of holding up General Kreipe. Ignorant of this, however, we made our way that evening to the village where Aristeides' parents were living, on the edge of the plain. There was a German company in two neighbouring villages, so we planned to leave next morning about 4 a.m., so as to be in the hills before they began to stir.

It was a cold grey morning for once, but a nip of raki helped to get us away briskly. As we were leaving, some village friend of Aristeides came in with one of the frequent unconfirmed rumours. He said that nearly all the Germans in the plain had gone up that night in front of us to the Omalo. This meant, if it was true, that they had taken to the hills, and were searching for scattered bands—and for General Kreipe, if he had been kidnapped. In fact, although Aristeides and the rest tended to discount

the story, it was just the sort of news which I had been expecting. Our route led across one corner of the Omalo, but we could skirt it by keeping round the hills above it, which would take us past a former headquarters of our own.

After about two hours we were nearly in sight of the old headquarters—a cluster of shepherds' huts in a bunch of windswept pear trees, when Aristeides, who was in front, rounded a ledge of rock and with a sort of suppressed whistle through his teeth stood stock still. I stopped immediately behind him, and so did the man behind me, though we could see nothing. I had become accustomed to attitudinising by my Greek helpers at times, but Aristeides was a straightforward fellow and I knew from his tense attitude that something was really wrong. Aristeides began to walk backwards silently step by step, half sideways like a crab, and whispered anxiously "Yermanee". I crept forward and looked round the ledge, and there they were—two hundred Germans—all round and over our old headquarters like wasps round a nest. Evidently they were just clearing up breakfast. They were two hundred yards off, but what was much worse was that they seemed to have put out scouts on the far side of the camp where the trees began. They no doubt feared that bandits might come at them from the woods, but in fact they had cut us off from our new headquarters.

The ground we were on was broken into small rocky valleys, and though we could keep out of sight of the main body, there was a nasty chance that the scouts would see us. With that hunched look, which men adopt when in view but not wishing to be seen, we hurried back, and then made a wide detour, which would take us round the far side of Mt. Varsami. In the next little valley we found a frightened shepherd, doing his best to lie low. He told us encouragingly that the Germans had arrived in the middle of the night, that they had sent out pickets at first light,

and that he thought they were now moving up the mountain. This meant that the next hour or so would be something of a race. We had to get over a bare shoulder of the mountain on the west before the Germans, coming up from the east, could look over, or round the edge, which they could not do until above the tree line. We could merely have returned to the woods above Lasithi, and stayed put, but it was high time that I got back to the set, and Aristeides with a grin said that we would beat the Germans to it easily. So we raced on up the rocks. By then all were enjoying the keen mountain air and feeling as vigorous as men can well be, after months of open-air life and walking, and plenty of the plain food and drink of the country. In another couple of hours we were over the shoulder, without sign of a German, and had dropped into a deep gorge with long slanting cliffs of golden brown stone. However I was in no mood to linger over the grandeur of the scenery. In fact the gorge was as dry and bare as a desert, and if the Germans had men at the bottom of it, we should never get out. Then a German picket appeared, about half a mile above us, on the shoulder we had just crossed. Clearly they could see us, for our black clothes must have been sharply outlined in the sunlight, which was now falling all too brightly, on the open bed of the gorge. In fact we could see that they were all looking at us and clustering round what looked like a portable wireless. There was now no way out except to race down the gorge hoping that no one would be there to intercept us. We reached the end of it without mishap, but this time with only a little to spare. A few minutes later we stopped at a shepherd's hut to ask for water, and found two women all too anxious to hasten us on our travels. The Germans had been seen coming round the mountain as well as over it, and we were now evidently about to bump into them again.

By this time, however, we were in trees. I have never been so fond of trees as I was in bandit days. It always seemed that in a good forest you could hide and dodge and fade away, if necessary until nightfall, when no patrol could ever get near, and it would have required far more men than the Germans could ever muster to throw an adequate cordon round us. So, like a bunch of much relieved rabbits, which are at length in range of their burrows, we struck off at a tangent, through the woods.

Soon we came to a little path running downhill through small holm-oaks, and life suddenly became peaceful and cheerful once more. The Germans would beat about the mountain, fail to find the hordes of bandits of which German soldiers constantly spoke, and then once more return wearily to their barracks. We had been able to drink on the way, but by now we were tired ourselves, largely from lack of food. In front there was a hut, and we were approaching it in hopes of some bread and goat's cheese, when something struck my attention about the donkey which was cropping the grass outside. As it turned there was a bright gleam from its back. Aristeides promptly stepped aside from the path and turning back up the hill began zealously to pick up sticks. Manoli Aggelakis, behind me, whispered something I could not hear, and at that moment I realised that the donkey was loaded with a large German petrol can and a tommy gun, and out of the hut about forty yards away came two Germans. Aristeides and Manoli had by this time turned up the slope and seemed to me to be overdoing their efforts to pick up sticks. They reminded me, in fact, not so much of ordinary villagers on a wood-collecting expedition, as of an effort to play the part by an over-eager amateur theatrical company. I doubt in any case whether they could have got away with it, for the Germans saw me on the track, and when I turned to move off with the others,

one of them let out an angry halloo. At that all three of us made a dash for it. The trees were sparse just there, but there was dead ground over a hummock fifty yards off, and before the Germans could get their tommy guns into action we were up and over it, and temporarily out of sight. We could hear Germans clattering after us and tore on, much to the surprise of two buxom homely shepherdesses, whom we passed in the next clearing. "Tell the Germans we went over there," Aristeides panted at them, swerving in one direction and pointing in the other, but I think they barely had time to take it in, as we raced away. Then a minute or two later with the Germans by this time right out of the race, we all three began to laugh. Once we were out of sight and hearing we knew the Germans would have no hope of catching us in the wood.

However, the Germans were clearly searching the areas where they thought bandits might be. If, having spotted three suspects they concentrated on our wood, we might soon be on the run again—so we trotted on, and soon came to a cliff where the wood dropped sharply into a ravine. There were more trees growing from the rock face and we were able to clamber down to a crevice with a thick bush in front of it. The cliff was overhanging at this point, so we were hidden by it from above and behind, and by the bush itself from in front. It was a perfect place to hide. There was no way up the cliff from below, so unless the Germans clambered down from exactly above the spot where we were hiding—which in any case they could only do one by one—there was no possible means of seeing us. Through the bush itself we could see the other side of the ravine, and a path running above it, which led to Manoli Aggelakis' own village. We planned to cross the ravine higher up at nightfall and make our way to the outskirts. It would be too risky to sleep there that night, but Manoli would be able to

waylay some acquaintance and his family would then bring us something to eat and a rug or so. After a time a shepherd, whom Manoli recognised, came and sat opposite us at the other side of the ravine. He looked a good deal at our bush, and Aristeides and Manoli were both certain that he had seen us get down behind it. Possibly he thought we were sheep-stealers preparing to raid his flock at nightfall. The ravine though deep was not wide, and he seemed within easy calling distance. Every time one of his goats knocked over a stone, you could hear the loud cracking of the echoes knocking against the cliffs from side to side. Then he called up to a passing villager on the path above, for news of the Germans, and in the stillness of the late afternoon, we heard a voice call down that there were thousands of them, that they would bivouac for the night in each of the villages, and that patrols were now coming down from the heights. They had shot at a shepherd on Varsami, and killed a shepherd boy, and were arresting anyone who could not explain himself. The voice added what was anxious news—that a company was now going to Manoli's village.

We had friends in the next village to Manoli's, and it appeared that the Germans had already settled in there for the night, so as dusk fell we made our way to a secluded sheep-pen some little way from it. Without disclosing who I was, Aristeides told a passing villager that we had been on the run and asked him to tell one of our friends, Joanni Belevesakis, to come to us. Very soon Joanni came, and gave us the reassuring news that the Germans were rounding up anyone whom they found on the hills, but apparently leaving the villagers alone. He soon returned again, with eggs and cheese, wine and rugs, and we rested on a plateau looking down the wide green valley from Males to the sea, while the evening drew in silently in a haze of gold and crimson. As we passed the

food and flask of wine, the long day seemed to be ending in calm and sweet content like a stanza from Omar Khayyam. It was hard, in fact, to remember that a few hundred yards away a German company was also resting after a long day of walking and climbing in the mountains. Joanni slipped back before curfew and then the view before us dimmed, as the silence grew. The stars came out and occasionally the tune of a German song came drifting to us. Suddenly there was a flash and a scream, and a rocket, fired from nearby, burst in white incandescence and seemed to hover pointedly above us. But a red one followed from Manoli's village, and a white one from a village further on, and we were soon glad of these gratis fireworks, feeling sure that the German companies were merely telling each other that all was well with them for the night.

Next morning in the glimmer of the chill hour when the stars are still visible before dawn, we slipped off again and were soon crossing the Males valley towards headquarters; and there next day we had word from Herakleion confirming that General Kreipe had been kidnapped two days before near the Villa Ariadne. It was cheerful work to report the capture, and that evening I received a full account of what had happened from an agent from Ierapetra, in however, disturbingly mixed terms. The kidnapping had gone off "first-class", but the Germans had blocked Paddy's line to the sea, by occupying a coastal zone to the south of Mt. Ida. Meanwhile the party was in hiding and was bound to miss a pre-arranged boat. A wireless near them was out of action, and the Germans were threatening savage reprisals.

However we could do no more than ask urgently for a boat or boats and instructions for Paddy. In an hour or two we had the reply with much congratulation from Cairo, and a few minutes later two runners were on their

way, one to the north and one to the south of Mt. Ida. However, with Germans in plenty on the way, it would take them, I knew, several days at best to find Paddy. In fact he was escaping westwards and, therefore, going further away from us. In the end, though I had one gay letter telling me that the General was a charmer, the party for practical purposes remained out of touch, and we heard with relief from Cairo a fortnight or so later, that they had been safely evacuated from the western half of the island.

Chapter Thirteen ♣

SOMETIME in the early summer I received from Tom a grubby little note telling me that I was to help a commando party who were coming in to make a raid on petrol dumps. We had already a detailed plan of the dump nearest to my headquarters, and I asked our helpers for information on three others in the centre and east of the island. I had some fun in mixing up these requests with a number of others, so that no one would realise in advance that we were particularly interested in petrol. However, we reported repeatedly to the S.B.S. (Special Boat Service), who were coming that parties of ten to twenty men could not possibly be brought in and hidden near the dumps, without hundreds, if not thousands of Cretans telling each other what was going to happen.

Towards the end of June I went down to the coast, to meet the recce party—Ian Paterson, the commanding officer, with a couple of sergeants, signallers, and a Greek liaison officer. They came off quickly in a dinghy.

Vassili Konios had brought a mule and one or two trusty cousins to the beach, and we were soon humping enormous army rucksacks uphill again, to a hideout in the woods near a friendly wireless. There we lay up next day, planning to make a quick night march of about twenty-five miles to a headquarters near the aerodrome at Kastelli, where the Germans had the main dump.

I had been down our route to and from the coast several times by then and we had contacts in the villages all the way along it. When we came to a new village, Vassili or the guide would steal ahead, whistle out the

mayor, or whoever we knew best, and bring him back to us with appropriate exclamations of delight and wishes for a speedy allied victory. Then the new guide, winding along silently on rubber-tyre soles, would lead us for an hour or so until the next man took over.

It must all have looked certainly very cloak and dagger, and it was fun to see a cockney sergeant gazing after the cowled figure of Vassili as he hurried forward, and then out of the darkness—for they had come on a moonless night—two or three other cowled figures would hurry back to us, and we would shake hands as though we were all old performers who had been playing this part of the melodrama for months. "Mr. Alexis?" They would say, "God be with you. It's all clear. We had some Germans at mid-day scrounging potatoes. Tell your friends that we are glad and proud to welcome the British army. Tell them that all the Cretans are with them."

By the time this performance had been repeated two or three times I think the S.B.S. believed that the whole of the island was really organised to help us, and in a sense it was, and it was pleasant, when one thought how futile and ineffective our previous work had often been, to find that to others it seemed to have built up an elaborate network of devoted conspirators. I enjoyed the whole of that month and it made much of the work of the months before seem worth while. On the first night Paterson had explained to me that the aim was to burn up petrol stocks simultaneously all over the island. If that was really successful, it would force the Germans to send a tanker from Salonica to Crete, and tankers in the Aegean and Black Sea were, I gathered, worth their weight in gold. Once a tanker was on its way to Crete, the Navy—in particular our submarines—could be safely trusted to look after it. So the whole operation fitted at last into a major pattern, and that did away with the feeling—which one

often had—that our job was a tiny inconsequential side-show, which could not affect the major war outside.

As dawn came up, we were still in a steep gully leading out of the plain of Herakleion. Any party of a dozen or so, particularly since the S.B.S. were in battle dress, might have been remarked from the plain and followed, so we left the track and camouflaged ourselves in some none too thick shrubs up one side of the gully, and stayed there all day. The local guide was asked to fill water bottles and returned with a bunch of cousins from the nearest village. Two or three shepherds saw us and hovered about like hopeful but good-enough-natured vultures. All this dismayed Paterson, who never became reconciled to the Greek idea of security.

At dusk we went on to the top. The mountains rise abruptly on the east of the plain, and near Kastelli there are steep gullies running thousands of feet down from the heart of the mountains. At a point where two gullies intersect, there is a spring of the clearest coldest water. A few hundred feet above it, the loose rocks form a bank so steep, that, as we clambered up, they would often go crashing down, filling the gully with echoes that bounded from side to side—echoes so loud and clear, that you could almost see the sound hitting the rock face. Above the loose stones there was a ledge more or less level, and then the rock rose sheer and solid for perhaps fifty or sixty feet. There are no eagles now in Crete, but looking up the rock, one almost expected to see the eagles swinging and sweeping above. It was a place created to be inaccessible. It could only be approached at all from one side, and any body of men coming to it must have been seen and heard long before they could reach it. Holm-oaks grew thickly, and you had to be on the ledge itself to know that there were two small caves in the rock. I had used them for some weeks before the S.B.S. party arrived, and though

there was nowhere near room for the whole party, we could keep the stores dry there, and slept ourselves on the ledge or among the holm-oaks farther up the gully. Unless the Germans organised a drive in that part of the mountains, there seemed scarcely any chance that any of the party would ever be seen, as we were out of sight of the nearest track. The local shepherd, a square-chested brigand with a heavy black moustache, had to know we were coming, but he was less talkative than most. He had, however, two young shepherd relations who, again to Paterson's dismay, spotted us at once, and would sit about on their haunches hopefully, while the party were preparing a meal. Gradually all the shepherd population of the mountain and through them hundreds of villagers came to know where we were. They looked approvingly at British battle dress, but our manners were often, I fear, unaccountably unfriendly.

The next fortnight or so was spent in arranging food supplies, information and guides. With the help of Micky Akoumianakis we soon had a good sack or two of rusks, potatoes, olives, and sugar, and the shepherds would supply any meat we needed. Finding reliable guides took more time, but Micky knew a young man from a village near the main dump. He had just been into it at night with a friend. They had been to steal petrol to sell on the black market—stealing from the occupation troops was, of course, a popular local sport—but the escapade had gone wrong. When I was first introduced to Phokion, he proudly showed me a tear in his trousers, which he said had been caused by the barbed wire, as he made a hasty get-away from the petrol enclosure. When a Greek villager wishes to protest the truth of an obvious lie, any piece of irrelevant circumstantial evidence is good enough, particularly if somewhat pathetic or ludicrous. So the tear in the trousers made me doubt the

whole story. But I was reassured when Phokion explained his terms. He would take the party to a point in the wire where it was easy to get through, but we must afterwards evacuate him to the Middle East. His young wife and infant child would go to relatives and we must maintain them. From this I was reassured that Phokion meant to carry out his part of the bargain.

The other two dumps in my area were easier, though smaller. One was in an open olive-grove south of Neapolis and Aristeides knew the approaches to it well. Although he could speak no English, he and the sergeant who was to lead that party were soon on the best of terms. They both had the friendliest of smiles which no doubt made up for the lack of a common speech. Aristeides had to guide them by night round the plain of Lasithi, hide them for a day near the dump, then take them to the edge of it, and bring them back to our hideout—a two-nights' march, which might be tricky as the Germans would by then be patrolling. They had, too, some diabolical little camouflaged mines looking like lumps of goat's dung to strew about on the roads, to catch the relief trucks that were bound to make for the dump, once the petrol began to ignite.

After about a fortnight the rest of Paterson's party were due to come in. Paterson was by then thoroughly at home in the mountains. He was lost in the chatter of Greek at times, and at first had no confidence that the Cretans, who spoke much of the reprisals that would inevitably follow, would really provide adequate information and guide us correctly at the vital moments, but when he got to know Micky, they warmed to each other.

The main party were to come in as the moon was waning. It would take two nights getting them into position; we should have to wait for a night or two to give other parties in other parts of Crete time also. Then

all the petrol dumps, we hoped, would blaze away at once. We should hurry back to the hideouts and two nights later be at the coast waiting for a boat. The whole party should be away in about ten days, before the moon had grown sufficiently to make the approach of the M.Ls. to the coast too dangerous.

A few days later the main party landed without mishap, but I was delighted by an incident with two of the S.B.S. privates next morning. We had all walked up the hill together the night before in the dark, but had had no time to look at one another. When we got to the first hideout everyone had bedded down where they stood, and I had gone off with Vassili and his friends to check stores. Next morning early I came back to find the S.B.S. beginning to turn their dry rations into breakfast, and already a lean expectant-looking shepherd had discovered them and was squatting about two yards away in silence. They knew well enough that they were supposed to keep out of sight of everyone, and evidently wanted to get rid of him, but didn't know how to. At that moment I came trudging up the gully with my shepherd's cloak over one shoulder, grinning unthinkingly. I was much surprised, when one of the privates said in loud tones to the other, "Here's *another* of the bloody perishers," (or rather stronger words to that effect). "I hope you had a good night," I said—and have seldom seen two young Englishmen more dumbfounded.

After lying up for a day the party split into two. We ourselves with about twenty-five men could not reach the headquarters in one night, so I had arranged that we should lie up for a day in the plain of Herakleion. The plain is hilly in places, and we knew of a large cave in one of the hillocks, which was normally used as a sheep pen. No one was likely to come there except the shepherd, who was a "good man". We had the usual long night

march, and it was amusing to see how some of the younger S.B.S. men peered about at first as if expecting to see the Germans at any moment. It reminded me of my own first marches, but by then my own party had long since become accustomed to walking about as if there were no Germans in the island at all.

Soon after we reached the headquarters, Micky brought us final news about the main dump and promised to produce Phokion, the guide, next day. Paterson and I were to do one final recce with him, but Micky and he took the fullest precautions to prevent any Greek from knowing in advance who he was.

Micky was as good as his word and Phokion, a thin but wiry young man, arrived just before we were due to start. He was a fast guide, but inclined to bravado. When we got into position he led us round the back of the hillock, on which the dump was sited. It faced south towards the lower ground of the plain, and a path from the north branched round it on either side. Phokion showed us the approaches and took us along the easterly fork of the path past the guard house, and then instead of turning back went on towards the plain. The path led past a second hillock, which was a bomb dump, and beyond this were German huts and tents on the outskirts of Kastelli aerodrome. We got half way down the track where it ran past the bomb dump, and could see a couple of Germans stripped to the waist for their afternoon siesta. As we came on, they seemed to be staring at us; probably the track was out of bounds to Greeks. Then the Germans were joined by several more, and I began to feel that it was really idiotic to go marching straight on. Paterson himself was a tall, strong-built Anglo-Saxon type, and although in civilian clothes, would very soon have been identifiable as British. In any case neither he nor I had adequate Greek passes on us. Phokion, however,

was leading on with almost a chuckle, and the Germans were only about a hundred yards ahead. I was just going to stop, when Paterson suddenly said, "This is no good", and we halted. Although there were olive-trees in the dumps, the rest of the country was lamentably bare stony slope, and all we could do was pretend that we had taken the wrong track. We turned back not overhastily. Behind us one of the Germans called out. However in sandals and trunks most of them were in no shape to give chase up the rocks, and, a short way on, the path curved out of sight, so we beat a quick though not undignified retreat. We got out of sight of both dumps behind a shoulder of hilly ground before any regular chase developed. I suppose both Paterson and I were pretty strung up by this. It was a very narrow squeak, and as it was solely due to the guide's desire to show us what an imperturbable fellow he was, I proceeded to give him as unamiable a rocket as my Greek allowed.

Next day we saw off two small parties, which were to go, one with Aristeides to a dump south of Neapolis, the other to the outskirts west of Neapolis with John Houseman, a young British officer who ultimately capped a series of adventurous episodes by marrying, in the best story-book style, a sister of Micky Akoumianakis. By this time other S.B.S. groups in the centre and west of the island had been able to get into position, but, meanwhile, messages from the local Greeks began to come in thick and fast, indicating that everyone round Kastelli knew that a raid was imminent. It seemed certain that some agent would by now have warned the Germans, or that some frightened father of a family would have warned them himself. I would gladly have given up the whole plan, and so, I think, would Paterson, who, in spite of our warnings, was appalled at the bad security—but it was too late to do so, and in any case Paterson was determined

to go on, even if the risk had been much greater than it seemed.

The S.B.S. had often done such raids before, and I remember that although Paterson, I, and several of the others must have been anxious enough when we set off, we all left in high spirits. The approach march that night might have been slower than usual, as we were all carrying sub-machine guns, ammunition, and a share of explosives, but I suppose the latent excitement bucked us up, and we all reached a deep overgrown ditch about twenty minutes from the target well before dawn. There we crawled in gladly enough.

Ditches in England look wet, mouldy and unwelcoming resting places, but this particular Cretan ditch was at that time of year dry and snug, and the sandy crumbling earth, though dusty, if you were clumsy in handling the rations, was comfortable enough. I don't think I slept much, if at all, but in spite of excitement about the job, it was a pleasant day, even though at times I wondered, amid the cheerful whispers of the commando boys, if the little tent of blue sky that I could see through the briars above me was in fact the last daylight that some of us would ever see again.

Throughout that day we kept hearing villagers walking by on the track beside our ditch. We planned to move up in twilight, and when we did emerge, I found, with some dismay, several villagers staring at the Greek Liaison Officer, Alexandros. They appeared to know, without asking, why we were there, and we gathered that most of the inhabitants of the village nearby were moving out to sleep in the fields that night, as they did not want to be caught in their homes when the Germans came next day.

The route took us about twenty minutes up a stony track which led to the north of the hillock. When we got north of it, we were to follow a track southwards, straight

towards the dump itself. This second track, when it reached the hillock, branched east and west to either side of it. We took the west fork. Then, halfway round the hillock, we would pass the wire, which ran across the top from one path to the other, fencing in the southern half of the hillock. Paterson, Phokion, and the Greek liaison officer were going to a point in the wire on the west side, and when they had found an entry, the rest of the main party would slip through and slink about the dump avoiding sentries, and depositing time bombs on the oil barrels. I was to go with an N.C.O. and one man across the hillock to the east slope and take up a position by the wire, covering the guard house on that side. If an alarm was given, we should open fire when the guards came out of their house, to give the raiding party time to get out of the dump.

Meanwhile we found that we had come up the approach track ahead of time. As we got to the top of it, we could hear a mule or donkey ahead, and, as it came nearer, someone cursing in German. I tried to get sideways off the track on tiptoe. The party knocked over plenty of loose stones, and there was a general rustling as we brushed past the thin grasses or thistles on the hillside. However, the German was evidently returning from some spree in one of the villages. I heard him ask tipsily in pigeon Greek what the noise was, and a Greek who was with him, said it was only sheep or goats moving on the hill. We hurried on and all seemed to be going well. A single friendly plane came over low just as we approached the point where Paterson and my party would leave the last path. Paterson had arranged a plane to come at zero-hour to distract the guards' attention. I lifted a silent blessing to it as it hummed round encouragingly overhead.

Then the two S.B.S. men and myself slipped off up the hillock. In the dark it seemed a long way to the top, and

we were frightened that we might not get into position in time. The ground was rough with plenty of loose rocks and if I had known how close we really were to the dump, I should have been much more frightened of being heard. Suddenly we found ourselves on the crest with the wire on our right only a few yards off. I crouched, peering through the darkness. Somehow I seemed to sense plenty of wakefulness on the other side of the wire. Then we crept down a few yards over the crest. By day we must, I knew, be in sight of the guardhouse, and I paused to listen. A light breeze rustled in the olives. Then, out of sight, but quietly and distinctly, I heard one of the guards talking as one might have heard someone on a warm summer evening at home talking at the far end of a tennis lawn, clearly enough to be heard and quietly enough not to drown the other sounds of the night. We paused, but we were still not up to the wire and when I had become accustomed to the guards talking occasionally, we crept forward again, and I found myself on the lip of a round winnowing floor about ten yards across, with the wire on the far side. The men were on my right, and I crept forward again across the winnowing floor. We could see the light of a cigarette and behind it a more than usually dense blackness, which, as I guessed, was a wall of the guardhouse. One of the guards seemed to be smoking with his back against the wall. The door, I thought, was facing down hill and from where we were, we should catch anyone running out of the guardhouse on the flank at about twenty-five yards range. I wanted to go further downhill to be able to fire at the door more from in front, but the slope was abrupt and broken and it was uncertain if there was a clear field of fire. The best thing seemed to be to go through the wire, and take up a position near the door. The sentries seemed to be stationary enough, and I had a pair of pliers and was just going to cut the wire.

stretched taut, when the N.C.O. with me saved a possibly fatal mistake by whispering suddenly, that if I cut the wire the sentry was bound to hear it. The N.C.O. had plenty of experience from former raids and it was lucky he had, for it had not occurred to me that the wire would twang. I stayed where I was on the lip of the winnowing floor and the men crouched behind some rocks on the right with sub-machine guns trained on the cigarette. It was then about 10.30 p.m. The job would take an hour longer perhaps. Afterwards the main party once clear of the dump, would signal to us by the hoot of an owl. In any event we were to withdraw to a rendezvous at midnight.

Some people would think that the next hour would seem a long one. I don't know why, but it didn't. I remember watching the light of the man smoking. Once or twice he struck a match and once, I think, he gave someone else a light, and I felt how beastly it was waiting there in the dark to murder him at a second's notice. They were friendly voices too. I didn't much like the fact that there seemed to be two wide-awake guards, and once or twice another at the bottom of the slope called up to them. At one point they seemed to be looking for something near the guardhouse, but they never came near the wire. I daresay they didn't want to wander about in the dark more than they could help. There was always the chance for them of bumping into an armed thief, if not worse, and besides that one of the other sentries might mistake them. At any rate they moved with enough noise to give plenty of warning of their approach.

Gradually I got more accustomed to the darkness. The guardhouse I reckoned must be about thirty yards away. We still could not make out the guards, which was just as well as they might have seen us. Most of the time I was straining to hear the members of our own party.

Presumably they had now worked round to our side of the hillock, but all I could hear was the wind in the olives, and the occasional sounds of the night. The talk of the guards became more and more spasmodic. The cigarette had gone out. After we had been there nearly an hour, I began every ten minutes to look at my watch. The first fuses were due to go off shortly after midnight, but the timing could not be exact. Now it was just on midnight and we were about to creep away.

Suddenly somewhere on the front slope of the dump, close enough to make us feel we were in the thick of it, there was a wild flash and a whole chunk of the hill seemed to explode and hurl itself into the air. I heard the sentry scramble to his feet and shout, and then all the pent-up excitement seemed to burst at once. A machine gun on a nearby hillock, firing on fixed sights, began to clatter burst after burst of tracer bullets across the gully that separated it from the dump, and at the same time with a new savage joy at taking part, I began to fire myself and called to the men to fire too. The guards seemed to be trying to get out of the guardhouse, but whether we killed the sentries and penned in the rest, I never knew. We fired single shots after the first burst or two, and there seemed to be no more movement from the guardhouse, but the din continued terrific. I suppose the first explosions only lasted a minute or two, but all this time new barrels of oil were going up one after another. There were five or six explosions, and meanwhile the first machine gun and a second on the other side of the hillock seemed to be firing in panic straight at one another. Somewhere out of sight below us the olives must have begun to burn, and then another explosion would go off and for a second as in sheet lightning we could see the outline of the hillock and across the gully to the nearest machine gun. Down below from near the pathway a single shot was aimed

towards us. It must have been the sentry who had called up earlier to the guardhouse. We sent a shot or two in his direction, but I expect that anyway he was feeling a bewildered terrified soul by then. That was all we heard of him, and above him the tracer bullets were screaming away. I think the outlying machine guns fired into the dump itself each time a new explosion went up.

By this time there was a real glow in the sky. A dozen of the oil barrels and several of the olive-trees must have been well alight, and the heat and flames were setting off other barrels all the time. The men were still firing away single shots but I called to them to get away. They were so intent on spotting a target, as the explosions lit up the hillock, that I had to give the order twice, and then we raced back along the north end of the hillock, and I remember thinking that this was the worst moment for us as the glare was increasing all the time, and we should be outlined as we crossed the crest. As we raced across, there was the horrid feeling that any second now one might get a bullet in the back, but then in a few yards we were across and down the other side, and though the fire still lit our way and there were probably guards on the other side of the hillock, there was no reason for them to expect us. As we legged it northwards, every yard put us further out of danger. But all other emotions were overwhelmed in a carefree ruthless joy that after all the weeks of waiting the raid had been a success. There is something brutishly satisfying to human aggressiveness about pressing the trigger of an automatic weapon and feeling the kick, kick, kick, as the bullets fly from you, and I hugged myself even then at the feeling of relief and release.

The fires were well under way, and as we raced up the valley, the grey rocks were bathed in a rich purple light like the sudden view of a sweep of moor when the heather is in full bloom. Across the dump the machine guns were

still blazing away. Then within a few hundred yards the shadows along the path closed down upon us, and it was suddenly depressing to be in blackness once more, and to remember that there was a long night march ahead, and no knowing what reprisals and what sweeps in the hills would be following after us for the next week or so.

The two S.B.S. men were pleased, too, although they were more accustomed than I was to the sudden transition from tense silent watching to explosive holocaust. We raced away gleefully enough, and in two or three minutes had reached the rendezvous. There we slowed up. There were figures grouped ahead, but in a few seconds we had identified each other, and Paterson was asking anxiously what had started the firing. I couldn't really explain it. I believe now that we just started firing because it was the obvious thing to do when the guards were roused, and I did not regret it, as it added to the confusion, and no doubt prevented the guards from removing any of the time bombs from the oil barrels. There had been, in fact, no need to fire as the main party had already been well clear of the dump. They had given their signal when they left, but we never heard it.

However, all was well so far. There were no casualties and we strode off, half marching, half running. We made the return journey in record time. Crossing the main road we feared an ambush, and slowed up to work across it one or two at a time, but apart from that we sped on; there were grunts of satisfaction from the men through the night, as for hours afterwards they heard bursts of firing continuing behind them, and once a particularly big explosion. We could see far behind the glare in the sky and smoke mushrooming against it.

It must have been half an hour or so before first light, when we clambered into the ravine where our headquarters lay, and slumped down among the rocks.

I had become accustomed by then to letting my body relax completely even on a rough stone surface, but it was a chilly dawn, and we had been sweating all night. Somehow I felt particularly stiff. Suddenly on the rocks below us we could hear men laboriously marching into the ravine. Sprawled as we were it was difficult to take cover. Indeed there was none except the rocks themselves, and we could not have moved unheard, but before the party were upon us, we were all crouched off the track and ready to ambush them. It was an anticlimax when, in the cold dawn light, we realised that it was only John Houseman and his party returning from the dump at Neapolis.

They had had no luck. The day before they had spent lying in an orchard above Neapolis, and all that day by coincidence, as it seemed then, the Germans had been dismantling the dump. They had continued to do so throughout the night, when the attack should have taken place. That seemed odd, until we learnt later that the third party, by an error of timing that no doubt sounds fantastic and might have had grisly consequences for all of us, had attacked their target the night before they were meant to. No doubt that explained the double guard at the guardhouse which we had been watching.

The morning turned into a beautiful, warm, blue day, fresh in the hills. So far all had gone well. The third party came in and had evidently made a fine mess of their dump, though it was a small one. Aristeides' rubicund features were wreathed in a beaming smile, and he and the sergeant who had led the party, without having exchanged a single intelligible word, were by now firm comrades in arms, and spoke enthusiastically in their several ways of each other. "Polly boom!" they said. ("What a bang").

While the raid was being planned, my other work had waited, but all that day I spent interviewing visitors to the headquarters. It sounded as if the other raids had

been successful too, but the talk of them was, as so often, all rumour. About 5 p.m., we set off up the ravine for the long trek to the beach. The shepherds were well pleased with sundry parting gifts. They and their dogs did any tidying up safely enough, and they wished us good luck, good fighting, and a speedy return. The party were in high spirits. It was a still light evening, and the clear strength of the mountains was set in grand relief, as the light slanted across them. I thought for a moment what a glorious life it was. We had timed the march so that we should reach the bare summit at twilight, too late for German fieldglasses on the plain to make out the party, so it must have been about dusk when we finally climbed out of the head of the ravine, looked down towards Kastelli, and there saw to our dismay the village nearest to the dump, as it seemed, already in flames. I had always thought that reprisals were inevitable, and knew that if the Germans burnt the houses, the men would almost certainly be shot too. It didn't bear talking of to Phokion, who came from the village himself. However there was nothing to be done, but go on to the coast. We had to lie next day among some most uncomfortable holm-oaks, but there was no sign of German patrols. The fires which we had seen were again visible from where we were. This convinced Paterson that they did not come from the village burning, but from the dump itself. He had plenty of experience and said that if diesel oil had caught, it was almost impossible to put it out, and it might burn for a week. Eventually we learnt that he was right. The fire in that dump lasted for several days. At the time we thought that miraculously there had been no reprisals, but in fact they followed later, or rather the Germans used this as one of the excuses for rounding up and shooting some scores, if not hundreds of villagers, to terrify the neighbourhood shortly before they evacuated it.

Before dusk, we marched on again. I must by then have been more tired than I knew, but eagerness to get safely to the coast and despatch the party (whose continued presence on the island would now greatly add to the dangers of life there) made me concentrate only on that. In the middle of the night, as we lay outside the village of Skhoinia for a halt, I was feeling that I must eat to keep up my vigour. I had then only cheese on me, and ate two large lumps of it with much distaste. I suppose I was too tired by then to digest anything, and was to regret it later.

We reached the hideout before dawn, and the party lay down contentedly in the trees. We had now two or three days in hand before the boat was due, while the other parties were making for the coast elsewhere. Meanwhile a nearby wireless would soon put us in touch with Cairo.

Nevertheless for some reason which I did not then understand, I felt utterly depressed. I do not think I slept much. Curiously I did not even want to go out of Crete with the rest of the party, who were beginning to describe the enormous extravagances which they would allow themselves when they got to Cairo. I remember lying by myself nearly all that day in the sandy bed of a watercourse feeling good for nothing, and beginning to wonder for the first time if something was seriously the matter with me. The next day I was feeling no better. Paterson no doubt wondered why I just wanted to lie still all day, as we were both active enough normally, and suddenly he said, "I know what's the matter with you. Just look up a minute"—and he lifted one of my eyelids, saw a yellow rim round the edge of my eye, and said, "You've got jaundice."

Chapter Fourteen ♣

MY first reaction on discovering that I had jaundice was one of joyful relief. It is not pleasant to be an outlaw and feel that you have got what seems a serious illness, without knowing what it is, particularly when you have become accustomed to abounding exhilarating health. For several days I had felt in fact like a poisoned rat, with nothing left—if I stayed in Crete—but to crawl away and putrify painfully in some out of the way hole. But to know what was the matter made all the difference. I had taken some medical notes with me before leaving Cairo, and I knew that what you needed for jaundice was largely rest, green vegetables, fruit, and milk. At that time of year all this could be had in Crete easily, and if I lay up with friends, in a few weeks all would be well. On the other hand, if I went back to Cairo with the S.B.S. they would put me in hospital, and only after two or three months would I have been pronounced fit for Cretan life by a doctor who understood nothing of its healthiness, by which time the dénouement of liberation might well have come and gone.

By then we had given up thinking that there would be an invasion, but believed that the Germans would try to evacuate, and that we and the Cretans would be able to harry their rear. I wanted to be with them, however the liberation came. So a few days later when the boat came for the S.B.S.—odd as it would have seemed a year before—I was really glad to stay behind. By then I could walk well enough, so was able to go to the beach with them, and it was good to shake hands with Paterson and feel

that that job was successfully completed. I wish we could have a crack about it now, but a few months later to the sorrow of all of us in Crete and, I am sure, of his men, we heard that Paterson had been killed in an air crash.

For the rest it was an uneventful boat party, but I like to remember best of all a smiling handshake in the darkness between Aristeides and the sergeant of the party he had guided. They still could neither exchange two coherent words in the other's language. "Good luck!" said the sergeant, and added in Greek "Efcharisto", (Thank you). "Kali antamosi," said Aristeides. (May we meet again happily soon). It was a simple parting and the dinghy was rocking to take the sergeant off. I don't suppose they will ever meet again, but each, it was clear, would always share the happiest of recollections of the dawns, and days and nights when they marched and crept and crawled around their oil dump together.

For the next three weeks I had a simple convalescence with the villagers of Favriana and Skhoinia. They took me back to Favriana from the boat, a fearful canary colour by this time, but in reality looking forward to the prospect of merely lying up for a week or two. By day I would lie in a dried-up watercourse outside Favriana in case the Germans came to the village. It was high summer and from the shade of a fig tree I used to watch a tiny lizard flickering its way like a grass-green electric current across the hot earth. Then it would pause, foot in air with head turned, basilisk eye fixed blankly in my direction, so that I never knew if it was really looking at me and thereby stricken motionless with terror or just gazing blindly into space. I had little to read then, and at the time was content to lie still and let the sunlight, and the goatsmilk, and khorta, and grapes purge and strengthen my stale tired body, and to enjoy the genial kindness of the people who looked after me. First it was Vassili Konios and his

family. Vassili's mother was the most remarkable of them all. She was a tiny, toothless, shrivelled-up old lady, who had borne six or seven children. She added with pride that they had all lived. In a Greek peasant family that was what counted. Any woman after all could have ten or a dozen children and many did, but how many could they feed and bring up? Certainly old Mme. Konios had good cause for pride. Vassili himself was the acknowledged leader of the village, and another son had become a doctor in Athens. It was curious to hear them speak of the modern world outside, while the old lady sat before her porch endlessly carding wool on the twinkling distaff, just like an old crone of Homer's day.

After a week or so at Favriana, I moved on to Skhoinia, and there was tended with affectionate and scrupulous care by Mikhali Khaniolakis, and his widowed sister. There were no Germans stationed in the village any longer. There was, however, a doctor who came to see me (with half the village), confirmed the diet of milk, green grass, and grapes on which I was living, and was even more useful in dissuading the villagers from well-meant, and insistent demands that one of them should be allowed to slit the inside of my upper lip. Demonstrations of how easily this could be done had in fact once or twice been made in front of me, one of the demonstrators eagerly flourishing a particularly rusty kitchen knife.

During this time the garrison of Crete was gradually but steadily being reduced. We knew this well enough, and the villages like Skhoinia which the Germans had left, already felt a lightening of spirit. At any time by marching a mile or two the Germans might return but the villagers had lost much of their fear, and they would crowd into Mikhali's living room and sit happily round the iron bedstead—the glory of the household—on which I lay. They kept, too, a fair lookout for Germans, and I should

soon have been hurried away into a little, covered stone trough in a corn-field outside the village, if a patrol had come our way. None did, however, although eventually the talkativeness of one or other of the villagers met with its inevitable retribution. Some weeks after I left, the Germans, learning that an English officer had been quartered there, rounded up the village, and took a number of hostages, including Mikhali. Fortunately they learnt nothing; but when I saw him again shortly afterward, Mikhali looked so much older and more strained, that it was difficult to believe that the same man had been looking after me so carefully and cheerfully a few weeks before.

With the Germans gradually pulling out of Crete and the summer weather keeping the mountain slopes warm at night, it was natural that various small bands which had been in hiding in the mountain caves throughout the winter should increase. Soon word came to me that there was to be a great gathering of the clans above Viannos—a report which I knew was wildly exaggerated, but which meant in fact that the several potential bandit leaders had decided to meet with their followers and affirm their unity. We had throughout been urging them to be united, but that was the last thing in the world they were. My own friends used to say with relish that the bands got on among themselves just as well as a brace of pistols. So I determined to be present myself and to give a cordial blessing from G.H.Q. I thought too that the presence of an allied officer might at least prevent the more passionate spirits from terminating their entente cordiale with mutual fratricide.

Accordingly with two or three of my own trusted party, I hurried off, and in a wild, rock-strewn bowl in the hills above Viannos found that the bands had been gathering into a ragged multitude of two or three hundred men and

youths, accoutred with British, Greek, German, and Turkish firearms, everything, in fact, from a British service rifle to a blunderbuss or muzzle loader. The scene made me wonder if other rebel gatherings had really looked like that. There was the same ragged fierceness about many of the faces, that the less romantic chroniclers might have seen long since in the features of the Highland clans, and the same variety of motives, some honest, some greedy, some fanatical, that could perhaps have been counted among Monmouth's rebels before Sedgemoor, but mostly the modern Cretan bandits resembled their own forbears, the Klephts of the Greek wars of Independence, who for centuries had gathered in the hills, where the Turks never subdued them. It was consciously, even self-consciously, because of that tradition, that a priest stood up first to bless the struggle. It may seem a paradox—but it was no surprise to me—that of the three main bands which were there, it was the communists, I believe, who had thought of providing the priest.

To form the largest band there that day, Bandouvas' younger brother, Joanni, who had been passing from house to house throughout the winter, had now collected the remnants of his brother's followers—villagers and shepherds from Males and Herakleion, individually hardy and nimble in the mountains, and bound together by the local power of the Bandouvas family. They were, however, poorly armed, and always individually liable to commit acts of senseless savagery or wild panic when firing started. With even a whiff of military training as one unit, they would have made excellent commandos. In that respect the other two bands were similar. One was led by Col. Plevres, whom I had met with Tom. He brought many of his own villagers from Lasithi and Herakleion, but in spite of—perhaps because of a reputation for cleverness—he was still not trusted by the other local

leaders. The communists had spread the tale that he was really collaborating secretly with the Germans. I did not believe it, but I knew that Plevres was desperate to get arms. His band contained rather more townsmen than the rest, men who had been with him in Albania, sporting over their workday clothes a Greek army jacket or trousers. Such of them as had army caps kept the Greek crown on them, whereas the communists had torn it off and put instead a pointed star. If anything the communists were more ragged and unkempt than even the other two bands, but in fact it was impossible to tell them apart man for man. The communists appeared to be led by a tall, dark, local doctor, whom I had met agreeably enough with two of his cronies in a warm little cave the previous winter. At the moment he was in a reasonable mood.

This motley host had already squatted down to share a midday meal when I arrived. As well as the three bands, the gathering contained now an occasional German uniform, for odd deserters were beginning to come over. They had slaughtered a goat or two, and most of them seemed to be having the feast of their lives, which made me realise my own high standard of mountain living, as the meal for myself and my party seemed merely an ordinary one. I was, however, occupied at the time in distributing my smiles on the leaders with more or less impartial favour.

After the meal the leaders addressed the multitude, standing one by one on a rock beneath the desiccated trunk of a withered holm-oak. The peasant chorus in front of them looked painfully real, but otherwise it was a romantic scene. At any rate one by one Plevres, the communists, and Bandouvas urged their followers to emulate the bands who had descended in the past upon the Turks, and then exalted the great deeds of their own men in the early days of the resistance—these, though often

fictitious, were already legendary—and then they called passionately and bitterly for the ruthless eradication of the savage Hun. No one loves rhetoric more than the Greek. We had many a vivid gesture and a pose beneath that blasted oak, but we all must have known how valueless it was militarily. For indeed the desire in the men to drive out the Germans was real enough, but the uppermost feeling in the leaders' minds was, I felt sure, suspicion of one another. When it came to my turn, it was false to congratulate them as I did upon their unity, though in fact we did desire unity from them urgently and sincerely enough.

After the speeches there were clappings and cheers and embracings, but having stated flatly that the allies had no concern in Greek politics and wished merely that the Greeks should soon be free to choose their own future, and having indicated too that allied help would go to those who genuinely co-operated with allied plans, I left before the light began to fade, and hurried back up-hill to my own eyrie, now on a new mountain slope above Kastelli.

There the rumours and the sense that the occupation was drawing to a close, and possibly a climax, were in-creasing. Somewhere in the plain an American officer, called Bill Royce, who had joined us in the spring, was close on the heels of the Germans, together with an eager bunch of young Greeks, busily infiltrating through the wire round the slumbering German units a variety of pamphlets, some demonstrating the inevitability of defeat, others offering a safe haven for deserters in the Middle East, others again purely—or rather most impurely—pornographic, for Bill had a strong line in postcards depicting the various ways in which Italian labourers in Germany and the wives and sisters of German frontline soldiers were supposedly enjoying themselves in each

others' company. Bill was a fervent believer in political warfare.

Meanwhile he was also sending to the wireless set a stream of messengers with reports that the German units were thinning out and beginning to pull back to Herakleion. So I decided to go down to the monastery of Angarathos, which was close to Herakleion. There we had many friends and good communications with the intelligence group in the town.

I took with me Antoni Papaleonidas, who had rejoined the party after helping Paddy to kidnap General Kreipe. Antoni was a ruddy, square-chested desperado with a twinkle. His family came from Asia Minor, and in his boyhood had fled from there before the Turks. Since then he had led a roving resourceful life. Paddy soon nicknamed him Wallace Beery, but naturally when we got to know him he seemed to have far more light and shade than any professional strong man in a film, and he used to surprise us by a blend of outward toughness, even roughness, and occasional touches of a strikingly philosophic sensitiveness. Once, for instance, when a young and much better educated Cretan came to our cave to beg for evacuation and almost grovelled on the floor beseeching me to send him to a boat, some of the men would have made fun of him, but I overheard Antoni remark that if a man was made that way by nature, there was no good plaguing him for it. He had too an attractive imagination. It was, for instance, delightful and amazing to hear him say—quietly as a matter of fact—as he did once speaking of a village girl—that her hair was so black you could almost drink it out of a cup.

It was a clear blue morning when we left the headquarters, but the stillness meant heat on the plain. After a succession of glorious mountain days, there was a hint of sultriness in the air. After about an hour's walk along

the loose stony path we met an enormous shepherd milking his goats. He was an old friend of both of us—so large and bony that given one eye he could have passed into legend as a Cyclops. Anyway there he was, swishing the foaming milk hot from the udder round a broad iron cauldron in great Homeric swathes. He commiserated with us on a hot journey, gazed at the unbroken blue of the sky, and remarked with conviction that it would break soon. However, I was accustomed to being encouraged with false hopes by then, and prepared for a long dusty day of marching and sweat. Our route at first lay down the paths which had taken us a month before to the petrol dumps near Kastelli. We skirted the resthouse outside Kastamonitsa and then throughout the morning marched on steadily through sloping fields covered with low vines, which at that time of the year were laden with warm bunches of deliciously sweet grapes.

By the afternoon we had left the vineyards and had reached barren, stony country. To the south lay the plain of Herakleion, which was there flat and open, and to the north a low-lying open coastline. The main German force was scattered among villages in the plain to the south, and there were three or four coastal batteries to the north guarding the Herakleion approaches. The country in between was normally deserted because of its barrenness, and crossing it reminded me uneasily of the distressing dearth of trees.

We had some cheese, rusks and raisins with us—plenty for keeping up our vigour—but by the end of the afternoon were beginning to be glad that the day's march would soon be over. Then we passed a posse of Germans on a hillock to our left. They were out of range, but it was mildly uncomfortable to feel them behind us, and we heard from a passer-by that they were stopping anyone

they met. After that the way ran up a shallow valley with a few olives on one side. On the rest of it there were just thin tufts of grass among the rocks and towards the top the olives ran out. As we neared the crest I was surprised to see motionless on the skyline a tall figure apparently looking down at us. Half his body was out of sight, and the sun which was beginning to drop was in our eyes but, as we neared him, I could see plainly his priest's hat. I had been able to send word ahead that I would be coming, in order that the monastery might send for our contacts in Herakleion to meet me there, and I thought that one of the priests had come part of the way to meet us. It occurred to me with some dismay that possibly he had come to warn us not to go to the monastery. We hastened up the last few yards towards him and then both at once saw squatting beside him, watching us about seventy yards away, a group of nine or ten Germans in field-grey, and therefore remarkably well camouflaged against grey rocks which were mostly in shadow.

"Yermanee!" snorted Antoni, swerving perceptibly; it was something between a growl and a hiss, but there was no need to tell me, and I knew what he did not, that the nasty little metal switch upright between them was the aerial of a wireless and that they could call up the patrol behind us and possibly others as well, to cut us off.

Once we had been seen, the olives behind us down the valley were, we knew, too sparse to hide us for more than a minute or so, and wherever else we turned on those lamentably bare slopes we were bound to be in full view. We could go on in apparent innocence, but, on a day when the patrols were stopping anyone they met, that was the same as capture, for the contents of our sakkoulis —pistols, ammunition, maps, and emergency rations— would have convicted us twenty times over. On the other hand to run outright from where we were was simply

inviting a shot in the back—so before we had really had time to reckon consciously what was best to do, we both swerved off the path into a dip on the far side from the Germans. There was no conceivable reason for branching off the path, but the dip was dead ground for some yards at least and once there we turned and bolted, running bent low, to keep in dead ground as long as possible, hoping that the Germans would expect us to reappear somewhere else. Antoni was a heavily built man and we were both weary with the day's march, but we certainly forgot all feeling of weariness just then. I felt only a consuming anguish that this time at last it must all be over.

As we raced down the valley, I longed to look back, but we reached the olives before we paused. There had been a shout, but the Germans were just appearing on the skyline. At least they were in no great hurry to close on us, and without pausing we rushed through the olives. They seemed even sparser as we ran, and indeed looking from side to side I thought that anyone running through them would surely be seen, but the Germans were a little above us, and from above the olive leaves no doubt gave better cover than the bare trunks from the side. In no time we were through them, had skirted a bare shoulder of hill, and were hurrying towards a village when a friendly shepherd squatting half hidden in the rocks called to us not to enter it. He told us that a company of Germans were searching the houses. We sheered off again but by now the Germans on the crest had evidently decided that it was not worth while to press any pursuit, so we slowed down and began to walk as fast as a man can without appearing in undue haste. I reckoned that there were at least two more hours of sunlight, and I have never longed so intensely before or since for the light to go and leave us—poor undeserving sinners—in blessed darkness.

We skirted the village and soon were making our way

up another low valley of bare rocks. Halfway up there was a little whitewashed chapel, a spring and two or three trees, and what was much better a pair of shepherds in full view. They told us that a German patrol had been there earlier and that it and other patrols had been on the hilltops all day, but it seemed that they were now drawing in to the villages for the night. They told us too of rumours from Herakleion of a proclamation, and that the Germans were driving the area because they believed it had given help to allied officers. The headquarters had apparently proclaimed that German patience was at an end. They had, they said, wished to co-operate with the Cretans, but the Cretans had helped to capture Kreipe, had attacked their petrol, and hidden bandits and allied parties, and now "the rifles would speak".

Actually we knew later that the Germans planned to intimidate the villages lying round Herakleion, by rounding up the inhabitants, keeping large numbers of them locked up for a day or so in the village school or chapel, taking hostages, and executing anyone suspicious. This was clearly not an immediate reprisal for anything done by the Cretans, but an act of planned policy to terrorise the neighbourhood and protect the German rear from organised resistance before the time—a week or two later—when the evacuation of Herakleion was to begin in earnest.

We did not know this at the time, and believed as the Cretans did, that they were suffering reprisals for aiding their allies, all of which made Antoni, as I later realised, unwilling to trust to local help. All the same there was no reason to distrust the report that the Germans had already been to the chapel where we were and from it we could see any other party approaching a long way off. The shepherds told us too that if we went to the head of that particular valley, there would be other Germans

watching on the far side, so there we waited, recovering gradually from a feeling of mental numbness, the reaction from previous over-alertness.

One of the shepherds said that he knew a good little cave where we could spend the night safely. I myself would have preferred to walk out of the patrolled area, and chance running into an ambush, but we did not know the country, and were told that the Germans had been active at night, shooting at anyone they saw.

Meanwhile dusk was falling, and after a time we made our way slowly down from the chapel, and clambered over a low slope of loose rocks. It was still open country and our steps on the rocks seemed to ring out for miles. A few hundred yards away Germans were dossing down in a village, but in the twilight they could no longer see us. Then the shepherd stopped by a long flat rock, rolled it aside, and beyond we saw a black slanting hole big enough to take the bodies of four or five men. Into it we crawled. The shepherd replaced the stone, whispered that he would come back in the morning with food, and then for a little we heard his footsteps padding away down the slope. If anyone was listening we must have sounded a mysterious and eerie troop—first, the three cloaked shadows passing up the slope with three pairs of boots ringing on the rock, and then two of them stopping dead and only one ghostly pair returning.

At night the rocky hillsides soon grew chilly, but inside our cranny the air was warm. The sloping floor was rough and jagged but we knew how to fit our cloaks and sakkoulis under us, fit our bodies to the rocks and still go quickly to sleep. Indeed for the present we were safe in the darkness and soon were both, I imagine, as oblivious of what had passed that day, as the rocks around us.

When I woke a thin cold grey glimmer was edging its way round the rock door. It must have been an hour

before dawn. Normally the promise of a clear blue day was exhilarating, but the recollection of our chase the day before only filled me that morning with a feeling of dread. I would gladly have stayed the whole day in the cave in the hope that the Germans would have gone back to billets by the following night, but Antoni was insistent that we must get away at once, and I realised that he did not trust our guide of the night before.

I trusted Antoni completely, so took his advice at once, but we climbed out on to the hillside with mounting anxiety. We had decided to make towards a line of low hills towards the sea and then skirt along them eastwards. This, if we could reach it, seemed to be rather less bare country than the dry rocks where we were.

After a little Antoni gave a grunt and muttered that the Germans were out again. He was too concerned for once even to curse them. I could see two groups, one behind and one on higher ground to the east of us, and then as we came on to higher ground ourselves, a third group came into view. They were picketing another wayside chapel and blocking the line we should have taken, and as we looked at them they began to move towards us. It was then that for the first time I felt something I suppose very like despair—an inner conviction that this time the game was up. There could be no explanation for our presence there then; the Germans were evidently again picketing the high ground and making for anyone they saw; we should never be able to keep away from them for twelve and more mortal hours. For the first time in my life I wanted to curse the sunlight out of the sky. I felt nothing else, I think, but bottomless misery and an overmastering longing to be snatched away from that arid landscape and its dangers.

In front there was a slope in full view of the Germans and a rise the other side. There in all probability there

would be another picket, but beyond it was dead ground to the Germans who were coming towards us, and the only thing left was to get there and hope to find a hiding place, although all the time we were getting pushed nearer to the coast and the German batteries along it.

The Germans approaching us were still five or six hundred yards away, but if we walked on would be in easy range as we went up the far slope, so dropping all further pretence we ran down and scrambled up the far side. To my relief the early morning patrols had evidently not reached that particular hillock yet. In front the ground ran down in a shallow valley to the sea. On the left hand side was a small olive-grove, and up both sides there were paths converging near us at a spring and water trough, with a thick clump of brambles. There we filled our waterbottles, before crawling into the brambles. They were excellent cover and again the luck seemed with us, but just as I was settling myself conveniently we heard voices nearby. That was less of a shock than it might have been, for the voices were obviously Greek. They were two villagers, who had been keeping out of the way in the olives, but from curiosity had come up to see what we were doing. They warned us that the Germans would certainly come up one of the paths, and stop at the spring and would fire into the brambles to clear them of anyone hiding there. Antoni and I had heard before that this was the way they often cleared a patch of undergrowth. Indeed I had already felt that the brambles were too good to be true. So we took the villagers' advice and hurried down into the olives, though they were distressingly sparse.

The Germans who had seen us cross the first valley were evidently sticking religiously to their own beat. They never appeared over the high ground after us, but soon afterwards a second file came slowly past us towards the spring—two or three carrying a machine gun and eight

or nine trailing along wearily with their sub-machine guns —for the sun was beginning to get hot. They were on the side of the valley away from the olives, about 150 yards off, but we each had an aged trunk between us and them, and each moved quietly round, keeping the trunks in the way as they passed. Anxious as we were, we could not help exchanging a grin. To me it was exactly like hide-and-seek round an old oak in a garden in Surrey twenty-five years before. I don't know what childish recollections Antoni had, but the sight of his swarthy smile did me good. The whole day it never occurred to me—and I'm sure not to him—that he might have left me to find my own way back, although if he had, his own chance of survival would have been far greater.

Once the Germans were past us we backed away from our trees, and then slipped to the bottom of the olive-grove. The path on our side was still in view of the Germans but now they had their backs to us, and we raced down it without much fear that they would look round, till the path itself bent out of sight. There were scattered bushes now, and as we ran on a number of heads poked out of a sunken ditch near the path. They were villagers driven that way from a village just west of us, and they told us that the Germans had surrounded their village early that morning, and were keeping anyone they found, shut in the church; they had threatened to shoot them for helping allied raiding parties. As our new companions at once guessed that I was British, I could see that Antoni had no wish to stay with them, for one of them might have decided, understandably enough, to save his or her kith and kin by directing the Germans to us. Their anxiety was all the greater, when shortly afterwards we heard a burst of firing up the valley. I expect it was the last German patrol firing into the brambles. At any rate after warning the villagers that the Germans might be coming

down the path on our side of the valley, we hurried on and found a slope blessedly dotted with gorse bushes. It was now midday and a sultry day at that, and for a time we rested in a sort of badger's warren under a gorse bush. The gorse was on relatively high ground near a village and therefore likely to be beaten shortly; below us the ground fell steeply to a well with a clump of figtrees and long grass round it. If we could get down unseen, we thought we should be able to lie hidden in the grass with little chance that anyone would search there. Unfortunately the ground between was bare, and as we began to cross it another party of Germans came into view on the outskirts of the neighbouring village. There was no good trying to hide in sight of them, and once in dead ground we turned up a path towards them looking for cover. Then two villagers came hurrying in the opposite direction with a warning that the Germans were approaching, and we all bundled precipitately into a providential vineyard. At that time of year the vines gave good cover from the side, but anyone on higher ground could have seen us crouching among them. However, once more we were living from moment to moment, and the best thing to do was to flatten ourselves round the vine stems with the leaves and clusters trailing over us and trust that the Germans would march hopefully by.

I had time to feel how weary of it all I was, and to wonder if fear would make me run as fast as yesterday if I had to, when suddenly and decisively our lucky star or divine providence or what you will, came to the rescue. I have mentioned that the weather had been sultry, but we had had no time to remember the forecast of the old Cyclops—that the weather would break—or to notice that the sky was darkening and about to burst in the most thunderous of thunderstorms, with lightning and lashing rain. But a moment or two later this happened, and as the

water soaked us to the skin I could suddenly have laughed and laughed with joy—for no German patrol after a day's marching would go plunging through that driving deluge in the hopes of rounding up a few more bedraggled and terrified peasants. They had been at it two days at least. Now was just the weather to call off the exercise. And indeed though the Germans were tough and vigorous enough, that is just what they did. The downpour lasted till five. The Germans took cover and then when it was over assembled to march back to their billets; and we who had slunk out meanwhile to the protection of the fig-trees watched them go with gladdening hearts. As dusk fell we set off on a long but thankful moonlit walk to the peace and protection of the Lasithi mountains, which we reached unmolested at dawn.

Chapter Fifteen ♣

A DAY or so later we learnt that all the German nurses in Crete were being withdrawn, and coupled with much other evidence of units pulling out of their normal stations, the news convinced me that the final evacuation had begun. I wired this to Cairo, but almost at the same time received a message from Tom, telling me to join him at the monastery of Arkhadi. He had reached the same conclusion and was assembling all the officers there to concert plans for harrying the Germans' departure.

We met Tom at the headquarters of a large band led by Kapetan Petrakogeorgis. Petrakogeorgis was a tall cordial bravo, who, before the occupation, had run a successful olive crushing business. He had led a party of local followers in the battle of Crete, and after it they had taken to the hills. His eldest son had been killed by the Germans. In spite of offers of amnesty and latterly a heavy price on his head, he had remained at the head of a tough, but reasonably prudent band ever since. The nucleus of it throughout had been a score or so of hawk-nosed banditti, each with the usual knife in his belt and bandolier across his chest, looking what in fact they were, the bucks of the district, happily accoutred to play the part of the third murderer. This ferocious bodyguard contained several men of really outstanding height and presence, and its fame had long since spread throughout the length and breadth of the island. By this time the numbers had greatly increased, and we found Petrakogeorgis watching his lieutenants enrol a new group of wondering, but eager volunteers, who had come up that afternoon from various

villages. He welcomed us to his eyrie among some large precipitous and well-wooded rocks on the western slopes of Mt. Ida, as though he had long been the lord of the whole mountain. Having been in pre-war days the nearest thing to big business in that part of Crete, he had been given the code-name Selfridge. Any delicacy in his particular store, whether a sheep's eye, a goat's brain, a sprig of garlic, or in more up-to-date style a spoonful of dehydrated carrot, was ours, I felt sure, for the asking, and our welcome was all the pleasanter because I knew that his band would try to carry out loyally any orders, which we might be getting from G.H.Q. Incidentally, Petrakogeorgis later became famous far beyond the bounds of Crete, as the parent in a modern Montagu and Capulet story. It was his eldest daughter Tassoula who was abducted subsequently by another staunch supporter of ours, called Kefalogiannis, one of the leading beaux from a rival clan from Anogeia.

Aided by members of the Anogeian band Kefalogiannis carried Tassoula off into his own mountain fastnesses and they were married in a deserted chapel. Such abductions are still not uncommon, but as Tassoula was pursued by her father and his men, and as Kefalogiannis also was the scion of a celebrated mountain family, the two clans were for a time seething with vengeful rage, and the whole island, excited by the world-wide celebrity given to it, lived for a week or so in pleasurable agitation at the prospect of being on the brink of civil war. The affair was only settled after the personal intervention of M. Sofocles Venizelos, the then Prime Minister, himself a Cretan.

When we met Petrakogeorgis, his band was centred some two hours' march above the monastery of Arkhadi, to which we went next day. Arkhadi had already an honoured place in modern Greek history. It was there during the War of Independence that the Greek defenders,

after a prolonged siege, blew themselves up over the powder magazine as the Turks rushed the last defences, and with this tradition behind them the abbot and monks were proud to play their part in resistance to the Germans. Ever since the battle of Crete they had been helping British escapers or agents or their own local bands.

That evening six or seven of us dined with the abbot. Originally there had only been three officers regularly in Crete, Tom, Paddy, and Xan Fielding, but by this time there must have been ten or so. Every hour a new officer would arrive from some different part of the island, and it was delightful to meet old friends again or be introduced by Tom to men, of whose doings I had often heard by the bush telegraph which operated from mountain to mountain. There was Bruce-Mitford, a red-haired Highlander, like Tom an archaeologist, who strode about the mountains as if thirsting to stick his dirk into some Teuton midriff; a young Polish officer called Stan, a handsome romantic soul quietly determined to go on fighting his country's enemies, wherever they might be; a young lieutenant called Fraser, who was so fair-haired that any German should have known two miles away that he could not be Cretan; and Stephen Verney, who being a conscientious objector at the beginning of the war had served in a Friends' Ambulance Unit throughout the desert campaigns, and then, having decided to become a combatant, volunteered for what he no doubt believed was the most dangerous job he could find.

That night we slept quietly in a copse a few hundred yards from the monastery. Though the abbot would have liked to offer us a whole dormitory, the Germans had been issuing too many threats of late, and there was no point in chancing a sudden German round-up of the monastery, which they were apt to arrange at dawn.

Next morning Tom discussed with me the position

round Herakleion; our main purpose was to save the harbour from demolition, when the Germans withdrew, and for that Tom was helping our committee of friends in the town to bribe the German engineers. We hoped also that the bands who would assemble outside Herakleion would be able to rush the gates and allow John Lewis and a picked party to capture the jetty, and either stop the demolition preparations or neutralise the demolition party, if they could not be bribed. Tom said that he would need one officer with a wireless set inside the town in the final stages. He had recently spent a week or so in Herakleion interviewing the committee there, but would have to remain with Petrakogeorgis and the other bands outside the city in the final stages, so it was agreed that I should go in to keep in touch with the Greeks who were negotiating with the Germans, and collect information about the withdrawal for Tom and the bands outside. Stephen Verney was to do a similar job in Canea. Bruce-Mitford and Fraser were to stay in that area, and Bill Royce was to accompany Tom to Herakleion and continue to harry the Germans with every form of depressing propaganda.

We made the journey to the outskirts of Herakleion without mishap. It would take, I knew, three full days at least, but we had had word that the Germans would evacuate the town on September 16. That would give just a day or two to get into position before they left, so I hurried on with an increasingly urgent feeling that we were all on the point of shooting the rapids. In a week's time, as I thought then, either the occupation of part of Crete at least would be ended and ourselves rejoicing, or there would have been a bloody massacre, and many of us would be dead. If anyone was going to get killed, it seemed at the moment that I had myself a high priority. I longed passionately for it to be over.

On the second day we were joined by my old friend of parachute training days, Friar Tuck, the flying parson. It was in fact little more than a year since we had trained at Haifa together, but it seemed, looking back on our many wanderings since then, as if we had lived a whole lifetime in Crete. And for Friar Tuck at least the whole tenor of life had been forcibly changed. He had been the senior priest of Anogeia, one of the largest and most prosperous villages in the island. Its four thousand inhabitants were famous for the fine rugs they wove from their flocks on Mt. Ida, but the Germans knew that the Anogeians had helped us. Probably they feared that the menfolk of Anogeia would shoot up their vehicles as they withdrew from Herakleion through the hills westwards to Rethymno. In any event a few weeks before, Anogeia had been utterly demolished.

It is difficult for anyone who has not seen it to imagine a scene of deliberate large-scale destruction. The Germans had surrounded the village, but most of the men had latterly been sleeping out of doors for fear of a surprise, and thus escaped. The rest were shot. The women and children were then driven out on to the hillside, and the work of demolition began. It was said that anyone who was bedridden was burnt or blown up inside the houses. At any rate a company of engineers had remained in the village for a fortnight methodically blowing up or burning every dwelling-place. When ten days after they had left, Friar Tuck took me with a certain quiet pride into the midst of the desolation, not a single house was erect. The Germans had left the three churches, but our way was blocked at every step with lumps of stone and broken tiles, or sherds from the jars, in which the village oil or wine had been stored. Down the barely discernible route of the village streets we made our way first to Friar Tuck's church, the largest of the three. It was astonishing to find

still hanging in their places, richly silvered and gilded ikons surrounded with faded flowers. Outside lay rotting with nauseating stench the carcase of a sow burnt to death in a nearby stable.

From the church Friar Tuck took me to a mound of rubble surrounded by the shattered stone stumps of what had once been four walls, and then propping in the centre of it the remains of a wooden chair, he sat me on it and pulling a little bottle of ouzo and a noggin cup like a large thimble from his pocket, he said with a full sense of the dramatic but not without dignity, in a tone that was both solemn and gay, "Well, Mr. Alexis, I always said that one day I would welcome you to my house. As you see, there's not much left, but at least we can offer you a glass." We smiled at one another and toasted freedom, victory, and the honour of the house. We were soon surrounded by a little group of Friar Tuck's elderly female first, second and third cousins and a flock of grandchildren who somehow or other had gathered out of the ruins. "Kali Elevtheria." "Fair is Freedom", they murmured as we emptied our glasses. Not that they knew what they were saying. The phrase had become a national catchword, little understood but repeated as a prayer for better days. In spite of the appalling devastation everyone was smiling. They were all too thankful that the occupation was finally ending to care about anything else.

Soon we were on our way again, this time to join the Anogeian band, who were hiding in the slopes overlooking Herakleion. The evening mist was rising, all the whiter for the moon above it, but soon we found the Anogeians and Michael Xyloures, a white-haired, charming old Cretan gentleman who had been throughout one of Tom's steadiest stand-bys. Now he had some seventy of the Anogeians waiting to be infiltrated into Herakleion, in twos and threes. Once I was in, I had to

confirm the date of the Germans' withdrawal and then send back word to the Anogeians. They would come under my orders inside Herakleion. For irregular troops I could not have had better support and Xyloures was clearly an excellent leader, but we had as yet no plan, knowing too little of the Germans' future movements.

Next day a young friend of Micky Akoumianakis took me across country to Micky's home. Micky, being the eldest son of Manoli Akoumianakis, who had been the chief foreman on Sir Arthur Evan's Minoan excavations, lived beside the site of the ancient Palace of Minos at Gnossos. We actually rendezvoused with Micky in one of the reconstructed chambers of the Minoan capital with half an eye on the frescoed bulls and minotaurs of the ancient Palace, and the other half on the Germans in the Villa Ariadne.

That evening however I was much too intent on making our way into Herakleion to bother about archaeology or information about the local Germans, who were no doubt busily preparing their general's evening meal. Micky was to stay outside for another night and would bring in the wireless operator, and it was arranged that the guide Elias would take me in just before curfew as dusk was falling, when there would be a crowd of Herakleiots pressing in before the gates shut. Herakleion being an old Venetian walled city, it was an easy matter for the Germans to close it at night, or indeed to check people coming in and out by day.

On the way in the road curved through olive-groves and then crossed a low bridge. There the Germans often posted a picket to check the road transport, but one of Micky's younger brothers came in with us thus far, keeping forty yards or so ahead to give us warning. Rounding the bend he made a sign behind him to my companion, so unobtrusive that I did not even recognise

it, at which the guide quickened his step and muttered that all was clear.

From this point onwards there were German units on either side of the road all the way, but they were bivouacking for the night, intent about camp fires which were blazing brightly, as the dusk fell; their cooking must be over before the blackout. We passed the cemetery outside the town, which had been a landmark during the fighting in 1941. From there the road sloped down for half a mile or so with a double row of houses lying well back from it. Along both sides the German transport was densely parked. We reached an open space before the old Venetian wall, a quarter of an hour or so before the road block at the entrance was due to close. It was here I knew that we might run into a sudden check, but almost before I knew what had happened we were abreast of a concrete pill-box and had skirted a pole across the road. For good or ill we were now inside the walls.

Although the idea of a walled city with the exits watched was disquieting, it was in fact a great relief to be inside, for my identity card, though a beautiful forgery, had been sent from Cairo after I reached Crete, and still required a stamped photo to be attached to it. I had had a photo taken, but a mayor of our acquaintance had been understandably reluctant to sign and stamp it. I had had no other opportunity to get it completed, and after a time I had counted upon not having to produce it in the hills. For our entry the lack of it had seemed a serious disadvantage, but, once we were inside there were sixty thousand Herakleiots crowded there too, and unless we were caught by a sudden snap check, we were safe enough with or without the proper papers.

Elias led me quickly past a couple of large open-air cafés; it was the hour when any medium-sized Mediterranean town goes for its evening promenade, so the open

space before them was crowded. In a provincial town of that size everyone knows everyone, but Elias was far too determined and experienced to stop and show me off to his friends. Soon we were out of the little park at the east end of the town and had entered a quiet, dark street near the harbour. One or two of the houses seemed to have back gardens abutting on the street, and one of these which seemed more derelict than the rest had no gate. We slipped through the open space where the gate should have been, unseen by anyone, and I found myself in the shadow of a palm tree in one corner of the garden or backyard, while the guide knocked quietly on the door of the neighbouring house. It opened, and a dark quiet woman of about thirty-five welcomed us gravely inside.

My first impression was an unexpected one—merely that it seemed monstrously convenient to have electric light once more. From now on our activities could be conducted at the tempo and with the conveniences of civilisation. The woman, whose mother-in-law had been a servant at the Villa Ariadne, was a cousin of the guide. She and her husband with Elias and Micky could keep in frequent touch with various helpers throughout the town, and it was really impossible for any of the German units or headquarter services to make a move without our knowing it. What would be much more difficult was to know their actual time-table for leaving, which was all-important to us; from what we had seen already, they could not leave as early as we had expected, and meanwhile the Anogeian band was presumably on its way.

However, it was no good worrying about what was happening or to happen just then. I had at the time no means of communicating with anyone outside the walls, and would not have till next day when runners could get in and out again. We spent the evening poring over a

large-scale map of the city, spread over the dining-room table. With Elias' help I soon got into my head the layout of the harbour and its defences. He knew it well himself, though not so well, perhaps, as another of our helpers, a small, thin but wiry little accountant in one of the banks—Christophoros Mamakos, who, a few months before, had wangled for himself a pass into the harbour through work for the Red Cross, after which he had accustomed the guards to see him fishing there quietly. Then one day he had been able to slip alongside a cargo boat and plaster against its hull, just below the water line, a "limpet", which he had hidden under his armpit. Limpets were convenient little contraptions full of explosives, in shape like half a globe with magnets on the flat side to make them stick. They contained a detonating device which operated when a charge of acid had eaten through a metal retainer, after a suitable interval. Niko's limpet had been timed to do its job a few hours later and in fact exploded and sank the ship just after it left the harbour. This was, of course, only one of many such stories; but when, some weeks later, I had the pleasure of hearing Niko recount something of it himself with sweet and guileless innocence, it seemed almost incredible that he could have ever done anything else all his life but sit primly behind a cashier's desk. At the time he was promenading with a young, and evidently loving, wife, both immensely proud of a charming baby covered in frills and flounces in the depths of a new pram.

On the morning after I reached Herakleion, Micky brought in the wireless operator; they were in high spirits after passing through one of the gates. For Micky this was an everyday occurrence, but this time they had with them a very second-hand suitcase looking so nondescript and innocent that I recognised it at once from the camouflage workshop in Cairo, and knew that the wireless set was

fitted inside. The wireless operator, Aristeides Paradeisanos, was then aged about 18. Both his parents had been taken hostage, and killed when the troopship which was taking them to the mainland was sunk. The father had volunteered to go as a hostage in his son's place, so that Aristeides could work for us. Perhaps it was this that made Aristeides exceptionally conscientious about his job. Like almost all young Greeks he enjoyed too to the full the absurdities of underground existence. In fact I never wished for a pleasanter or more loyal young companion.

Micky had brought with him plenty of information about the Germans. There were announcements too in the local paper, and the wireless soon began tapping away messages to Cairo. There were still far too many Germans around Herakleion to make any smash and grab attack feasible, and we sent word to Michael Xyloures not to start infiltrating his men into the town.

Meanwhile the acting bishop together with a small committee of prominent citizens had got into touch with the Germans and reported through Micky that they were apparently willing to leave the town and harbour if they could be assured of a safe withdrawal. They wanted also, we were told, a relatively modest sum in gold. Actually we had been prepared to give the Greek committee up to a hundred gold sovereigns for this, but in the end the Greeks—who are enthusiastic and persevering in business matters—knocked the Germans down and we had a report that they had got a promise of their harbour, as it were, for ninety. In the end it was less. We actually parted with eighty. We could not trust the Germans, however, and sometime that day Micky, through his sub-agents, received a guarded message from the German counter-espionage office asking him to contact them directly. I was in two minds at first about letting Micky go. He was,

of course, a key man, whom we could not afford to lose, if anything went wrong. Also he might well be followed after meeting the counter-espionage officers and that would give away the location of the wireless set, not to mention ourselves. In fact on the face of it any contact was dangerous, but he was convinced that his safe conduct to them would be honoured.

This too seemed likely, so I agreed. Looking back on it I realise that at this stage I made a mistake in not going to the Germans myself. At the time it never occurred to me. We were then, of course, planning to attack the Germans and they still seemed deadly enemies. But they were by then far more anxious to find some reliable channel of communication with the allies than to hunt out any small group of agents in the town.

Micky came back from his meeting well content. An officer in the counter-espionage office whom he knew already by name and sight, and who was apparently amused to confirm that Micky, whose face he also knew, had been an agent all along, told him that the Germans would not blow up the harbour, unless they were attacked, but if they were, the harbour would be demolished and the town bombarded with their artillery, which was already closely concentrated round it. They were quite adamant that the airfield must be blown up in any event, and also any ammunition which they did not take, but apart from this, they would leave Herakleion undisturbed. So far, so good.

Next morning, however, we had come into a front room to have breakfast and start work early—at, in fact, precisely five minutes to seven, because the agents depended on the hours of sunlight—when we heard outside the unmistakable tramp of a party of men marching. At first Aristeides and I merely exchanged interrogative smiles. But there was no doubt at all that it was a party

of Germans, and the sound grew louder and louder. We listened intently. They were marching down the back street by which we had come, and getting almost level with the house. As far as I knew there was only one way out of the house—by the door leading straight on top of them. By the time they were level, our encouraging smiles had turned into unfeigned anxiety; I laid down a piece of toast and groped for a pistol. At this moment the door opened and Khariclea, the lady of the house, popped her head in, and announced hurriedly that it was the German harbour picket going to relieve the night watch. Remarking no doubt that this did not seem so much of a joke to us, as it did to her, she gave us a cheerful reassuring grin, closed the door, and returned to her kitchen. By the time we had collected a smile, the tramping had passed on down the street with an almost insulting steadiness. Next morning the same thing happened, but this time we merely listened intently; by the third morning we paid no attention and went on eating breakfast. After that we should have been disappointed if they had not clocked in, as it were, at the usual hour.

For the first two or three days Aristeides and I lived in the back room. We had a map spread over the large kitchen table with a tablecloth folded at one end, ready to throw over it, in case anyone unexpected came in. Otherwise a sudden visitor would merely have thought, perhaps, that we were a couple of down-at-heel students. Each day I wrote a report to Tom, and messages for the wireless, and kept trying to work out the date when the Germans would leave. Each day their perimeter round the town shrank. I doubt now if they had a fixed plan for their departure. It depended partly on the number of air transports which left each evening, and which from nightfall onwards we could hear groaning low over the town. The number of the aircraft varied nightly, for the

aerodromes round Athens to which they went were, as we guessed, being much bombed at the time.

We sent many messages—perhaps twenty a day. They had to be carefully compressed, for the German signals headquarters was only a few hundred yards away. They were certain to hear our tapping before long and would realise that an unknown transmitter was at work close by, and they had vehicles with them, as we knew, fitted with direction-finding apparatus. If we had stayed on the air for more than ten minutes or so the direction-finders would have had time to locate the house.

The general sense of confusion was increased by messages which kept coming in from the acting bishop, the Herakleion committee of our political organisation, and the communists inside the town. The acting bishop wanted to save the town from reprisals (so did we, unless the harbour could only be saved by a skirmish in the last stages). The committee wanted to co-ordinate any advice of theirs to their members in the town with any military action which we took, and the communists wanted to know our plans, partly to be able to throw the blame on us for any reprisals, and partly in the hope that we might protect them from the other bands (which, fortunately, out-numbered them).

Meanwhile I had to try to keep in touch with the Anogeian band and direct it to hideouts in the town. We had runners coming in and out of Herakleion, and there were too many people passing in and out of the town by day for it to be possible for the Germans to make any careful search of them. It was easy to smuggle messages in and out inside a sock or a boot or the lining of a belt, but Xyloures and his men were moving at the time and I could not be sure when messages would reach them. The situation was changing so rapidly, or rather the final evacuation was taking so much more time than we had

expected, that I had to tell Xyloures to wait, and on the second night he rightly took his men some two hours back from Herakleion and out of the plain. This meant that they would not be found and attacked before they were needed, but it also meant that I was for the time out of touch with them.

As long as the gates remained open there were messages coming and going, but about 6 p.m. the gates were closed for the night, so on the first evening I took the opportunity before curfew (about 7 p.m.) to have a quick look at the streets running to the harbour. Micky guided me, and although we could not enter the harbour, I was able to get the lie of the land and the shape of most of the buildings into my mind's eye. On the second evening we went out at dusk for a gay little stroll through back streets to the café of the Three Comrades, where we settled down unobtrusively among the crowd in front of an old Venetian fountain. Micky and Elias, who was with us, were delighted to point to a notorious collaborator who, they said, had done very nicely for himself during the occupation, but was now preparing to go into hiding.

We supped our Turkish coffee and glasses of cold water, and watched the Germans hurrying by, hardly anyone taking any notice of them—and I felt amid the gossip and life of the town, as if I had come out of some underground burrow into an unaccustomed world. In the end I was quite glad to return again to our little backroom. Strolling in the town, though amusing for a time and a relief from incipient claustrophobia, was too like walking on a stage to be comfortable for long.

By this time it was clear that our sojourn in Herakleion, so far from lasting some 48 hours, might well be prolonged, and I was beginning to feel anxious at the unnecessarily large number of people who already knew where we were. The messengers were not brought in to meet us, but most

of them must have guessed that we were nearby, and so, I felt sure, did many others. When I returned that evening, there were three young women in the front room, gaily chattering away, and evidently most curious to catch a glimpse of the visitors.

For the rest of that week we lived day by day in an ever increasing tempo of messages, without any definite sign that the Germans were really on the point of going. Meanwhile Aristeides and I had moved out of the back room to the house next door, which was uninhabited. It had been badly shaken through air raids and through the explosion in the harbour of a ship loaded with ammunition. Khariclea was the caretaker, so could slip in and out with messages and meals without arousing attention. The staircase was rickety, but the walls and roof were more or less intact, and there was an admirable attic, which could only be reached by a ladder. We lived for about a week in the attic, drawing the ladder up after us; food was brought in a basket, and we hauled that up on a cord. No one walking through the place could have reached us without bringing a ladder of their own up two flights of stairs.

I got really very fond of the attic. It was low but long; there was enough light to work by day and we had torches at night. It seemed free and near the sky, which was an agreeable contrast to the windowless ground floor room which we had come from. There was, of course, no plumbing, but by storing pails and jars of different sorts at the far end, we got round the lack of a lavatory. Aristeides, the wireless operator, who fully entered into the fun of it, was pleased to be sending a stream of hot news to Cairo.

By this time communications with Tom, who was standing by the Greek Government's representative, Colonel Nathenas, were becoming more and more difficult, and as our original plans were now much out of date,

I decided to go out to see Tom and discuss the situation. Micky had been using a taxi for messages, so we set off to pick up the taximan, who was on friendly terms with the German guards at the gate. For security purposes we got into the taxi near the gate itself and I snuggled down in the back seat. If anything went wrong they were going to pretend that I was ill.

I had a nasty jolt, however, when the car stopped fifteen yards short of the gate. The driver was waving violently across the street. If we waited there, the German sentries, who were watching us, would come to inspect the trouble. Presumably for that reason Micky began speaking to the driver in Greek too violent to be comprehensible to me. Then the car gave a lurch and we sailed on under the gateway. Apparently our chauffeur, in the affable friendly manner of Greek relatives, had merely seen some distant cousin and been offering him a lift out of town.

A few minutes later we reached the village where Tom had his headquarters. There we found considerable confusion. Colonel Nathenas, a conscientious officer, held an impressively stamped piece of paper from the Greek Government in Cairo authorising him to act as military governor of the island, but he had no real means of controlling the different bands. He was also already surrounded with a host of insistent place-seekers. Tom was backing him up wherever he could, and using his own influence with the leaders to keep a threat to the Germans in being, but of the five bands, all of which had grown considerably in the last few weeks, only the Anogeians and Petrakogeorgis would be inclined to obey our instructions.

Of the other three bands one was communist under Bodias, located due south of the town. The other two under the brothers Bandouvas and Col. Plevres were

east of the town close to the aerodrome. We believed that they were more intent on seizing a full share of authority after the Germans left, than of doing anything to drive them out. For various reasons we had advised against arming these bands on any large scale, and their leaders had ceased to hope for much help from us. We had therefore no influence over them. By devious means they did, however, acquire a number of German arms, which meant on the one hand that the communists were mortally afraid of them (no bad thing in itself), but on the other hand it was clear that there would be no concerted action against the Germans. We still hoped, however, that a remnant of the garrison might be caught or attacked when they finally left. Meanwhile it seemed that the wireless in Herakleion would be useful to signal what was happening, so after talking over the situation with Tom, I went back to Herakleion with Micky.

A day or so later the Germans began taking special precautions, and it became clear that the party under John Lewis, which we hoped would prevent the demolition of the harbour, could no longer be smuggled in and hidden near it. Evidently the fact that we were planning an attack was known to the Germans, which was not surprising. Tom had warned me that there were German agents at Colonel Nathenas' headquarters, and in any case many of our acquaintances knew that we were planning an attack, which might end in reprisals on the city. There was therefore an increasing risk that we might be given away, and Tom advised me to hide the set, and come out with Aristeides. By this time the German units were concentrated round the city rather than in it, and we could run the intelligence centre from outside better than inside. So with a mixture of regret and relief, I decided to leave.

After that the Germans lingered on for another week.

They still had over a thousand men round the walls, with artillery on the line of withdrawal, ready to shell the town, so throughout the week we were mainly concerned to keep the peace between the bandit leaders and increase our own influence in the district by appearing in as many places as possible in uniform.

Then one night the Germans withdrew their main force west of Herakleion, leaving a rearguard round the aerodrome and about the city walls, and at dawn the bands began to close in after them, each eager to be the first into the town. They had possibly three or four hundred good rifles between them, but the Germans were still over a thousand men, with plenty of armoured cars, artillery, and mortars. Even if the bands had been united, a direct attack could only have led to a large-scale massacre of Cretans and the destruction of much of Herakleion, and of this the people of Herakleion and indeed most of the bands were shrewdly aware. So by tacit agreement any idea of a direct attack upon the Germans had been abandoned.

However, the lack of any blood-soaked climax was far from preventing the Herakleiots, ourselves, or the bands from celebrating the day with triumphant entries and victory rejoicings. I had spent the previous night somewhat depressingly with a small party of German deserters, who were now coming over regularly in two and threes, but at dawn, when we learnt of the German withdrawal, I hurried off to find Petrakogeorgis and make sure that he got into the town early. I found him seated in a captured German vehicle, with a broad and confident smile, chuckling behind the reddish beard tucked against his chest, and looking like some nineteenth-century South American general about to lead a revolution. After three years in the mountains he was clearly going to have his day and enjoy it. Behind him his second-in-command, a

dark handsome man, seated on a large and hefty nag, was turning for a last word with the men who, in a conscientious effort to change themselves from mountain guerillas into a regular relieving force, were drawn up and down the road in a somewhat shaggy column of fours. I could not help feeling that it might be glorious, but it was hardly war. Fortunately the German armoured cars were pulling back, and I knew that Petrakogeorgis could be trusted to keep to his allotted entry route. His men would maintain order in their sector of the town, and he was well aware that he had better arrive there as soon as any of the others. At this time we were anxious about the wilder bandits, who were wishing to capture collaborators and might well attack innocent people in the process.

After a few words with Petrakogeorgis I hurried off again to find my own wireless, which was now near the village of Mastamba, just south of the town. I had to send a message and wanted to learn if any news had come in that morning from Cairo, and from there I could follow up the Germans as closely as possible without being too much associated with one band rather than another. Also we still had some hopes of major desertions, if the Germans knew that allied officers were in evidence. I wanted too to show the townspeople that their allies were themselves taking a leading part in the "liberation", and to reassure them by our presence that there would be no breakdown in law and order once the Germans left. However, from then on, as will be seen, events took charge, and it became impossible for any one person amid the heaving melée of the crowds to give any real direction to what happened.

Near the wireless set I found Bill Royce and a large crowd converging on the New Gate, in front of which stood three German sentries ruefully eyeing a sea of blue and white Greek flags. In front of them again was a yet

larger crowd making no effort at all to conceal their delight that the Germans were leaving. They could easily have torn the sentries to pieces, but that would have meant in its turn a machine-gun massacre of themselves, and in any event their feeling about the Germans that day was more one of "Good riddance and good luck", than any thought of further strife to mar the rejoicings.

Bill and I being in grey army shirts and khaki slacks were hailed everywhere with astonished delight as the vanguard of the allied armies. For some minutes we were pushed around or slapped on the back and cheered in front of the Germans. Clearly neither side had much idea what to do next. Amid the general jollification it was unthinkable to shoot each other. On the other hand to fraternise, when we were still at war, seemed equally impossible, and would have caused much bitterness among our best friends in the villages. So for a time we and the Germans merely scowled at one another, whenever our eyes met, like people who are determined to cut each other with ostentatious rudeness—and then we withdrew to a friend's house round the corner and had lunch.

Meanwhile the crowd grew. The bands were now packed along all the main roads leading to the gates, except the westernmost through which the Germans would leave. The sentries had disappeared, and we walked again to the New Gate or rather were pushed through a lane that formed in front of us amid cheers, and flower-throwing, and spontaneous embracing on all sides. At the Gate itself the crowd opened out to disclose a large German armoured car. The lid of its conning tower was open and from it half a dozen Germans looked out, black and bewildered. Bill gave it a playful slap on the mudguard as we were swept past, and then we walked on into the town with tremendous cheering. The street was full and the balconies and houses seemed to be rocking in

front of us amid all the flag-waving, but at the end of the first street we reached an open space and found ourselves face to face with a German subaltern and about twenty men guarding a crossroads. By now Bill and myself had been pushed well in front of the crowd, and it clearly looks bad, if you wish to appear as a powerful ally and are being welcomed as a conquering hero, to turn tail and push back through a crowd which is urging you forward. So with inward anxiety we strode smilingly by.

At this point however a civilian car came slowly past us in the opposite direction; the main body of Germans were, we knew, in the main street just beyond, and if we went on, it seemed that sooner or later they must be goaded into shooting or capturing us, so, as though to rise above the crowd and give them a yet warmer greeting, we leapt on to the running-board waving cheerily and were carried back again to the New Gate, thereby making a discreet retreat. We found the armoured car still pointing a large gun at the crowd at two yards' range, but an invitation to desert which we passed to the sergeant was at once torn up angrily.

Shortly afterwards the armoured car withdrew, and I was amused to see Bodias, the communist leader, sway through the New Gate on a distinctly recalcitrant pony, which was tossing a heavy chain of flowers draped round its neck and understandably objecting to the cheers of a communist claque behind it. Perhaps it was this episode which induced the press at home to say that Major Houseman and Major Rendel had recaptured the town at the head of a band of devoted guerillas.

From now on the events of the day became even more crowded and confused. Bill went off to the aerodrome hoping to get in touch with the German commander, and persuade him to desert, and meanwhile I made my way to the Town Hall but found no one there. The crowd was

denser than ever, and shortly afterwards the German convoy came in from the aerodrome and drove down the main street through an avenue of waving Greek flags, to which allied flags had now been added.

To my astonishment I saw Bill Royce at the head of the column in one of the German cars riding side by side with the adjutant. He had found on reaching the aerodrome that the commander had already left and that there was no hope of desertions, and had agreed to ride through the town with them to lessen the chance of an incident.

At the Canea Gate the adjutant halted to let the column go by, and there I caught them up. His name was Capt. Achterling. He was already well known to me from various reports as an efficient officer and a good fellow. It seemed strange to meet him without indicating affably that I had heard a great deal about him already, but we got through the interview with frigid correctness. He asked me to release an officer who had gone astray that morning and had been taken prisoner, and that I refused.

Meanwhile a section of armoured cars had drawn up beside us at the rear of the column, and Capt. Achterling gave them final orders. For all the bathos of their departure it was diverting to see the armoured car commander's outraged expression, when he saw us beside Achterling. He was a tall, strong-looking young man; I remember noticing the skull and cross-bones badge of an armoured unit on his lapel, and the look of frustrated hatred which he gave me, as he saluted, clicked his heels, and got into his armoured car. A moment later Achterling drove through; the armoured cars were now closed down and as the last car swung through the Gate with the rear gun pointing momentarily at my chest, I had a split second's fear that that scowling subaltern might seize the opportunity to loose off a parting shot and blow us to smithereens. However, as anyone might have known, he stuck to

his orders to go quietly and a moment later we were all wildly cheering at the thought that the town was now free once more.

Soon after that one of the city fathers carried me off to uncork with pride a last cherished bottle of champagne. The rest of the evening and night was given up to the happiest mass rejoicing. I was carried round and round the main square by three young bandits whom I had never seen before. For once even politics were forgotten, and the bands by tacit consent dropped their rivalries throughout the hours of celebration. All that evening the city echoed to the rattle of bandit musketry fired into the air in pure high spirits.

At some stage that afternoon we were, too, borne away by various Herakleiot worthies for a thanksgiving in the cathedral. The intoning of modern church Greek I could not understand, but in any event it was an odd service. Outside we could still hear the echoes of the Germans' withdrawal, but although in the hills and villages we had always sworn vengefully one day to murder them, now that we had come face to face in the open nobody wanted to. We had come to give thanks, and indeed even for a Mediterranean city accustomed in peace to days of festival, the whole town seemed brimful of thankfulness, with everyone chanting, even shouting for joy.

Perhaps the effect of the champagne was wearing off. In any event, once we were inside the cathedral, I began to think to myself, in spite of the general jubilation, what the occupation had meant, and at once a crowd of more sombre thoughts came to mind—for, against the background of excitement and romance and amusement, which the bandit life had meant for most of the allied officers, it was, I knew, the sadder moments, that were more enduringly real and more essentially part of it.

Among them first and foremost comes into my mind always the recollection of the burnt-out villages—there were some forty utterly demolished in Crete alone—and with that the sight of the crosses along the skyline above the road to Rethymnon, where some twenty Cretans in reprisal for a senseless attack upon a German truck were shot and buried together. I thought, too, that afternoon in particular, of Perkins, who had had less luck than we over his ambush and whose body was still then thousands of feet above us in his first grave in the White Mountains. And since then I have coupled often with him an old Cretan peasant woman, who was brought to me after it was all over.

I had sent her son in to Canea and there, only a week or two before the last surrender, he was arrested and shot. He had left me with a smile, knowing gladly that he was trusted to carry out a dangerous job, and only a week or two later the old lady was led in to ask for the last news of him, when I knew that he was dead. I told her what news we had as best I could, while she looked silently before her, and I saw the tears running swiftly over the lined brown surface of her cheek—and then as she turned away, "Why did you let him go?" she said—and then quickly from the friend who had brought her in, "No, no, you mustn't say that." But I put my hand on her arm to comfort her, for I had no more to say, and if to reproach us could help her, at least I had no desire to avoid reproach.

Chapter Sixteen ♣

MOST people no doubt remember both the beginning and the end of the war clearly. For me it had two endings. The first took place a week or two after the Germans left Herakleion in October 1944, and was marked, as I always knew it would be, with intense relief. True, the war was still going on elsewhere, and there were ten thousand Germans still left in Crete and now closing into a perimeter round Canea at the western end of the island; but as the Germans withdrew westwards, the villagers in the east, where most of my travels had been, knew well that, whatever fighting there might yet be, the war for them was really over. Naturally I was longing to go back to my former haunts and hug some of our older cronies there, before the first joys of liberation wore off, and when the situation in Herakleion had begun to settle I managed to slip away to Lasithi.

The journey was both delightful and instructive. Already inklings had come to us that some of our best friends were in trouble with the communists, who were in control in some towns and villages. I little imagined that the communists would try to nobble us, and that when that failed, our visit would be interpreted as a subtle political move to undermine them. Unable to give notice in advance I motored one afternoon with Manoli Angelakis from Herakleion to Neapolis, with the sole purpose of rejoicing openly with our friends now that the hole-and-corner work was over.

As soon as we arrived in Neapolis, I could see that all was not well. The bishop was under house arrest for having preached anti-communist sermons, and we heard

that in Agios Nikolaos the left-wing leaders had locked up a number of their political opponents, some of whom had done us good service. Although I had at the time no wish to become involved in internal political squabbles, I sent word ahead that I hoped to meet the leaders, meaning to urge them to return to normal peaceable behaviour and release the prisoners. This was a stupid mistake.

At that time, although we did not know it, civil war was about to break out on the mainland. In Crete up to then there had arrived only some 150 British troops, who were widely scattered, but the Cretans believed that in the last resort physical control rested with us, and the political leaders were all convinced that the average voter would choose whatever party we backed. They would not believe that we wished to keep out of politics, and the left wing leaders, like all the others, wanted to show that in the areas where they were in control they had our support.

My message to Agios Nikolaos was therefore at once interpreted as an indication that I wanted to hob-nob with the left leaders, and unknown to me they prepared to receive us in style. From then onwards our movements were known in advance, and like other British officers all over Greece we were taken in tow wherever we went and were feted everywhere. The journey became in fact no less than eight crowded days of tumultuous, though hardly glorious, life, during which, although often drowsy with sheer fatigue, we were kept almost continuously awake on a monstrous miscellany of mass hysteria, politics, pork and cognac. We lived like royalty on tour. I had always thought that a king's job must be great fun—that it would, for instance, be delightful to know that by merely asking someone for a light, or recognising a face, you were creating a fund of human enjoyment. But I had not realised how conspicuous it feels or how constraining.

Meanwhile I had a day in which to thank our old friends and helpers in and around Neapolis. It was a time when even Greek extravagance seemed justified, and we were much too happy to meet again, with the Germans well across the horizon, to bother what we were saying to one another. Already the tales of narrow squeaks, surmounted by Odyssean cunning and effrontery, were becoming swollen and distended into the legend of battles long ago—but that was part of the fun of it.

It was as we reached the outskirts of Agios Nikolaos that the visit really assumed its regal character. We had by now been joined by Kosta Loubounes and a small party of our closest friends, and I was just recalling that on our right was a threshing floor, where I had spent the most flea-infested night of my whole sojourn in Crete, when the car in which we were jolting along was suddenly halted by four or five middle-aged citizens, looking obviously civic and representative, but waving excitedly. "Ah!" said one of my companions as if this was natural enough, "The deputation." He was right. The local leftwing leaders had in fact come out to drive us into the town, in order to demonstrate to the townspeople the British Government's approval of themselves.

Demurring slightly with some show of ineffective modesty, and with a growing realisation that we were about to be exploited for low-grade local purposes, I was soon ensconced beside the driver of the leading car, and we proceeded into the town through a lane of cheering Nikolaites, none of whom had seen an allied officer in uniform for four years. Greek spirits are nothing if not effervescent. Most of the crowd were sincerely delighted to welcome their allies back again, and the leftist politicos for their part had instructed their immediate followers to make as febrile and furious a fuss of us as they could.

I was naturally glad to return the crowd's greetings, but had to be careful all the time not to be photographed too smilingly side by side with the leftist leaders. The proceedings, therefore, became somewhat doublefaced. In the end, however, it was impossible to feel anxious about local politics as we proceeded down the main street amid screams and roars of delight, pelted with handfuls of autumn rose petals from the balconies by ladies of all ages, shapes and sizes. Alas! I have now had considerable experience of flower throwing and public embracing, and must recall a trifle wistfully that on these occasions it is the more aged and shapeless who show most dash and verve.

We passed amid pandemonium under a wobbling victory arch built of local evergreens, across which a broad streamer bore in charming if faulty English letters the two words"Well Come". This brought us to the market square, where I was presented by various youth organisations with enough bouquets to make it impossible to advance with any dignity. However Greeks, I knew, have little use for dignity on such occasions, preferring merely a sunny smile. Meanwhile two young ladies from the local high school were expressing their respect for Great Britain—one in careful Greek periods, the other in prize-giving English—and then smiling broadly Manoli and I, each clutching an armful of roses, tripped and stumbled to the town hall, taking as little notice as possible of a leftwing guard of honour, who were presenting a variety of irregular weapons each in his own sweet time.

Once on the balcony I had to be careful again. The crowd now filled the market square and had soon worked itself into a paroxysm of enthusiasm. Everyone seemed to be waving a flag. They were being harangued by a left-wing leader on the triumphs of the resistance movement in which the leftwingers and myself had played so glorious

a part. I was expected to confirm this as far as the Left were concerned. However, it was easy merely to thank them all, underline the blessings of unity, and say, which was the solid truth, that the townspeople who had helped us from their homes, had done a far riskier job than anyone in the hills.

Then there was more cheering, and speeches, a short and most acid meeting with the leftwing leaders in private, and a vast and indigestible feast of chunked pork before we slipped off to the car on the way to Ierapetra.

We had by now been met by Brigadier Karandinos, who had been head of the military side of the organisation there. As a leading Nationalist, he had been detained in a cave for eight days by the communists, but partly through Madame Karandinos' determined intervention, he had just been released, and he was evidently determined—justifiably—that if anyone escorted us into Ierapetra, he would.

By this time we knew, however, that the communists would try to stage a demonstration of unity with us, and in fact before we reached the town, a large crowd blocked the route cheering deliriously.

It was pleasant enough to feel that most of them were merely wishing to show their friendship for their allies, and let off some of the steam suppressed during the occupation; but I could not help feeling that royalty as they wave from their carriages must often think what a deplorable sight a hysterical crowd really is, and how passionately they must dislike the self-importance of the civic fathers who collar them in public.

Then the car came to a stop and before I knew what was happening several young men shouting "Long live the National Liberation Front"—a euphemism for the Communists—had hoisted Manoli Angelakis and myself shoulder high. Manoli burst out laughing. He had every

reason to be amused. A few months before we had walked into the town at twilight just before curfew, trying to look as inconspicuous as possible. I had had a long evening's discussion with Karandinos in the home of George Khaniotakis, to decide what the local patriots could do in the rear of the German shore emplacements, if Ierapetra was attacked from the sea, and we had met one communist, a shifty-eyed humid type, who had been no assistance before or since. Our return home borne aloft by the Left before the entire town was, therefore, in the first flush of excitement a cheerful contrast with our previous travels, though I myself had no time to be amused. I was determined not to let Karandinos be separated from me, and so was still grasping him by one hand. Karandinos was a short man, and some thirty years older than the youths who were carrying me, and who were only too keen to edge him off. It is not easy to be carried shoulder high holding on to someone a yard behind you. After the first few paces we advanced through the cheering like a horse with a rider who is falling off backwards. Meanwhile Manoli had taken the lead, but when he shouted back to me in Greek, I beat him to it as we swayed into the market square. His own squad, who had originally thought he was English, had stopped to dispute violently among themselves. Someone shouted that he was a Nationalist, whereupon as I sailed past, I chirped in loudly that he was an excellent fellow, a good patriot, and resistance fighter of long standing and just the right man to chair—which added nicely to the growing uncertainties—but by this time they had let Manoli down, and several of them were wearing the anxious look of one who has tried in vain to tread the party line.

Much to the disgust of the communists I slept that night with Karandinos, and next day we motored on to Siteia, where the local leaders were genuinely on our side.

This made the rest of the week a straightforward affair of the gayest jubilation and there was no reason why we should not heartily enjoy being the centre of it.

Two incidents stand out in my mind. In one of the smaller communities on the route the local leader of our embryo military organisation had asked me to be godfather to his grandchild. This was a compliment, which British officers in Crete often received, and I had been glad to accept it, as the mayor in question had stood by us loyally. As usual we were much delayed and although due at midday, we only arrived at the village about 7 p.m. Much to my consternation we found that there was to have been a wedding on the same day, but it had been decided (rightly enough), that we would like to see it, so the bride and bridegroom had been kept waiting until we arrived.

At once everyone hastened to the church, where we found them already waiting by the altar. We rattled through the service, which is administered in a Greek church something like the oath in a British court, with an exceptionally efficient matter-of-factness. Then we all trooped to yet another feast. The infant who was to be christened had, I was told, gone long since safely to sleep, so there was no hurry. Meanwhile I was asked to name it. I had been forewarned about this and was determined that in fact the parents should choose the name they wanted, but there was a lot of polite insistence at first that I should have the honour. The conversation went something like this:

Self. "Thank you very much, Mr. Mayor, but what would the child's mother like it to be named?"

Mayor: "We shall all be delighted with any name you choose, Mr. Alexis."

Self (noticing an anxious look on the features of a lady who appeared to be the mother): "Thank you very much

—but all the same I should much prefer that the mother and I should agree."

Mayor: "Really we should all prefer you to choose."

Self: "But I am no good at all at choosing a girl's name and the mother will know all about it."

A member of the mayor's party: "Please call it after the Queen of England."

Self: "But the Queen's name is Elizabeth. That is not at all an ordinary Greek name."

Another: "Then please, Mr. Alexis, call it after your own wife."

Self (with relief since this was easy): "But my wife is also called Elizabeth."

Another (with tiresome persistence): "Then why not name it after your own daughter?"

Self (truthfully and in triumph): "But my daughter is also called Elizabeth!" (Then realising that by sheer luck I was winning), "Excuse me but I think this lady is the mother. Would you please tell me, madam, what you would like the baby to be called?"

The mother (with quiet relief): "Maria, Mr. Alexis."

Self: "Good, I too like Maria very much."

Mayor (retrieving a bad business with real inspiration): "And Maria is also the name of the former queen of England."

Self and almost everyone else in chorus: "Beyond all doubt Maria it must be!"

It was now about midnight and the future Mary had been roused and was not unnaturally roaring her head off. I felt sorry for Mary. Splashing cold font-water over an Anglican baby's forehead is nothing to what a child of the orthodox Greek church has to endure, and on this occasion Mary having roared herself once more to sleep, was roused again to full tongue by an enthusiastic young male relative who, as we reached the threshold of the chapel,

in order to express his affection, exploded a hand-grenade. As far as I remember Mary, who had been encased in a thick chrysalis of swaddling clothes, was then completely unwound and held naked in front of the whole village, partly under the chin of the priest who, even for a Greek cleric, had a good-sized, black, and very tickly beard. He also carried through—with the utmost gusto—the ceremony of dabbing the infant's forehead, breast, and stomach with sacramental oil, but by this time Mary had sobbed herself again into a merciful comatose state only to be roused once more to a further terrified scream, when our exit from the chapel was again celebrated with a second hand-grenade.

After the christening four young villagers suddenly seized me aloft and we proceeded shakily to some sort of village hall, where I was cast on to the floor with appropriate shouts of "Long live England!"—after which the village sang and danced all night. I managed myself to slink away about 3.30, being by then utterly but happily exhausted. My last recollection was of the bride and bridegroom who were also inescapably a centrepiece of the revels, looking on gallantly but more and more wanly, as their wedding night ebbed away. They were a nice looking young couple, and I have always felt that I owed them the deepest apology, although I don't think village customs would have allowed them any privacy, even if my party had not chanced to be guests of the village just then.

The second incident which I most clearly remember took place at a small sunlit village in the eastern extremity of Crete; I had passed through it secretly some weeks before. Throughout the villagers had helped us with information and when I returned the second time, I knew that when the Germans had withdrawn the village had remained strongly nationalist and anglophile. I was able,

therefore, to thank them in sincerity, and they were genuinely happy to welcome us back, now that the occupation was over. This remote corner of Crete is not mountainous and on a calm sunny day with the sea never far away round three sides of it, it seems as utterly quiet and peaceful as any place on earth. It was a bright clear day, when we came over a hill in sight of the village. Below we could see the white-washed houses gleaming in the sunlight with the red tiles of the roofs as neat and bright as the illustrations in a fairy story. Up the mule-track towards us came running the village committee with our own trusted friends leading a tall white horse, on which I was swiftly and joyfully hoisted. Then with the church bells ringing fit to break, and with ropes of oranges and chains of flowers tumbling from the horse's mane, we advanced unsteadily down the flagged steps of the track and up the cobbled village street. This heroic entry on a white charger could only have appeared to any outsider as a parody. Yet why bother? The joyfulness was genuine enough. After all, the occupation was over and the war in this part of the world was over too. Four years of distrust, cross-questionings, torture sometimes, executions frequently, were now at an end, and for a little the village could cheer with their allies with a full prospect of peace and tranquillity and many another sunny day to come.

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The second and real ending of the war, however, occurred more grimly seven months later when the German commander in Canea, General Benthak, flew back to our headquarters in a Fieseler Storch to sign the surrender. We had been in touch with him through the bishop of Canea and the Swedish Red Cross. I had to receive him and his chief of staff on the aerodrome in the evening as the light was failing, so that no one should see him. We motored (his cap was removed for fear a Cretan

might recognise him and take a shot at it) to the Villa Ariadne, where the terms were read to him. He boggled at "unconditional surrender". Did that mean that one of the terms, for instance, might be that the commanders would be shot? If so, we could not expect him to sign it. He was told he must take it on trust. The paper was put in front of him at a table in a long room, that formerly had served as the sitting room for the students of the British School of Archaeology. Since then it had seen less scholarly and peaceful purposes. First it had been a British hospital and then a German headquarters—the General himself must often have dined there—and now it was filled with British and Greek senior officers. My brigadier had, at my special request, let me be present too. I wanted to see the liberation finally signed.

General Benthak was a tall square-built man. You could feel the tension in the darkened room, as he rose and sat under the arc lamp at the end of the table.

As he began to write, there was a click and a whirr. One of the officers was filming the signature with a cine-camera. The pen paused for a moment, and then he wrote on stolidly as if nothing mattered, and got up stiffly with his head still bent. I think someone said "Thank you"—as if he had been signing a cheque for the mess. It seemed too smug, even for all of us too humiliating a scene to give any sense of victory or triumph or enjoyment. All the same to see the surrender actually signed made a clean break between peace and war and wrote beneath the months that were now past, an authentic FINIS